

THE FINAL WAR

A Three-Part Cinematic Event

Film One: The Ambush and the Forging
Film Two: The Call — Shadow Knowledge
Film Three: All Heroes Rise

"From one weakness was born infinite power."

For Seiko Toast.
The best friend anyone ever had.

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The Perfect Joseph and Gumball:
The Multiversal Saga

FILM ONE

THE AMBUSH AND THE FORGING

Target Runtime: 115 Minutes

FADE IN:

INT. THE OUTER DARK — EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN — NIGHT

BLACK. Not the absence of light. The presence of something that has made darkness its preferred architecture. Something that chose it long ago and has not reconsidered.

A CHANDELIER hangs in the void between dimensions. Three hundred crystal drops, each one refracting light that originates from within — not from any external source. The chandelier is its own sun. Small. Perfect. Controlled.

Below it: a long mahogany table. Eighteen feet. Seats for twenty-four. Currently set for one. The place setting is exact to the millimeter. A single wine glass, crystal, stem precisely centered on a white linen cloth that has been ironed with more care than most people give to anything.

The meal has been finished. The plates have been cleared. Only the wine glass remains, and the man who holds it.

JEFFREY EPSTEIN (BILL SKARSGARD) sits at the head of the table. He is perhaps fifty. He holds the wine glass by the stem, turning it slowly — a fraction of a degree at a time, in increments so small they are almost not increments at all. A man conducting a private experiment in the patience of things.

He has never, in his entire life, needed to hurry. This is visible in every part of him — the set of his shoulders, which carry no tension whatsoever; the angle of his neck, which suggests comfort so complete it has become invisible; the way his eyes move across the room with the measured patience of someone who understood, very early, that the world would come to him. That there was no need

to go to the world.

He watches a prism of light cross the tablecloth. The prism moves with the rotation of the chandelier – a rotation so slow that you can only perceive it by watching the prism travel, which Epstein has been doing for eleven minutes. He knows exactly how long it will take to reach the far end of the table. He has timed it. He times everything.

He times everything because time is the one resource that has limits, and Epstein is a man who respects limits the way other people respect gravity – not because he can't push against them, but because understanding them is the first step to working within them more effectively than anyone else.

EPSTEIN

When I was twenty-three, I sat across from a man who ran three governments and didn't know it. He had created the conditions that allowed three separate governments to operate according to his preferences, through a sequence of financial decisions made over a period of nine years, and he had done it so gradually that no single decision ever looked like what it was. He had forgotten, by the time I met him, that he'd done it at all. It had become background. Normal.

He sets the glass down precisely where it was before he picked it up. He doesn't check. He knows.

EPSTEIN (continuing)

He was eating a tuna sandwich.
Paper napkin tucked into his collar. A man who had shaped the policy of nations, sitting in a diner in midtown, eating a tuna

sandwich with mayonnaise that had
come from a jar.

The prism reaches the midpoint of the
table. Exactly when
he predicted.

EPSTEIN

(a pause; the prism moving)
And I thought: this is what power
looks like when it doesn't know
it's power. When it hasn't
examined itself. When it sits in a
diner and thinks it's just having
lunch. When the thing it has built
has grown so far beyond the
builder that the builder can no
longer see the edges of it.

EPSTEIN

(continuing)

I resolved, at twenty-three, to be
the other kind. The kind that sees
the edges. The kind that builds
something and then builds
something around that, and then
something around that, so that no
matter where you stand, you are
standing inside something you
designed.

A sound from the far end of the room.
The specific
signature of a portal opening – not
from inside this
dimension but from the boundary of it.
A careful,
announced entry. The kind of entrance
that has been
designed to be recognized as careful
and announced.

Epstein doesn't turn.

EPSTEIN

Six minutes early, Kronos.

INT. THE OUTER DARK — CONTINUOUS

KRONOS (GIANCARLO ESPOSITO) steps through the sealed portal with the unhurried precision of someone who has had longer to practice unhurried precision than almost anyone alive. He wears a dark suit of no particular era. He has been wearing dark suits of no particular era for longer than suits have had eras.

He exists at a slightly different speed than the rest of the world — not faster, not slower, but at a tempo that is measurably, visibly his own. The specific tempo of a man who has more time than he needs and has learned to be deliberate with its use.

He closes the portal behind him. He crosses the room. His footsteps make no sound on the floor because Epstein prefers a room in which he is the only source of sound.

KRONOS

The dimensional streams are accelerating. The Convergence is forty-eight hours ahead of the projected schedule. The cascade is propagating faster than the initial models indicated — the fracture lines are taking energy from adjacent dimensions as they complete, which is feeding the next fractures. An autocatalytic effect.

EPSTEIN

I know.

KRONOS

Seventeen hero factions have

confirmed mobilization in the last six hours. The al-Mithali team is coordinating. The signal they sent – broad-spectrum, all available dimensional channels – has been received and responded to by entities in forty-three separate dimensions.

EPSTEIN

I know.

KRONOS

Forty-seven confirmed responses in the first two hours. The count is still rising.

EPSTEIN

I know the count, Kronos. I've been watching the responses as they arrive. Some of them are interesting.

KRONOS

Interesting.

EPSTEIN

Two signatures that don't match anything in our catalogue. I've had the analysis team working on them for three hours. They haven't been able to identify the dimensional origin point. The signatures appear to exist outside any dimensional framework we've mapped.

Kronos is quiet for a moment.

KRONOS

Outside any framework we've mapped. That's – significant.

EPSTEIN

Yes. I find it interesting. I don't find it concerning. There is a difference.

He stands. Unhurried. He moves to the void-window – a section of wall that has been made transparent to the space beyond this dimension. Outside: infinite dimensional space. Galaxies scattered like grain across the dark. Universes stacked on universes, each one a variation on the theme of existence, each one connected to every other by the architecture Epstein has spent his life mapping and intends to spend the rest of it controlling.

EPSTEIN

(at the window)

Al-Mithali always coordinates. That is his nature. He believes in consensus because he was raised to believe that the way forward is through agreement – through finding the shared interest and building from it. He has never been in a position where the shared interest was not sufficient. Where the thing he needed required more than consensus could provide.

EPSTEIN

(a pause)

That is about to change.

EPSTEIN

(continuing)

Let them gather. Let them be magnificent. Forty-three dimensions, responding to his signal, bringing their best. Let them assemble the most extraordinary force that has ever existed in any single place in the multiverse. Let them feel, in that assembly, that they have already won.

EPSTEIN

And then let them find out what they're actually fighting.

He turns. He looks at Kronos with the expression of a chess player who has been playing multiple games simultaneously and has reached the point where all the games are going the same way.

EPSTEIN

Accelerate to twenty-four hours.
Not forty-eight. Not thirty-six.
Twenty-four hours from this
moment.

KRONOS

The cost to the temporal buffer
will be significant. We lose the
safety margin.

EPSTEIN

The safety margin was designed for a scenario in which we might need to abort. We are not going to abort.

KRONOS

If something goes wrong –

EPSTEIN

Kronos. What could go wrong?

Kronos looks at him. At the void-window. At the infinite space beyond it.

KRONOS

I have been with you long enough to know that that question has always, eventually, received an answer.

A pause. Epstein looks at him.

EPSTEIN

Yes. You have been with me long enough. And in all that time – in everything we have built, in every calculation that seemed impossible and turned out to be merely difficult – have I been wrong about the fundamental structure of the plan?

KRONOS

No.

EPSTEIN

Then twenty-four hours.

KRONOS

Twenty-four hours.

He opens a portal. Steps through. The portal seals.

Epstein turns back to the void-window. He picks up his wine glass — he has carried it with him without noticing, the way some people carry a phone. He holds it up to the chandelier. He looks through the crystal at the darkness beyond.

The prism on the tablecloth has nearly reached the far edge. He watches it travel the last few centimeters.

EPSTEIN

(to himself; to the universe that has always done exactly what he expected; to the tablecloth as the prism reaches the edge and disappears)

Twenty-four hours.

He sets the glass down. He walks into the deeper darkness. Not dramatically. The way a man walks when walking is simply what the next moment requires.

The chandelier turns. Very slowly. The prism is gone.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. THE VOID — BETWEEN DIMENSIONS — INFINITE

A single Arabic oud, barely audible. Minor key. No reverb. No room sound. Someone playing alone in a space that has no walls, no ceiling, no reference points. The kind of music that happens when no audience is expected and so the player is only accountable to the truth of the notes.

ABSOLUTE DARKNESS.

Then — a hairline crack. A thread of golden light in the black. The width of a human hair. The color of something that has been waiting a very long time to be let out — not trapped, but patient. Aware that its moment would come. The light of things that have been growing in the dark toward nothing in particular because the growing is the point.

Slow push in. The camera moving through the dark the way thought moves through a mind that has already decided and is simply waiting for the rest of the body to catch up. There is no hurry. The hurry has been resolved. What remains is the approach.

Villeneuve-scale — forty-five seconds of controlled movement, every second earning the next, the darkness giving way not because it has been defeated but because something worth giving way to has arrived.

The crack widens. Not violently. Not triumphantly. The way a door opens when someone who has been traveling a long time finally finds the handle and doesn't need to force it because the door was never locked. It was only closed.

Through the crack: the suggestion of SOMEWHERE. Blue sky. An atmosphere. The faint shimmer of a dimension on the other side of this darkness — a place where things have weight and weather and the specific quality of existing in time rather than between it.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

My mother had a ficus on the
kitchen windowsill. She watered it
on Thursdays. Every Thursday,
without exception, for as long as

I can remember. I am thirty-one years old and I cannot remember a time when Thursday did not mean my mother standing at the windowsill with a watering can that was slightly too large for the purpose, pouring water into a pot that was slightly too small for the plant.

The crack widens. The golden light fills more of the frame. More of the darkness becomes visible as what it is – not the end of things, but the space before them.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

She watered it on Thursdays because she had decided, at some point before I was born, that the plant needed Thursdays. Not the water – the Thursdays. She told me this once when I was perhaps eight years old and asked her why she didn't just water it when the soil was dry. She said: because the plant doesn't need water on Thursdays. The plant needs someone who notices it on Thursdays. The water is secondary.

A beat. The oud holds a single note. The note breathes. The darkness breathes with it.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

I thought about this for a long time. About what it means to be noticed on a schedule. About what it does to something – a plant, a person, a relationship, a world – to know that someone has set aside a specific time for it. Not

because it asked. Not because it was convenient. Because the someone decided it mattered enough to be scheduled.

The golden crack begins to widen significantly. Not a crack anymore – a gap. A passage.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

It was not a beautiful plant. It had always been slightly too large for its pot – the roots pressing against the walls, the branches extending past the edges of the windowsill, always threatening to knock something over and never quite doing it. My mother never repotted it. For years I thought that was stubbornness. Her specific stubbornness, which was considerable and which I have inherited to a degree I'm still mapping.

The golden crack SNAPS WIDE.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

I understand now that it was faith. Faith that the thing inside the pot, even when it seemed wrong, even when the roots pressed against the walls and there was no room left for growth in the obvious direction, was still growing. Still finding its way toward what it needed. The pot was not the point. The growing was the point. The Thursday was the point.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. AN UNNAMED DIMENSION — FOREST EDGE — DAY

A FOREST of bruised purple and silver. Trees whose bark has the faint iridescence of oil on water. The light falls at angles that no sun in any conventional solar system produces. Two shadows for every object, pointing in different directions, both equally dark.

The air smells of rain that hasn't fallen yet and won't fall here — the dimensional bleed of a weather system from somewhere adjacent, its atmospheric signature crossing the membrane while the rain itself does not.

The PORTAL hovers in a clearing. Amber. Pulsing with the specific rhythm of a stable transit window that is, like all transit windows, not stable forever.

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI stands at the edge of the clearing, hands at his sides, watching the portal. He is late twenties, Moroccan-American. He has a stillness to him that reads as compressed rather than peaceful — a man who has learned to hold a great deal in a small amount of visible space. A man who has trained himself, over time, to express only what needs to be expressed, and to hold everything else at a level just below expression, where it is available but not visible.

He has dark circles under his eyes. He has been in this dimension for four days, sleeping in increments of three hours because three hours is the maximum the dimensional transit window will allow before requiring recalibration. He is, by any objective measure, exhausted. He does not look exhausted. He has decided not to.

Behind him, his team:

SEIKO TOAST stands precisely two meters back from Joseph's position — close enough to respond instantly, far enough to give Joseph the space Joseph always needs. He is 27, Japanese-American, and his spine is always precisely straight in the way of someone who learned early that posture is a form of preparation. He holds a tablet in one hand and a styrofoam cup of tea in the other.

The styrofoam cup is SEIKO'S specific comfort object in field situations. He has carried some version of this cup — always styrofoam, always tea, always at a temperature

that started too hot and is now approaching optimal – across more dimensional transits than either of them has counted. The cup is a signal: Seiko has achieved a sufficient level of situational control to permit the comfort object. The cup is also, and this is important, a way of having something to hold.

YARA GORDON reads the geometry of portals the way other people read road signs – automatically, efficiently, without needing to think about it. She is the daughter of a dimensional cartographer. She grew up with portal maps on the kitchen walls instead of pictures. She knows the shape of a stable transit window the way she knows the shape of her own hands.

The portal pulses. Joseph takes a step toward it.

SEIKO

Stable window. Thirty-two seconds before the fracture layer shifts. Once it shifts, the transit signature inverts and we come out twelve degrees off-vector on the other side. We've been through that calculation. It puts us in the middle of the–

JOSEPH

I know.

SEIKO

I know you know. I'm saying it because saying it is part of my process.

JOSEPH

Twenty-four seconds.

SEIKO

Twenty-three now.

YARA

Twenty-two.

Joseph doesn't move. He looks at the
portal the way you
look at home when you've been away a
long time and aren't
entirely certain what you'll find when
you arrive – not
afraid of what's there, but aware that
it might have
changed in your absence, and that
change is not always
what you expected and is sometimes not
what you wanted.

SEIKO

Joseph.

JOSEPH

I know.

YARA

Eighteen seconds.

SEIKO

Sixteen.

Joseph moves.

And then – from somewhere above the
frame – a SOUND.

Air displaced at velocity by something
very large moving
very fast. Not a vehicle, not a
natural phenomenon.
Something that chose to move this way.
Something that has

always moved this way and has never
had reason to choose
otherwise.

SOUND DESIGN: Sub-bass at 40Hz, rising
steadily in pitch
as the object decelerates through the
final thousand
meters of approach — a controlled
deceleration, the kind
that happens when something very
powerful decides how fast
it wants to be moving when it arrives.
A percussive crack
as it crosses the sound barrier. No
music. Just physics
presenting itself.

Joseph stops mid-step. He turns.

HOMELANDER (ANTONY STARR) descends vertically from above
the treeline. Red and gold. The cape catches the purple
light of this dimension the way material catches light
when it was made in a different dimension with different
physics and is experiencing what happens when the rules
are slightly different here. He lands thirty feet away
from Joseph with the controlled violence of someone who
has never had to be careful about landing and has never
developed the habit. The ground compresses. The grass
flattens in a perfect circle. Some of the dimensional
flora, which is not used to this kind of impact, makes a
sound that suggests it was not prepared.

He looks at Joseph with the expression he uses when he
expects to be disappointed and has arranged to enjoy it —
the expression of a man who has spent a long time in the
position of having expectations, and a long time having
them confirmed, and has arrived at a place where
confirmation itself has become the satisfaction.

Behind him: THREE FIGURES.

ONE: A woman in dark tactical gear, hands already moving
in patterns that bend probability. Not gesturing —
working. The specific, precise movements of someone
editing the mathematics of what is likely to happen next.
She doesn't look at what she's doing. She looks at Joseph.

This is the most frightening thing about her.

TWO: A man whose augmentation has progressed past the point where the human architecture is the primary architecture. Enhancement nodes visible through his skin, pulsing in time with something that is not his heartbeat. He doesn't breathe visibly. He may not breathe.

THREE: A figure who simply stands still. In a combat situation, absolute stillness is either the sign of someone who has given up or someone who has already, in some meaningful sense, won. This person has not given up.

HOMELANDER

I heard you found a door home.
Word travels in this dimension.
Things echo. I've found that
things echo especially loudly when
somebody really wants to go home
and has done something dramatic to
make it happen.

JOSEPH

It's not a door if they won't let
you through it.

HOMELANDER

Ah. So it's more of a wall.

JOSEPH

More of a conversation.

HOMELANDER

I love conversations.

JOSEPH

I know.

Homelander's eyes move. Not dramatically — the controlled movement of someone who is looking for something specific and will not stop until he finds it. His eyes travel across the team. They land on RYAN.

Ryan is sixteen. He has positioned himself at the back of the group, which was a tactical decision and also not. He is trying to project calm, which is the bravest performance being given anywhere in any dimension at this moment — not because the calm is unconvincing but because of how clearly visible the effort is, to anyone who is looking for it.

Homelander is looking for it.

Something moves through his face. Something that arrived without permission and doesn't know how to leave. Something that is not the expression of a man who has arranged his feelings. Something that is the feeling.

HOMELANDER

(to himself; the volume of something that wasn't meant to be said aloud but said itself anyway)

He's here.

The PROBABILITY MANIPULATOR raises her hands. The air around the group bends — not visibly, not dramatically, in the way that would announce itself and allow preparation.

In the way that air bends when the
mathematics of reality
are being revised at a level too
fundamental for the
senses to detect before the revision
is already happening.

SEIKO

Probability cascade – Joseph, the
field is –

THE HIT LANDS.

Everything at once. The probability
wave strikes the team
in ways that physics, in its
conventional formulation,
does not permit. The air becomes
adversarial. Gravity
negotiates new terms. Joseph goes down
hard – cheek
against purple soil, hands flat, the
impact distributed
across a body that has been trained to
absorb impacts and
is absorbing this one.

Seiko drops behind a tree, the tablet
shattered on impact,
backup device already in his other
hand because Seiko has
always had a backup device. The backup
device's screen
shows three numbers that are rapidly
becoming four. He
begins recalculating.

Yara SEIZES the portal with both
hands. She doesn't grab
it – you can't grab a portal. She
establishes relationship
with it, her body and the portal
finding the specific
resonance that means it will stay open
while she holds

that resonance. Her arms are extended wide. Her face: strain, but below the strain, control. She has held harder things.

Joseph lies still for exactly three seconds.

Three seconds of assessment. Three seconds of reading the situation with his eyes open and the specific quality of attention he has trained himself to produce under exactly these circumstances – the attention of someone who has resolved not to panic and has, through sufficient practice, kept that resolution.

MUSIC: A single low brass note. 58Hz – the specific frequency at which a significant decision registers in the body before the mind has finished making it. Arabic strings enter on the second measure. Not swelling. Not triumphant. Waiting, the way good music waits when it knows something is about to happen and has decided to let the thing happen before it responds.

Joseph opens his eyes.

INSERT: HIS POV – TACTICAL:

Ryan, twenty feet away, holding the AUGMENTED OPERATIVE with everything he has. The hold is not winning. It is not losing. It is the hold of someone who has decided that winning and losing are secondary to not stopping.

Yara, arms wide, the amber portal shimmering in her grip. Her face: strain, but below it, control. She has held harder things.

Seiko, behind a tree, three screens running on the backup device. He is, even now, running calculations. He cannot stop running calculations any more than his heart can stop beating. These are the same function.

Homelander. Circling. Not engaging. Looking at Ryan with an expression that has nothing in it of strategy.

END INSERT.

Joseph gets up.

He gets up the way someone gets up when getting up is a reflex so old it no longer requires thought, only execution. Not dramatically. Not with effort that shows. He simply returns to vertical because that is what vertical is for.

JOSEPH

Homelander.

Not loud. Not commanding. The specific quality of a voice that has decided exactly what it is going to say and will not be moved from saying it.

Everyone stops. Not because he commanded them to stop. Because there is something in the quality of the silence before the word that functions as a pause button for the room – for the clearing, for this dimension, for the specific mathematics of what is happening here.

JOSEPH
(continuing)

Your son is here. He made a choice four days ago. He had you at his mercy – had the opportunity to do what most people in his position would have done, would have felt justified in doing. He chose differently.

JOSEPH

That was his choice. Not mine. Not yours. His.

He looks at Homelander with the directness of someone who has nothing to hide and has stopped pretending otherwise.

JOSEPH

You can fight me. I will fight you back, and that fight will be real, and at the end of it we will have done exactly what Jeffrey Epstein needs us to do. We will have removed ourselves from the equation at the moment he needs us removed. Or — you can ask your son what he chose. And why.

A long moment. Long enough to be a demonstration.

Homelander stops circling. He looks at Joseph. He looks at Ryan.

Something in his face that is not calculation. Not strategy. Something older and less organized — the thing underneath the performance that the performance was designed to cover, which has always been there and which shows, now, because there is no longer quite enough performance left to cover it.

RYAN

(before anyone tells him to; not loudly; with the clarity of someone who has rehearsed a sentence many times but is saying it for the first time)

I chose not to carry it.

Homelander looks at his son. Ryan is sixteen and standing very straight and not shaking — the stillness that sometimes means the opposite of calm.

RYAN

Not because you deserved mercy. I don't know if you deserved mercy. I don't know how to calculate that, and I tried. I thought about it for a long time.

A pause. He holds Homelander's gaze.

RYAN

I chose not to carry it because I didn't want what killing you would do to me. That's the difference. That's the only thing I know with certainty.

Silence.

Homelander stands in it. An uncomfortable, enormous silence that he has no idea what to do with. He is a man who fills silences. Who fills rooms. Who fills whatever space he's in with the specific frequency of his presence. He does not know how to stand in a silence that has something in it that is not about him and that he cannot change by being present in it.

HOMELANDER

(genuinely asking; not performing the question; asking it)

Is there actually a difference?

JOSEPH

A significant one.

HOMELANDER

You sound certain.

JOSEPH

HOMELANDER

I am.

How?

JOSEPH

Because of what I carry. And what it weighs. And what I would give to have made different choices about some of it.

Homelander looks at him for a long time. The assessment of a man who is deciding whether to believe something he has not believed before.

The PROBABILITY MANIPULATOR has been watching this. She knows what a situation looks like when its strategic value has passed. She also knows what she signed up for and what she didn't.

PROBABILITY MANIPULATOR

I'm standing down. I didn't sign up to die for a conversation that's going to end the same way whether I'm here or not.

She lowers her hands. The distortion collapses. Air normalizes. Physics returns to its preferred settings.

Joseph raises one hand. A focused PULSE — precise,

minimal, surgical. The enhancement nodes running through the AUGMENTED OPERATIVE deactivate in sequence, each one losing its charge as the pulse finds it. The operative folds. Contained. Not damaged.

THE STILL FIGURE looks at Joseph. Looks at Homelander. Turns and walks away. Just walks away. This is either defeat or strategic withdrawal and may be both.

Joseph turns back to Homelander.

JOSEPH

What happens to you now. You go home, or you stay here, or you go somewhere else. But we're finished fighting. Whatever you decide next, it's not this.

Homelander looks at Ryan one more time.

It is the look of someone trying to say something they have never had the language for. Not trying and failing — trying and discovering, in the trying, that the language was never going to be available. That the thing they wanted to say is the kind of thing that does not have words because it has never needed words before. Because it was always supposed to be shown, not said, and it was not shown, and now it is too late for showing and still too early for anything else.

He turns. He flies north. Not dramatically. Not with a speech. He simply returns to the air, which is where he lives, and goes.

Ryan watches the space where his father was. Five full

seconds. He picks up his bag from
where it fell in the
probability cascade.

RYAN

I still want to help. If you'll
still have me.

Joseph looks at him. At sixteen-year-
old Ryan who made a
choice that cost him something real
and is living,
already, in the specific peace that
comes from having paid
a cost and found that it was worth the
price.

JOSEPH

Yes. Come on.

They move toward the portal. Yara
releases it. The amber
light deepens and then contracts and
then they are all
through and the forest is empty and
the dimension goes
back to being what it was before any
of this happened.

MUSIC: The Arabic strings lift one
octave. Not resolution
— suggestion. The promise that
resolution is possible.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 — CANYON SYSTEM — LATE AFTERNOON

IMAX-wide. Geological columns of stone veined with
materials that have no business being in stone. Threads of
silver-white running through the canyon walls like the
capillaries of something enormous. Striations of deep blue

where Beskar has been forming in crystalline layers for centuries, unobserved and undisturbed and accumulating in the specific way of things that have nowhere else to be.

And the gold. Deposits of it threaded through every layer, not gold in the conventional sense – not the gold that moves through financial systems and sits in vaults and has been assigned a number – but the Weezy Gold: dimensional mineral, native to this specific earth, native in the way that nothing else in any other dimension is native, which means it cannot be found anywhere else and therefore cannot be catalogued by anyone who hasn't found it here.

The light is gold filtered through two thousand years of dimensional overflow. Photons from adjacent dimensions, having crossed the membrane and lost most of their original energy in the crossing, settling here and becoming something new. The light of this canyon is borrowed from everywhere and belongs to nowhere.

A faint high-frequency resonance in the air. The specific sound of dimensional materials that have been accumulating charge for centuries, a sound below the threshold of deliberate hearing but above the threshold of feeling. You don't hear it. You feel it in your back teeth, gently, the way you feel the presence of something significant before you identify what it is.

Joseph and Seiko walk the canyon floor. Seiko has a new tablet – pulled from a supply pack during transit, unwrapped and operational within eleven seconds. He is already working.

SEIKO

The Vibranium lattice is confirmed present in the south canyon wall – concentration levels sufficient for the base structure with twelve percent margin. The Nth Metal seepage from the north wall is consistent with the survey projections. The Beskar crystalline deposits are accessible but will require extraction rather than surface

collection.

JOSEPH

How long for extraction?

SEIKO

Depends on equipment. With what we have — and what's already here — two days. With additional support, less.

JOSEPH

The Weezy Gold?

SEIKO

Native. Which means not catalogued anywhere in Epstein's system. Which means the frequency it generates is outside his models entirely. If the binding agent works the way the analysis suggests —

If.

JOSEPH

SEIKO

The theoretical margin of confidence is ninety-three point six percent. Ninety-three point six is not 'if'. It is 'almost certainly'. I use 'if' only because the remaining six point four percent is not zero and I prefer precision.

JOSEPH

Fair enough.

SEIKO

Yes. It is.

They walk in silence for a moment. The
canyon around them.
The dimensional gold in the stone.

JOSEPH

Seiko. The signal you sent.

Yes.

SEIKO

JOSEPH

Who could receive it?

SEIKO

I designed it as broadly as I
could while maintaining
dimensional coherence. The
structural frequency pulse should
be receivable by anyone with
specific interdimensional
sensitivity – anyone who works
with these materials, anyone who
has spent significant time in
dimensional transit, anyone with
the right kind of attunement.

JOSEPH

That's a wide net.

SEIKO

Yes. I cast it as wide as I could

and then I let it go. That's all a signal can do. Be sent and hope it finds what it's looking for.

Joseph looks at the canyon. At the extraordinary material wealth of a place that has been accumulating for millennia without anyone coming to claim it.

JOSEPH

Then we wait and see who comes.

SEIKO

That's the plan.

JOSEPH

You're comfortable with that plan?

SEIKO

I have thirty-seven backup plans. None of them require us to be comfortable with the primary plan. We simply need the primary plan to work.

JOSEPH

And if it doesn't?

SEIKO

Then we move to backup plan two. Or seventeen. I'm flexible.

Joseph looks at him.

SEIKO

(clarifying)

In the sense that I have prepared
for many contingencies. Not in the
sense that I experience
flexibility as a positive state.

JOSEPH

I know.

SEIKO

I know you know.

CUT TO:

INT. EARTH-2397 - CAVE ENTRANCE - WALTER'S FACILITY - DAY

The cave opening is unassuming. A slit in the canyon wall, partially obscured by dimensional undergrowth, requiring a specific approach angle to see. This is deliberate.

WALTER WHITE (BRYAN CRANSTON) stands at the entrance. He has been working in this facility for four months. He has developed the specific relationship with solitude that productive people develop when they are given a problem worth having and sufficient resources to attack it: he has forgotten to be lonely because the problem has been company enough.

He wears a practical jacket over a work shirt. He has not shaved in three days, not because he has forgotten but because shaving is not currently in the critical path. He looks like a man who has found the right problem after a very long time of finding the wrong ones.

He looks at Joseph. He looks at Seiko. He looks at the carrying case with the Weezy Gold sample.

WALTER

(a dry acknowledgment; at the container)

I assumed.

JOSEPH

The Weezy Gold. From the main deposit.

WALTER

Yes. I can see that from the spectral signature. The color is distinctive at this purity.

JOSEPH

You've modeled the binding?

WALTER

For six weeks. The theoretical properties suggest a binding stability that is — I want to be precise here — not additive. Not even multiplicative in the conventional sense. The Weezy Gold at this purity appears to enable a form of coherence in the alloy that I don't have adequate language for.

JOSEPH

Adequate language being one of your standards.

WALTER

It is my primary standard. I don't say things I can't say correctly.

He turns and walks back toward the facility. Not waiting.
The people worth following follow.

They follow.

INT. EARTH-2397 - WALTER'S FACILITY - CONTINUOUS

The facility: extraordinary. A cave transformed by four months of systematic work into a precision laboratory and metallurgical space. Workstations built from materials available in this dimension plus equipment brought through dimensional transit in carefully packed cases. Temperature management systems. Ventilation designed to handle the specific outgassing of dimensional-reactive materials - a problem Walter identified in the first week and solved by the second.

Everything is organized with the logic of a mind that cannot function in a space that has not been optimized. There is a place for everything. Everything is in its place. The places are not random - they are the result of weeks of iterative positioning, moving things until the workflow was correct, and then leaving them there.

JESSE PINKMAN is at a workstation in the back, calibrating a thermal monitoring unit with the focused attention of someone who has learned the hard way what happens when thermal monitoring units are not calibrated correctly. He is wearing protective equipment. He has gotten much better about wearing protective equipment.

JESSE

That the Gold?

Yes.

WALTER

JESSE

Cool. Is it as pure as you needed?

WALTER

We'll see.

He sets up the Weezy Gold container in a sealed examination chamber. He runs the scanner slowly, checking purity, dimensional charge, any instability in the

molecular lattice. He takes his time. He always takes his time when taking time is possible.

The scanner reads back. Walter looks at the numbers. He looks at them again. He runs the scan a second time with a different instrument.

WALTER

(very quietly; to himself first)

Ninety-six point two.

SEIKO

Confirmed by our field analysis.

WALTER

The theoretical model assumed purity in the range of eighty to eighty-five percent. Ninety-six point two is not in the range of eighty to eighty-five percent.

JOSEPH

Is that a problem?

WALTER

It is the opposite of a problem. It changes everything I modeled. At ninety-six point two, the binding isn't additive. The layers don't just hold together. They — communicate.

SEIKO

Communicate.

WALTER

A pause.

In the metallurgical sense. Each layer becomes structurally aware of every other layer. They function as a unified field rather than a composite structure. The failure modes I modeled — all of them — disappear at this purity level because failure requires the layers to disagree, and at ninety-six point two they can't disagree. They're the same thing.

JOSEPH

In practical terms?

WALTER

In practical terms — what we build with this will not fail under any dimensional pressure I can model. And I have been modeling dimensional pressure for four months with very good equipment.

JESSE

So we're good?

WALTER

We're better than good, Jesse.
We're correct.

He looks at the container with the specific reverence of a man who has spent his career being the most rigorous person in any room and has just encountered something more rigorous than himself.

WALTER

(quietly)

We can begin.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 - CANYON SYSTEM - THE ARRIVALS - DAY

The sun has moved. Hours have passed. Walter has established the preliminary forge structure in the canyon — a cathedral assembled from first principles, functional before beautiful. Joseph has been assisting with the thermal layout. Seiko has been running calculations that account for every material they expect and several they haven't received yet.

And then the arrivals begin.

ONE.

A BLUE STREAK from the east, moving at a velocity that renders the canyon walls as impressionist suggestions of themselves — all color and direction and no detail. SONIC decelerates in the final fifty meters: a visible CONE of displaced air preceding him, a compressed wave of physics obeying the physics of deceleration. He stops in the exact position that Walter's slightly extended hand indicates before the hand is fully extended.

He is carrying, organized in dimensional-stable packing, a quantity of NTH METAL that represents what he could carry at maximum velocity over the maximum distance he could cover in the time since he received the signal.

SONIC

I received the signal thirty-seven hours ago. I've been gathering since then. I believe this is the maximum Nth Metal available from the nearest source deposit without beginning to impact the structural integrity of the deposit itself. I left enough for natural regeneration.

WALTER

(without looking up; already examining the material)

This is precisely what was required. The reserve you've maintained in the deposit is appropriate. Thank you.

SONIC

You're welcome. Where do you need me?

WALTER

Here. For now. I'll tell you when I need your specific capabilities.

Sonic takes a position and holds it. This is also what he's good at.

TWO.

ANNIE STARLIGHT arrives from the southwest. She is walking, not flying. She has been on Earth-2397 for six

months – longer than anyone else who
will arrive today.
She found this place before the signal
existed. She knew
someone was coming the way you know a
storm is coming:
from the quality of the air and the
behavior of the light
and the specific weight of
expectation.

She has been gathering for six months.
What she sets down
is organized by a system that is
immediately apparent to
Walter and would take significant time
to explain to
anyone else.

JOSEPH

You've been here since before us.

ANNIE

I knew someone was coming. I
didn't know who or when. I knew
what they would need.

JOSEPH

How did you know?

ANNIE

Because I've been watching the
dimensional currents for a long
time. There's a shape to it – to
what's been building. To the way
the multiverse has been leaning
toward a particular kind of
crisis. And when a crisis has a
particular shape, the solution has
a particular shape too. I started
gathering the materials that

matched the shape of the solution.

JOSEPH

And you didn't reach out to us.

ANNIE

I didn't know who you were yet. I
knew you were coming. I waited.

Walter is examining what she's
brought. His examination
has shifted from neutral to attentive.

WALTER

The organization of this material
— you sorted it by dimensional
charge density.

ANNIE

And by binding potential. The ones
in the left section have higher
affinity for the Weezy Gold
frequency. I thought that might be
relevant.

WALTER

It is relevant. It's more than
relevant.

He makes a note. A very specific note.
The note of a man
who has encountered something that
changes a calculation
he thought was finished.

WALTER

(to himself; quietly)

Good.

THREE.

WILLIAM TURNER arrives from the coast.
He has sailed here
— not metaphorically; actually sailed,
in an actual ship
through dimensional currents that
behave like oceanic
currents once you know how to read
them. He carries URU
INGOTS in a waterproofed canvas pack.
He is, as always,
anachronistically beautiful in his
appearance — the beauty
of someone who was made, or made
himself, in a different
era and carries that era with him like
a second skin.

WILLIAM

The deep-sea trenches between
dimensions — where the membranes
are thinnest and the pressure is
highest — the Uru has been
concentrating there for centuries.
I know those channels. I've sailed
them.

WALTER

The depth of origin will have
affected the crystalline
structure.

WILLIAM

Yes. Which is why I brought
samples from three different
depths. The deep sample — eleven
thousand meters — has a
crystalline density I haven't

encountered anywhere else. I
thought you might want to compare.

Walter opens the deep sample case. He
looks at it. He
looks at it for a long time.

WALTER

Where did you learn to think about
materials this way?

A pause.

WILLIAM

I've been a blacksmith, a sailor,
a soldier, and a man trying to
keep promises across impossible
distances. All of those teach you
something about what things are
made of and what they can hold.

WALTER

Yes. I imagine they do.

WILLIAM

I know hammer work. When you need
it.

JOSEPH

We'll need it.

FOUR.

HAWKEYE appears at the canyon rim. He
has been here a
week. Nobody knew. He did his
reconnaissance, completed

his materials survey, and waited for the right moment to make himself known, which he determined was now.

He descends to the canyon floor and hands Seiko a complete materials map — annotated, cross-referenced, with margin notes that correct two assumptions in Seiko's own survey in ways Seiko did not expect.

Seiko stops working. He looks at the map. He reads the margin notes. He looks at the section that corrects his assumptions.

HAWKEYE

(already turning away to scale the canyon wall)

You're welcome.

SEIKO

Wait —

Hawkeye is already twenty feet up.

SEIKO

This is better than my map.

Hawkeye, from the canyon wall, without looking down:

HAWKEYE

I know.

Seiko looks at the map for another moment.

SEIKO

Where did he get the northern
deposit data? I didn't — I didn't
survey the northern face.

JOSEPH

He did.

SEIKO

When?

JOSEPH

Before we arrived.

SEIKO

He's been here —

JOSEPH

A week.

Seiko processes this. He returns to
work, but his posture
has shifted slightly — the microscopic
shift of a person
who has been surprised in a way they
didn't expect to be
surprised by and are, against
expectations, pleased by.

FIVE.

SPONGEBOB SQUAREPANTS emerges from a
geological formation
on the canyon floor, carrying
VIBRANIUM ORE in a kelp net.
He is cheerful in the unguarded way of
someone who

genuinely hasn't considered being otherwise – the cheerfulness of a being whose baseline relationship to existence is one of enthusiastic engagement.

WALTER WHITE looks at him. The look of a man running a very fast calculation about what he is seeing and whether his calculation is correct.

SpongeBob looks at Walter White. The look of someone meeting a person and determining, quickly, that this person cares about things the way he cares about things, which is: completely, and with attention to detail.

A beat of mutual assessment. Two beings who have, in their respective ways, achieved mastery through an unlikely combination of obsession, craft, and a willingness to be changed by what they learn.

SPONGEBOB

I've been down in the deep formations for two weeks. The main Vibranium concentration is at the sixty-meter level – not the surface deposits, those have trace contamination from the dimensional overflow. The sixty-meter level is clean. The current in the access cave is very specific. You have to approach at forty-seven degrees or you miss the entrance entirely.

WALTER

How did you determine the correct angle?

SPONGEBOB

I tried forty-six degrees. I tried forty-eight. I timed the current and calculated the deflection

coefficient and worked backward
from the access point to the
correct approach vector. It took
two days.

WALTER

The purity level on this ore is -

SPONGEBOB

Ninety-four point seven percent. I
ran the analysis three times with
three different instruments
because I wanted to be sure.

Walter looks at the ore. He looks at
SpongeBob.

WALTER

(very quietly; to himself; with the specific
tone of a meticulous person encountering
unexpected meticulousness)

He's meticulous.

He makes a note.

AND THEN - the others.

BILLY BUTCHER arrives with the same
energy he brings to
everything: thoroughly ready for
whatever this is, making
no announcement of that readiness,
looking for the
position that requires the most work
and positioning
himself there without being directed.

GOHAN arrives quietly, finds a
position in the forge
perimeter, and demonstrates through
his behavior over the

next hour that he has been thinking about this kind of situation for a long time and has specific ideas about how to contribute effectively.

JESSE PINKMAN, who has come out of the facility to watch, watches each arrival with the expression of someone who has seen extraordinary things and has not entirely gotten used to extraordinary things, which is why he is still capable of being moved by them.

PAUL ATREIDES and CHANI arrive together. Paul takes in the canyon, the forge structure, the assembled people, and nods once — the nod of someone whose visions showed him a version of this and who is now confirming that the version was approximately correct.

CHANI

(subtitled; to Paul)

This is what you saw.

PAUL

(subtitled)

Something like this. The details are different. The feeling is the same.

CHANI

Good feeling or bad feeling?

PAUL

Necessary.

A-TRAIN is there. VISION is there.
GAMBIT, shuffling a
deck of cards with one hand while
carrying material
samples with the other, is there. They
come from every
direction. Each carrying something.
Each face showing the
same quality: the quality of someone
who felt a pull they
couldn't explain and followed it, and
arrived to find that
the source of the pull was the right
place to be.

Joseph stands at the edge of the forge
structure and
watches them come.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

There is a thing that happens when
you ask people for something that
matters. Truly ask – not order,
not manipulate, not appeal to
self-interest or obligation or
fear. Ask, with your full self,
knowing exactly what you're asking
and what it costs them and what it
might cost everyone. Some of them
say no. That is their right and it
should always be their right.

He watches them work. The forge taking
shape. The
extraordinary coalition of people
assembled around a
shared purpose that none of them would
have predicted.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

But some of them – more than you
expect, always more than you
expect, always more than your

models suggest — show up. They show up carrying impossible things from impossible distances, and they look at the work, and they find their position, and they begin.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

And you realize something that should have been obvious but wasn't: you were never going to do this alone. That was never the shape of it. The shape of it was always this — improbable, from everywhere, carrying things you couldn't have gathered yourself, willing to be here for reasons you can't fully account for. That was always going to be the shape of it.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 — THE FORGE — THREE DAYS LATER — DAWN

The forge is operational. Four days after the first arrival, three days after the work began in earnest — Walter has built it to specifications that do not exist in any manual, using materials that have never been combined before, to produce a result that he could not have predicted with certainty when he started and cannot fully account for now that he has.

A cathedral assembled from first principles. The kind of structure that only exists when someone with complete technical mastery is also working without a template — not improvising, not guessing, but applying the deep knowledge of what things are to what they can be when you put them together correctly.

The forge breathes. This is not a metaphor. The thermal cycling of the crucibles has established a rhythm — intake

and exhaust, heat building and releasing, a biological quality to the mechanical process that emerged on its own from the interaction of the materials and the conditions.

SOUND DESIGN: This is the sound design director's territory and the sound design is everything. The deep resonant breath of the primary crucible, maintaining dimensional-precise temperatures that no conventional thermometer can measure. The cooling and cracking of metal as each layer completes – Vibranium makes a sound like a tuning fork on silk; Adamantium makes a sound like a stone dropped in a very deep well. Each material has its own voice. Each voice is part of a chord.

WILLIAM TURNER is at the great hammer. He has been here for twelve hours. He does not look like someone who has been at a great hammer for twelve hours. He looks like someone who has arrived at a conversation he has been meaning to have.

WALTER WHITE is at the central crucible. He hasn't slept in thirty-six hours. His hands don't show it. His hands are the hands of a man who has decided that whatever else his body does, his hands will remain precise. They are precise.

Only his eyes give it away: focused past the point where ordinary focus operates, into a territory where everything unnecessary has been cleared away by accumulated hours of refusing to let the unnecessary in. The eyes of a man who is running entirely on the essential.

WALTER

(the liturgy; each layer named as it goes in; not for anyone else – for the work)

Vibranium lattice. Base structure.

He works. Around him: the team. Sonic at the thermal management station, maintaining variance within tolerances measured in fractions of degrees. Annie Starlight providing the energy-directional element – her specific capability at this specific task is something she didn't know she had until Walter identified it and told her, at which point she understood immediately what she'd been doing without knowing she was doing it.

WALTER

Temperature at eighteen hundred.
Holding.

SEIKO

Confirmed. Variance at point-three
percent. Within tolerance.

WALTER

Adamantium grain. This is the
eleven-second window.

The canyon goes quiet. Not
deliberately — automatically.
Everyone who knows what eleven seconds
means has stopped
making any sound that might constitute
distraction.

Walter's hands move. Precise.
Unhurried — not because
there is time but because hurrying
would be the wrong
relationship to this material, and
Walter knows the wrong
relationship to a material the way a
musician knows a
wrong note: immediately, specifically,
without needing to
think about it.

Seven seconds. Eight. Nine. He watches
the temperature
with his hands near the surface,
feeling the specific
quality of heat that means the grain
is seating correctly.

WALTER

(ten; the grain goes in; it seats; perfect)

Now.

The exhale that moves through the assembled group is not coordinated. It is the natural release of people who have been holding something without realizing they were holding it.

WALTER

Uru crystalline overlay. The window here is longer but the distribution is critical – uneven distribution and the overlay creates stress concentrations at the irregularities.

He pauses. He checks the temperature three times with three different instruments. He holds his palm near the surface.

Forty seconds. Forty-five. Forty-nine.

WALTER

Now.

The Uru goes in. The temperature receives it. The overlay begins to seat.

WALTER

Beskar weave. This is what holds the structure against the specific pressures of dimensional transit.

SEIKO

Thermal variance is dropping.

WALTER

I know. The Uru is stabilizing the thermal profile. That's supposed to happen.

SEIKO

I know. I'm confirming that it's happening.

WALTER

Then we're in agreement.

Butcher is at the bellows. He has been there for six hours, maintaining pressure without variation, without complaint, without asking questions about what he's doing or why. He has understood that this particular moment requires someone at the bellows who can sustain pressure indefinitely and ask no questions and he has positioned himself there and is doing it.

WALTER

Nth Metal and Promethium. Energy mechanics. Without this layer, the weapon is physical but not dimensional.

He works. He has been working without pause for thirty-six hours. He will work without pause until this is finished.

He straightens. He turns to Joseph.

WALTER

The binding agent goes in last.
From the top. Hold the container
perfectly level – not
approximately level, perfectly
level. Thirty seconds. Start to
finish, thirty seconds, and the
container must be still for all
thirty of them.

JOSEPH

Understood.

WALTER

If the distribution is uneven by
more than two percent in any
direction, the Weezy Gold will
create binding nodes at the
concentration points. The blade
will hold at those points. It will
fail at the points between them.

JOSEPH

I understand.

WALTER

The nodes will be invisible. The
blade will look correct. But under
maximum load – at the moment of
maximum need – it will fail. At
the weakest point between the
nodes.

JOSEPH

I understand, Walter.

Walter holds his gaze. The assessment
of a chemist who has
learned, over a very long career, not
to trust

declarations of understanding. He has learned to look at the person making the declaration and determine whether the understanding is real or whether it is the performance of understanding, which looks exactly like understanding until it doesn't.

WALTER

Yes. I think you do.

He steps back.

Joseph steps forward.

CLOSE ON: His hands as he takes the container. The GLASS CONTAINER holds the Weezy Gold in its liquid state — extracted and processed over three days by Walter and Jesse in a process that Walter has described as 'technically straightforward and emotionally exhausting.' The substance is luminous without being bright: it gives off warmth rather than light, a warmth that registers in the palm before the eyes confirm the glow.

It moves with the slow deliberate quality of something that knows exactly where it is going.

Joseph holds the container over the crucible. He checks his grip. He finds his footing. He breathes.

He opens the seal.

THIRTY SECONDS.

SLOW MOTION.

The Weezy Gold falls in a perfect continuous stream. It catches the forge light and becomes, in the catching, something that doesn't translate directly to conventional description. It is the color of things being completed. Not finished – completed. The difference is that finished implies an end, and this is not an end.

As it enters the alloy:

The CRUCIBLE CHANGES.

Not dramatically. The change is not dramatic. It is precise. The kind of change that happens when something finds what it was looking for – not a collision but a recognition. The Weezy Gold and the alloy, recognizing each other.

SOUND DESIGN: All the sounds of the forge – the roar, the hiss, the thermal breath, the hammer-ring that has been the heartbeat of this work for three days – fall, simultaneously, to a single sustained perfect tone. Every frequency in the canyon aligned to the same note. The note of something becoming coherent.

The temperature STABILIZES. Not adjusted – stabilized, from within. As if the material has found its own answer to the question of what it should be. As if the question is no longer a question.

The surface of the alloy SMOOTHS. Every impurity, every micro-variance, every stress concentration that Walter has been managing and mitigating for three days – resolved. All at once. As if they had never been.

Something in the material's nature becomes COHERENT.

Like a word, spoken correctly for the first time, in the language it was always meant to be spoken in.

Walter watches it happen. He is watching it with the eyes of a chemist who has spent his career being more rigorous than the evidence required, who has seen many things and refused to overstate many of them, who knows the specific quality of a moment when something real is happening and is distinguishing it, in real time, from the many moments that feel like something real is happening and aren't.

This is real.

WALTER

(barely above a whisper)

Proto-Adamantium. Fully realized. The Vibranium lattice, the Adamantium grain, the Uru overlay, the Beskar weave — every layer is in coherent resonance with every other layer. The Weezy Gold is functioning as a dimensional binder at the atomic level. Not the molecular level. The atomic level. The structure is unified. Not composite — unified. One thing that is made of many things that are now one thing.

He looks at Joseph.

WALTER

I did not actually believe this was achievable. I built the model, I identified the theoretical pathway, I gathered the materials and designed the process — and I did not, at any point, believe it was achievable. I considered it possible. I considered it worth attempting. I did not believe it.

A pause.

WALTER

I was wrong to not believe it.

Joseph is still looking at the crucible. At the gold thread that runs through the dark material, visible now – not reflecting light but holding it, keeping it.

JOSEPH

(very quietly)

Neither did I.

MUSIC: Full orchestra. The Arabic oud that has been present since the opening – since the first hairline crack of golden light in the void – now harmonized into the full orchestral structure. Resolved. Not the resolution of a conflict but the resolution of a question: yes. Yes, this is possible. Yes, this is real.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 – THE FORGE – THE BLADE – DAY

The material is ready to be shaped.

Joseph holds the hammer. He has never held this specific hammer before, and before this project he has not done this specific work, and both of these things are visible in the way he holds it – not wrong, but unfamiliar. The way someone holds something they have read about carefully and practiced in their imagination and are now discovering is not the same as reading about it. It never is.

WILLIAM TURNER positions himself beside Joseph. He doesn't touch the hammer. He doesn't offer to take it. He looks at how Joseph holds it and he looks at the material and he

begins.

WILLIAM

You're not going to break it.
That's the first thing. The
material is stronger than anything
you can do accidentally — it's
only vulnerable to the deliberate
choice. So release the part of
your attention that's worried
about breaking it.

Joseph's grip adjusts slightly.

WILLIAM

Better. Now — the Weezy Gold has
given the material a knowledge of
itself. It knows what it wants to
be. Your job is not to impose a
shape. Your job is to ask a
question with the hammer and
listen to what the material says
back.

JOSEPH

How do I listen with a hammer?

WILLIAM

You feel the rebound. Each strike
tells you what the material wants
to do next. If the rebound is
sharp and direct, you're working
with it. If it's absorbed or
deflected, you're working against
it. Follow the rebounds.

Joseph strikes. The sound is
extraordinary — not the sharp
ring of ordinary metal, not even the
resonant ring of

exceptional metal. Something with
resonance that
propagates through more than physical
space, as if the
strike is happening simultaneously
here and in the
structures adjacent to here.

WILLIAM

Again. Slightly higher on the
face. You felt that rebound – it
told you where to go next.

Again. And again.

SLOW MONTAGE – each strike given its
weight. Not fast, not
triumphant. The patience of work that
has its own rhythm
and cannot be rushed because rushing
would change the
thing being made into a different,
worse thing.

The dark material finding its form. The shape emerging not
as a human choice imposed on passive material but as a
collaborative discovery – Joseph learning what the
material wants to be, the material learning what Joseph
intends, both of them arriving at the same place from
different directions.

The blade: not elegant in the decorative sense.
Functional. Precisely proportioned. Balanced in the
specific way of something designed to be used, to be held
by a human hand for a purpose, and to perform that purpose
without remainder.

Strange working at the edge of the forge, threading the
REALITY-WARPING capacity through the structure – not
adding it but finding where it wants to be, the same
patience Joseph has developed with the hammer.

The PLASMA CANNON architecture in the hilt: not
decorative. Every element load-bearing. Every line the
shortest distance between what it is and what it does.

The Weezy Gold as a thread through everything – visible when the light catches it right, present always, the thing that holds the rest in conversation with each other.

END MONTAGE.

Three days. The forge is quiet. The material has found what it was.

Walter examines the finished blade. He takes ninety minutes. He uses eleven different instruments. He uses his hands. He uses the accumulated knowledge of his specific life, which has been a life of understanding what things are made of and what they can do and what they can't.

He says nothing for the entire ninety minutes.

Then:

WALTER

It's correct.

That is all he says. In another context, from another person, this would be damning with faint praise. From Walter White, in this context, after ninety minutes and eleven instruments and the application of the accumulated knowledge of a specific and remarkable life:

This is everything.

Joseph picks up the blade for the first time.

CLOSE ON his face.

It is heavy. Not in the physical sense – the balance is perfect, the weight is designed to be carried. It is heavy in the sense of every person who contributed something to bring this object into existence having left their weight in it. Every hour of transit. Every material gathered from impossible sources by people who had no obligation to gather it. Every choice – Ryan's choice, Butcher's choice, Annie's choice to wait six months for someone she didn't know – that made its way, somehow, into this.

He thinks of the canyon. He thinks of the arrivals.

He thinks of his mother's kitchen. Of the ficus on the

windowsill. Of what it means to tend something on a schedule — not because it's easy but because the schedule is the point.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

This had better be worth it.

CUT TO:

INT. SPACECRAFT — OBSERVATION ROOM — SUBSPACE TRANSIT — NIGHT

Subspace aurora outside the hull — green and gold and the specific blue that only exists in the spaces between dimensions, the color of distance measured in ways that don't have units yet.

The spacecraft is quiet. Most of the team is asleep. The forge work took everything they had, and what comes next will take more, and the space between is for recovery.

Joseph sits beside Ryan in the observation room. They have been here for forty minutes. Neither of them has spoken.

Some silences are worth keeping. This is one of them.

JOSEPH

You don't have to stay with us.
When this is over — whatever this becomes when it's over — you have options. You've always had options.

RYAN

I know.

JOSEPH

I want to make sure you know I

know that. That I'm not — that you're not staying because you think you have to.

RYAN

I know. You've been clear about that.

JOSEPH

Okay.

A pause. The aurora shifts. A long wave of green becoming blue.

JOSEPH

What you did in that clearing. Not killing him. That was —

RYAN

I know what it was.

JOSEPH

I was going to say it wasn't a small thing.

RYAN

It didn't feel small. It felt like — it felt like what the rest of my life is going to weigh. If I'm going to carry it forward or leave it there.

JOSEPH

Which did you choose?

RYAN

I left it there. I think. I'm still figuring out where exactly I left it.

JOSEPH

That's usually how it goes.

RYAN

Does it get clearer?

JOSEPH

The choice gets clearer. The weight of it doesn't necessarily change. You just get better at carrying weight.

RYAN

You've had to carry things that weighed a lot.

Yes.

JOSEPH

RYAN

Does it ever — does it ever feel like it might have been wrong? Like you made the choice and then later wondered if you made the right one?

Joseph looks at the aurora for a long time.

JOSEPH

Yes. There are things I've carried for years where I still don't know. Where I look at the choice and I can see the argument for the other way and I don't know if I was right.

RYAN

How do you live with that?

JOSEPH

You accept that you made the best choice you could with what you knew. And then you try to become the kind of person who makes better choices with more knowledge next time.

RYAN

That sounds like a lot of work.

JOSEPH

It's the only work that really matters.

Ryan looks at the aurora. The green and gold and impossible blue of the space between things.

RYAN

I still want to help. When this is over. Whatever comes after — I want to be part of what comes after.

JOSEPH

Then you will be.

The aurora shifts. A long wave of color, moving through the spectrum of things that don't have names.

MUSIC: A single piano note. Middle C. Held for four bars. Released.

The note hangs in the air of the observation room longer than it should.

Then it's gone.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

"THE FINAL WAR"

Film One: The Ambush and the Forging

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. SPACECRAFT — SEIKO'S QUARTERS — NIGHT

Small. Organized with the specific logic of someone who has spent a great deal of time in small spaces and has made peace with them by making them exact. Everything in its place. A shelf of physical books — actual paper, actual binding — that Seiko has carried across every transit for the last four years.

Seiko sits at his desk. Not working. He has the tablet face-down — a deliberate act, for him, equivalent to leaving the building.

He is writing by hand. A letter. On actual paper. With an actual pen.

Joseph appears in the doorway.

JOSEPH

You're writing by hand.

SEIKO

I write by hand when the content should not be in any system. When it is for someone specific and should only reach that person.

JOSEPH

Who is it for?

SEIKO

My sister.

A pause. Joseph has known Seiko for six years. He has heard Seiko mention his sister exactly twice.

JOSEPH

She doesn't know where you are.

SEIKO

She knows approximately. She knows the kind of work I do. She has always been — comfortable with approximation. It is not a quality I share, but I appreciate it in her.

JOSEPH

What do you write to her about?

SEIKO

What I can. Context without specifics. The quality of the work. Whether I am — whether the situation is one that I find

meaningful.

JOSEPH

And is it? This one?

Seiko looks at the letter. At the pen
in his hand.

SEIKO

Yes. This is the most meaningful
work I have done. By a significant
margin.

JOSEPH

Because of the scale?

SEIKO

Because of the asking. You asked.
You didn't order. You didn't
manipulate. You said: here is what
is happening and here is what I
need and here is what it will cost
and you decide. That's —

He stops. He sets the pen down.

SEIKO

That's not how most people operate
when the stakes are high. When the
stakes are high, most people stop
asking and start telling. You kept
asking.

JOSEPH

It seemed like the right approach.

SEIKO

It was the only approach that had a chance of working. You couldn't have compelled any of the people who are going to show up in that canyon. Not one of them. The only thing that reaches them is an honest request.

He looks at the letter again.)

SEIKO

I'm telling her that. That I am working with someone who asks honestly. She will understand what that means.

He picks up the pen.

JOSEPH

Seiko.

SEIKO

Yes.

JOSEPH

Thank you. For being here.

SEIKO

You asked honestly. That's why I'm here. You can thank the asking.

Joseph nods. He leaves Seiko to his letter. In the corridor, he pauses. He thinks about the Thursday. He thinks about the ficus.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 - CANYON SYSTEM - THE FIRST NIGHT - DUSK

The canyon at dusk. The dimensional gold in the stone catching the last of the light and holding it longer than it should — as if the stone itself doesn't want the day to end.

Joseph sits at the canyon rim. Below him: the preliminary forge structure taking shape. People working around it by the light of portable equipment.

ANNIE STARLIGHT sits beside him. She has been here six months. She has the specific quality of someone who has been alone for a long time and has learned to be comfortable in it without losing the capacity for company.

ANNIE

You didn't expect this many people.

JOSEPH

I expected fewer. The models — Seiko's projections — suggested twelve to fifteen responses. We're at thirty-two and the eastern portals are still active.

ANNIE

Why did you think twelve to fifteen?

JOSEPH

Because the models are built from historical data. How many people responded to comparable signals in comparable situations. And historically, the number is small. Most people, when something

difficult and dangerous is
happening in a dimension that
isn't theirs, choose not to get
involved.

ANNIE

That's true of most people.

Yes.

JOSEPH

ANNIE

But the signal you sent wasn't
aimed at most people. It was aimed
at the ones who wouldn't choose
not to get involved. The frequency
you used —

JOSEPH

Seiko designed it. To reach people
with specific dimensional
attunement. A narrow band.

ANNIE

You're describing a very specific
kind of person. The kind of person
who doesn't tune out when things
become difficult and dangerous in
places that aren't their immediate
problem.

JOSEPH

Yes.

ANNIE

There are more of those people
than the historical models account
for. Because the historical models
are built from the people who
responded to previous signals. And
previous signals were – less
honest than yours.

Joseph looks at her.

ANNIE

I can feel the honesty of a
signal. Most people can, actually,
if the signal is calibrated right.
Most signals at this kind of scale
carry a freight of manipulation
underneath the ask – a designed
consequence, a manufactured
urgency, something that makes the
receiver feel they have no choice
but to respond. Your signal didn't
have any of that.

JOSEPH

What did it have?

ANNIE

Just the ask. And the
acknowledgment that they could say
no. That was the unusual part. The
acknowledgment that no was
available.

JOSEPH

I meant it.

ANNIE

I know. That's why it worked.

The canyon below them. The people
working by the light of

the equipment. Thirty-two of them.
More coming.

JOSEPH

Why did you come? Six months ago.
Before the signal.

ANNIE

Because I felt the shape of what
was coming. And the shape required
someone who could do what I can do
— the energy-directional work, the
specific application of light at
these frequencies. And I wanted to
be here for it. I wanted to be
part of whatever responded to it.

JOSEPH

Even without knowing who would
lead it.

ANNIE

Especially without knowing who
would lead it. The response shapes
itself around the person who leads
it. I wanted to be present for
that shaping. I was curious what
kind of person it would be.

And?

JOSEPH

ANNIE

You ask honestly. In my
experience, people who ask
honestly are either naive or have
resolved something that most

people haven't resolved. I don't think you're naive.

JOSEPH

What have I resolved?

ANNIE

A pause.

That you can't do it alone. That needing other people isn't weakness. That asking is stronger than commanding, in the specific circumstances where it matters.

JOSEPH

I'm still not entirely sure I believe all of that.

ANNIE

I know. But you act as if you do. And in the situations that matter, acting as if is the same as believing.

The canyon. The light. The people working below.

JOSEPH

Thank you for being here, Annie. For the six months and for now.

ANNIE

You're welcome. The work is good. The cause is right. And the people

—

She looks down at the forge structure.
At the thirty-two
people working around it.

ANNIE

The people are remarkable.
Whatever happens, that's already
true.

CUT TO:

INT. EARTH-2397 - THE FACILITY - WALTER AND JESSE - NIGHT

The lab is quiet. Most people are sleeping. Walter is not sleeping. He is at his workstation, running calculations he has run eleven times today. Each time the calculation comes back the same. He runs it a twelfth time.

JESSE PINKMAN sits on a stool in the corner, eating something from a container. He eats with the specific attention of someone who has learned that meals are not guaranteed and should be attended to when they happen.

JESSE

You're running it again.

WALTER

I'm verifying.

JESSE

You verified it eleven times.

WALTER

Verification is not a process with
a fixed number of iterations,
Jesse. Verification is a process
that continues until the result is

certain.

JESSE

Is it certain?

WALTER

It is consistent. Eleven times consistent.

JESSE

That sounds like certain.

WALTER

It sounds like eleven times consistent. Which is different.

Jesse eats. Walter runs the calculation a twelfth time.

JESSE

Is this going to work?

WALTER

The theoretical basis is sound. The materials are correct. The process I've designed is the most efficient path to the required output. Whether it will work —

JESSE

Whether it will work.

WALTER

I have never built this before. No

one has built this before. It is not possible to have complete confidence in a process that has never been completed. It is possible to have confidence in the theory. It is possible to have confidence in the materials. It is possible to have confidence in the process design.

But.

JESSE

WALTER

But certainty requires precedent. And there is no precedent for this.

JESSE

Mr. White.

WALTER

Don't call me that.

JESSE

Walter. Is this going to work?

A pause.

Walter looks at his calculation. At the twelfth result, which is the same as the first eleven.

WALTER

I believe it will work. I believe that more strongly than I have believed most things I have built. The Weezy Gold changes the

calculus in a way that makes the outcome more likely than I initially projected when I agreed to this project.

JESSE

How much more likely?

WALTER

Significantly. The word 'significantly' is not precise enough for the kind of precision I prefer, but it is accurate.

JESSE

Good enough.

WALTER

Is it?

JESSE

Yeah. 'Significantly more likely' is good enough to keep going.

Walter looks at him.)

WALTER

You have always had an unusual relationship with certainty.

JESSE

I spent a long time needing everything to be certain before I could move. I wasted a lot of time that way. Now I try to figure out if there's enough to keep going

and then keep going.

WALTER

And is there enough here?

JESSE

Yeah. There's enough here.

Walter looks at the calculation one more time. He closes it. He does not run it a thirteenth time.

WALTER

Get some sleep, Jesse.

JESSE

Yeah. You too.

WALTER

In a while.

JESSE

That means not tonight.

WALTER

It means in a while.

JESSE

Okay.

Jesse goes. Walter sits alone in the lab, in the specific quality of late-night silence that is different from all

other silences. He looks at the materials assembled around him. At what they will become. At what they will make possible.

WALTER

(to himself; to the work; to the night)

In a while.

He opens a new calculation.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 - CANYON RIM - PAUL AND CHANI - DAWN

Before the forge begins. The canyon in the specific quality of first light — the gold in the stone not yet visible, the shadows still long, the air still carrying the coolness of night before the dimensional warmth of this place asserts itself.

PAUL ATREIDES and CHANI sit at the canyon rim. Below them: the forge structure, the people sleeping around it, the extraordinary gathering that has assembled in response to a signal Paul felt from across three dimensions.

CHANI

(subtitled; in Chakobsa)

You've been quiet since we arrived.

PAUL

(subtitled)

I've been thinking.

CHANI

About the visions?

PAUL

About what the visions miss. They show the shape of events. They don't show the cost. They never show the cost.

CHANI

What is the cost here?

PAUL

I don't know yet. That's what I've been thinking about. The vision showed me people assembling in a canyon. The canyon. The forge. The signal going out. I saw this —

He gestures at what is below them.

PAUL

— but I didn't see what it costs to bring it to the next part.

CHANI

What is the next part?

PAUL

The battle. And after the battle — something. The visions get unclear when they approach the moment of highest consequence. The spice shows you the shape of possibility. The moments where everything could go differently — those are the ones where the shape is least clear.

CHANI

Because everything could go differently.

PAUL

Yes. The visions are most useful where the future is most fixed. They're least useful where choice matters most.

CHANI

Then in the moment of highest consequence, you are without guidance.

PAUL

Like everyone else.

A pause. The first light reaching the canyon floor. The dimensional gold beginning to glow.

CHANI

I've always thought that was a mercy. The visions.

PAUL

A mercy?

CHANI

They could make you think you know what will happen. They could make you overconfident. But they fail at the moments that matter — which means you can't rely on them.

Which means you have to develop judgment. You can't outsource judgment to the visions. They won't let you.

PAUL

I hadn't thought of it that way.

CHANI

I know. You've been thinking of them as a tool that works imperfectly. I'm saying they're a tool that works precisely – at teaching you not to rely on tools.

Paul looks at her.

PAUL

How did you get so wise?

CHANI

By watching you make mistakes. It's educational.

He almost smiles. She is already standing.

CHANI

Come. The forge begins today. We should be there.

He stands. They descend into the canyon together, into the first light of a day that will produce something that has never existed before.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 - CANYON FLOOR - WILLIAM AND JOSEPH - FORGE
DAY TWO

A break in the forge work - the middle of the second day, when the Adamantium integration requires a three-hour thermal stabilization period and there is nothing to be done but wait. Walter has been very clear about the waiting.

Joseph and William Turner sit against the canyon wall. William is cleaning the hammer - not because it needs cleaning, but because it is what a craftsman does with his tools when the tools are not in use.

WILLIAM

You've never held a hammer before today.

JOSEPH

Not this kind of work, no.

WILLIAM

And yet you didn't hesitate when Walter said you would do the binding.

JOSEPH

I hesitated. I didn't show it.

WILLIAM

Why not?

JOSEPH

Because showing it wouldn't have helped anyone, including me.

WILLIAM

That's a thing warriors learn. The difference between feeling fear and performing fear. The performance doesn't help anyone. The feeling is useful – it sharpens attention.

JOSEPH

You've fought a lot.

WILLIAM

A very great deal. In circumstances you would find difficult to credit. And I've found that the fights I was most afraid of were the ones that mattered most. The fear was proportional to the consequence.

JOSEPH

Does that help? Knowing the fear is proportional?

WILLIAM

It helps me respect it. The fear is giving you information. The information is: this matters. The appropriate response to information that something matters is attention, not paralysis.

JOSEPH

How do you not cross the line into paralysis?

WILLIAM

You ask yourself: what is the next thing I can do? Not the whole sequence. Not the outcome. The next thing. And then you do it.

A pause. The thermal stabilization hum from the crucibles.
The dimensional mineral in the canyon wall glowing faintly in the afternoon light.

JOSEPH

The binding today – the thirty seconds with the container.

Yes.

WILLIAM

JOSEPH

What's the next thing?

WILLIAM

Hold the container level. That's all. Just that. One instruction, thirty seconds.

JOSEPH

And after?

WILLIAM

After is after. Focus on the thirty seconds.

Joseph looks at his hands. He opens them. He closes them.

JOSEPH

I've been the person who plans everything. Who thinks ten steps ahead. Who knows what comes after the after.

WILLIAM

And now?

JOSEPH

Now I'm being asked to trust thirty seconds.

WILLIAM

Yes. Because in those thirty seconds, the planning is finished. There's nothing left to plan. There is only what you do with your hands.

A long pause.

JOSEPH

That's terrifying.

WILLIAM

Yes. That's the fear being proportional. This matters enormously. The fear is giving you correct information.

JOSEPH

And the next thing?

WILLIAM

Hold the container level.

Joseph nods. He looks at his hands again. He will hold the container level.

CUT TO:

INT. SPACECRAFT — RYAN'S QUARTERS — SUBSPACE TRANSIT

Small. Standard. Ryan has arranged it with the specific logic of someone who is sixteen and has not yet settled on a system for how they prefer to inhabit space. He is on the bed, looking at the hull above him.

He is holding a photograph. We cannot see it clearly.

A knock. He puts the photograph face-down.

RYAN

Yeah.

SEIKO appears in the doorway. He is holding two cups of tea.

SEIKO

I made extra.

RYAN

I don't usually drink tea.

SEIKO

It's not about the tea.

Ryan looks at him. Seiko looks at the extra cup. Ryan takes it.

SEIKO

May I sit?

RYAN

Sure.

Seiko sits on the only chair. He looks at the face-down photograph without drawing attention to the fact that he is looking at it.

A pause.)

SEIKO

You didn't sleep last night.

RYAN

Neither did you.

SEIKO

I was working. What were you doing?

RYAN

Thinking.

SEIKO

About what?

RYAN

About whether I did the right thing. In the clearing.

SEIKO

By not killing your father.

Yeah.

RYAN

SEIKO

What's your current assessment?

RYAN

I don't know. That's the problem.
I can see the argument for what I
did. I can also see the argument
for the other thing.

SEIKO

Both arguments are valid.

RYAN

That doesn't help.

SEIKO

No. It doesn't. I'm sorry. I don't
have a framework for this kind of
question. My expertise is in
systems with correct answers. This
is not a system with a correct
answer.

RYAN

Then why are you here?

SEIKO

Because I made extra tea. And
because —

He looks at the face-down photograph again, very briefly.)

SEIKO

Because Joseph told me once that the most useful thing you can do for someone who is working through a hard question is to be present while they work through it. You don't have to contribute to the working-through. You just have to not be absent.

RYAN

Does that work?

SEIKO

I don't have enough data. But Joseph said it. And Joseph is generally correct about things that are not systems with correct answers, which is the category this falls into.

Ryan almost smiles. He drinks the tea.

RYAN

He didn't kill his father. Homelander. Back in the clearing. Joseph talked to him and he left.

Yes.

SEIKO

RYAN

Do you think that was the right call?

SEIKO

I think it was the call that Joseph made based on his assessment of the situation and his judgment of what Homelander was capable of. Whether it was 'right' in the absolute sense —

RYAN

You don't know either.

SEIKO

I know that it produced an outcome in which we are all still here and proceeding toward our objective. Whether that constitutes 'right' depends on a definition of 'right' that I'm not sure either of us has.

A long pause. The subspace aurora outside the hull. Green and gold and impossible blue.

RYAN

He looked at me.

SEIKO

Your father.

RYAN

Yeah. At the end. Before he left. He looked at me and I don't know what he was trying to say. I don't know if there was anything. Maybe it was just — looking.

SEIKO

Maybe that was enough.

RYAN

Is it?

SEIKO

I don't know. I'm not the right person to ask about fathers looking at their children. I'm the right person to ask about signal processing and dimensional transit calculations.

RYAN

But you made extra tea.

SEIKO

Yes. I made extra tea. That I can do.

They sit together in the small room. The subspace aurora outside. The tea getting cold – but this time, for once, Seiko doesn't notice.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 – THE FORGE – DAWN OF THE FINAL DAY

Before the binding. Before the thirty seconds with the container. In the last hour before Walter says it's time.

The forge structure: complete. The alloy: ready. The material: waiting for its final element.

BUTCHER stands at the bellows. He has been at the bellows for six hours. His hands are steady. His face is the face

of a man who has found, in this specific task – this sustained, specific, unacknowledged work – something that he recognizes.

GOHAN approaches. Quietly. He has been on the perimeter all night, holding position without being asked, without making it known.

GOHAN

You've been at that for six hours.

BUTCHER

Yeah.

GOHAN

Do you need to rest?

BUTCHER

Not yet.

GOHAN

I can take it for a while.

BUTCHER

You don't have to.

GOHAN

I know I don't have to. I'm offering.

Butcher looks at him. A long look – the look of a man assessing whether the offer is real or whether it's the kind of offer that expects to be declined.

BUTCHER

You mean it.

GOHAN

Yes.

BUTCHER

Right. Give me ten minutes.

He steps away from the bellows. Gohan steps in.

Butcher stands at the edge of the forge structure, looking at the canyon. At the extraordinary place they're in. At the people around the forge — everyone who showed up, all of them doing their specific thing, all of it contributing to the same outcome.

M.M. appears beside him.

A pause.

M.M.

How are your hands?

BUTCHER

Fine.

M.M.

That's not what I asked.

BUTCHER

They're fine, Marcus.

M.M.

Why are you here, Billy?

BUTCHER

What do you mean?

M.M.

I mean — why are you here. At the bellows. Six hours. At a forge in a dimension that's not yours, for a fight that you don't have a personal stake in.

BUTCHER

You're here.

M.M.

I'm here because it's the right thing to do. You don't usually show up for things that are just the right thing to do.

Butcher is quiet for a moment. He looks at the canyon. At the gold in the stone.

BUTCHER

He asked. Al-Mithali. The way he asked — no manipulation, no quid pro quo, no 'you owe me this' or 'think of what we can accomplish.' Just: here is what is happening, here is what I need, here is what it will cost, and you decide.

M.M.

And you decided.

BUTCHER

I decided.

M.M.

Because?

BUTCHER

Because that's how people should ask for things. And when someone asks correctly, the correct response is to answer correctly.

A pause. M.M. looks at him.

M.M.

That might be the most straightforward thing you've ever said.

BUTCHER

Don't make a thing of it.

M.M.

I'm not making a thing of it.

BUTCHER

You're about to.

M.M.

No I'm not.

BUTCHER

Good.

They stand together, looking at the
forge. At what is
being made.

M.M.

Billy.

BUTCHER

What.

M.M.

I'm glad you said yes.

A pause. A long one. The kind that is
its own answer.

BUTCHER

Yeah. Me too.

He goes back to the bellows. Gohan
steps aside. Butcher
takes his position. He holds pressure
without variation.
Without complaint.

CUT TO:

INT. SPACECRAFT - JOSEPH'S QUARTERS - TRANSIT NIGHT THREE

Joseph can't sleep. He lies on his back looking at the
hull. The aurora shifts colors beyond the viewport - green
to gold to that specific blue that only exists in the
spaces between dimensions.

He has been running a calculation in his head. Not a
mathematical one. A different kind.

He sits up. He opens the drawer beside the bunk. He takes

out a folded piece of paper. He unfolds it.

A photograph. His mother's kitchen. The windowsill. The ficus — too large for its pot, branches extending past the edge of the frame, leaves catching the Thursday light.

He looks at it for a long time.

A knock.

JOSEPH

Come in.

ELEVEN in the doorway. She looks at the photograph in his hands without drawing attention to the fact that she's looking.

ELEVEN

Can't sleep?

JOSEPH

No. You?

ELEVEN

I don't sleep much. The Upside Down changes your relationship with sleeping.

JOSEPH

How so?

ELEVEN

You learn to be awake quickly. To be ready. After a while you don't know how to be anything else.

She sits on the floor, back against the wall — her

preferred resting position, the one
that allows her to see
the door.

JOSEPH

Is that what you want? To know how
to be something else?

ELEVEN

I want to find out what it's like.
To sleep in a place where nothing
is going to happen while you
sleep.

JOSEPH

What does that feel like?

ELEVEN

I don't know yet.

A pause. The aurora outside. The
photograph in Joseph's
hands.

ELEVEN

Is that your family?

JOSEPH

My mother's kitchen. The plant she
kept on the windowsill.

ELEVEN

The ficus.

JOSEPH

You know about it?

ELEVEN

You talk about it. In your head.
When you think about why things
matter. I don't read minds — but I
can feel the shape of what someone
keeps coming back to. You keep
coming back to the plant.

Joseph looks at the photograph.

JOSEPH

She died four years ago. Before I
understood what she was teaching
me with it.

ELEVEN

What was she teaching you?

JOSEPH

That the container isn't the
point. That what's inside the
container, growing toward what it
needs — that's the point. The pot
was too small. She never changed
it. But the plant kept growing
anyway.

ELEVEN

She knew it would.

JOSEPH

She knew it was already doing what
it needed to do. The pot being
wrong didn't stop it. It just
meant the growth looked unusual
from the outside.

El looks at the photograph.

ELEVEN

What's the pot?

JOSEPH

I don't know yet. That's the calculation I've been running.

ELEVEN

Is it the powers?

JOSEPH

Maybe. Or maybe the powers were never the point, and the plant — whatever the plant is — is something I don't have a name for yet.

ELEVEN

The growing toward what it needs.

JOSEPH

Yes. Whatever that is.

A long quiet. The aurora shifts. Gold to blue to something in between that doesn't have a name.

ELEVEN

My father — Hopper — he used to say that the people worth knowing were the ones who kept growing past what they were given. Past the container they were put in.

JOSEPH

He sounds like someone worth
knowing.

ELEVEN

He was. He's gone now. But I carry
it.

JOSEPH

The thing he taught you.

ELEVEN

Yes. I carry it for him.

They sit in the small room. The
aurora. The photograph
between them in the air, a bridge of
shared understanding
between two people who arrived at the
same truth from very
different directions.

JOSEPH

El.

Yes.

ELEVEN

JOSEPH

After this — when this is done.
Whatever ordinary looks like on
the other side. I hope you find a
place in it.

ELEVEN

What kind of place?

JOSEPH

The kind where you can sleep in a
room where nothing is going to
happen while you sleep.

El looks at the photograph. At the
figus on the
windowsill, too large for its pot,
growing toward the
light anyway.

ELEVEN

I think I might.

JOSEPH

Good.

She stands. She goes back to her
quarters. Joseph folds
the photograph and puts it back in the
drawer. He lies
down. This time, he sleeps.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 — THE FORGE — THE HAMMER WORK — DAY THREE

The blade is taking shape. What was formless alloy two
days ago is becoming something — the shape emerging the
way shapes emerge when they have been waiting to be found
rather than made.

WILLIAM TURNER is teaching. Not standing over Joseph and
correcting — standing beside him, working in parallel on a
practice piece, demonstrating by doing rather than by
explaining.

The rhythm of the work: strike, listen to the rebound,
adjust, strike again. A conversation in metal. Learning

the language.

GOHAN is watching from nearby. He has been watching for two hours. He approaches.

GOHAN

Can I try?

William looks at him. Looks at the practice piece.

WILLIAM

Have you done hammer work before?

GOHAN

I've spent my life learning to shape power into precision. The principle is similar.

WILLIAM

The principle is similar. The practice is specific. Here.

He hands Gohan the practice hammer. Gohan takes it. He holds it with the considered attention of someone who has learned many physical disciplines and knows how to approach a new one.

He strikes. The sound is different from Joseph's early strikes — more controlled in some dimensions, less controlled in others. The rebound gives different information.

WILLIAM

What did you feel?

GOHAN

The rebound was absorbed. I was working against it.

WILLIAM

Yes. The material pushed back.
What does that tell you?

GOHAN

That I was pushing in a direction
the material doesn't want to go.

WILLIAM

And?

GOHAN

And I need to find the direction
it does want to go and work with
that.

WILLIAM

Yes. Try again.

Gohan tries again. The rebound is
different. Better.

WILLIAM

You felt that.

GOHAN

Yes. That's the material's
direction.

WILLIAM

Follow it.

He does. The practice piece changes.
Not quickly — you
can't hurry this — but correctly.

Joseph watches from across the forge.
He watches Gohan
learning what he learned yesterday. He
watches it take
hold.

JOSEPH

(to no one; to himself; to the canyon)

He's good.

SEIKO

(appearing beside him; tablet in hand)

He's very good. He learns quickly,
he listens to the material, and he
has the patience for slow work
that most people at his level of
capability don't develop because
they can usually force outcomes.

JOSEPH

Have you been watching too?

SEIKO

I observe everything. It's my
practice.

JOSEPH

What else have you observed?

SEIKO

That Butcher has been at the bellows for six hours and has not complained once. That Annie and Walter have developed a working shorthand that functions almost like a shared language for the material properties they're managing. That Paul Atreides has been watching the canyon's dimensional currents and making small adjustments to the thermal management without being asked.

JOSEPH

Without being asked.

SEIKO

He saw what was needed and did it. The same way you do things. I've been noticing it in several of the people who responded to the signal.

JOSEPH

What are you noticing?

SEIKO

That the signal selected for a specific quality. Not just dimensional attunement. Something more specific than that. The quality of people who see what's needed and do it without requiring direction.

JOSEPH

Self-directed competence.

SEIKO

And something else. The willingness to do the unglamorous thing. The bellows. The perimeter. The six-hour thermal monitoring. These are people who are willing to hold whatever needs holding, regardless of whether anyone is watching.

Joseph looks around the forge. At the people working. At what they're doing and how they're doing it.

JOSEPH

The signal found them.

SEIKO

The signal found them. Yes. I'm running a post-analysis on the frequency you used. I want to understand the selection mechanism.

Why?

JOSEPH

SEIKO

Because if we understand it, we can use it again. More precisely. For other situations that require this specific quality of response.

JOSEPH

Or we can just keep asking

honestly.

SEIKO

The honest asking is how the signal works. I want to understand the mechanism behind the honest asking.

Joseph looks at him.

JOSEPH

Seiko. Some things work because they're right, not because of a mechanism.

SEIKO

Everything has a mechanism. Even rightness has a mechanism. I want to understand the mechanism so I can apply it correctly.

A pause.)

JOSEPH

Run your analysis.

SEIKO

Thank you.

He begins running his analysis. The forge continues around them. William's patient hammer work. Gohan learning. The thirty-two people holding whatever needs holding.

CUT TO:

INT. EARTH-2397 - THE FACILITY - NIGHT BEFORE THE BINDING

The night before the thirty seconds. Walter is not sleeping. Jesse is not sleeping. The two of them are at separate workstations, running separate checks, not speaking.

This is the specific quality of their working relationship: two people who have been through something together that required everything they had, who have rebuilt what they are from what that left behind, who work in parallel with the comfortable efficiency of a collaboration that has been stress-tested beyond what most collaborations survive.

Jesse sets down his instrument. He looks at Walter.

JESSE

Walter.

WALTER

Jesse.

JESSE

We've been running checks for six hours.

Yes.

WALTER

JESSE

Everything is correct.

Yes.

WALTER

JESSE

Are we going to keep running
checks until morning?

WALTER

We're going to run them until I'm
satisfied.

JESSE

What would satisfy you?

Walter sets down his instrument. He
looks at Jesse. A
long, honest look.)

WALTER

I don't know. That's the problem.

JESSE

You're scared.

WALTER

I am — concerned.

JESSE

You're scared. It's okay. I'm
scared too.

WALTER

I am not —

JESSE

Walter. Mr. — Walter. You are
scared. We both are. This is the
biggest thing either of us has
ever done. It's supposed to be

scary. The scary means it matters.

A pause. Walter looks at his hands. At the instruments. At the work that is either complete or about to be proven complete.

WALTER

What if it doesn't work?

JESSE

Then it doesn't work and we did everything we could and we tried. That's — that's enough.

WALTER

Is it?

JESSE

Yeah. I spent a long time thinking the outcome was the only thing that counted. That if you didn't succeed it meant you'd failed. I don't think that anymore.

WALTER

When did you stop thinking that?

JESSE

When I realized that the trying is the part that defines you. Not the succeeding. The trying tells you who you are. The succeeding tells you what happened. Those are different things.

Walter is quiet for a long moment.

WALTER

I have spent my entire life
measuring myself by what I
achieved. By what I produced. By
whether the work was correct.

JESSE

I know.

WALTER

The work is correct. I am as
certain of that as I have ever
been certain of anything.

JESSE

Then that's what you've got. The
work is correct. The rest is —

WALTER

Out of our hands.

JESSE

Yeah.

A long quiet. The lab around them. The
extraordinary
materials assembled into an
extraordinary result.

WALTER

Jesse.

JESSE

Yeah?

WALTER

The work we did here — in this facility, on this project — it is the finest work I have ever done. By a significant margin.

JESSE

Yeah?

WALTER

By a very significant margin. And I want you to know that a meaningful part of that is because you were here. Your contributions —

JESSE

Walter, don't —

WALTER

Your contributions were significant. Your attention to the thermal calibration. Your specific capability with the Beskar integration. The way you ran the purity checks — three times each, with three instruments, every time. That is the kind of work that makes the difference between a correct result and an almost correct result.

Jesse looks at him. At this man who has never given him anything without a cost attached. At this man who is, right now, giving him something that costs nothing and

means everything.

JESSE

Thank you.

WALTER

Yes. Accurate.

JESSE

Get some sleep, Walter.

WALTER

In a while.

JESSE

Now.

Walter looks at his workstation. At
the instruments. At
the completed work that will still be
completed in the
morning.

He closes the workstation.

WALTER

Very well. Now.

He goes. Jesse watches him go. He
looks at the lab — at
what they built together, at what it
will do, at the
extraordinary ordinary improbability
of being here and
having done this work well.

JESSE

(to himself; to the work; to whatever it is
that brought him to this specific point in
this specific life)

Yeah. Good.

He closes his workstation. He sleeps.

EXT. EARTH-2397 - CANYON - RYAN AND SONIC - DAY FOUR

CUT TO:

The forge work in its final phase. Most people occupied
with the technical work, with holding the perimeter, with
the dozen tasks that a project of this scale requires.

RYAN is at the canyon rim. Not needed for this part.
Watching.

SONIC appears. He moves at human speed - the specific
choice of someone capable of moving much faster who has
decided, for this moment, to be at the pace of the person
they're approaching.

SONIC

RYAN

Hey.

Hey.

Sonic sits beside him at the canyon
rim.

SONIC

You're watching the forge.

Yeah.

RYAN

SONIC

Not contributing to it.

RYAN

I don't have a specific thing to contribute to it. My specific thing —

SONIC

Was the clearing.

Yeah.

RYAN

SONIC

The thing that happened with your father.

RYAN

Yeah.

A pause. The canyon below. The extraordinary materials. The people working.

SONIC

I run. That's my thing. I'm very fast and I run and I deliver and I'm at the next place before most people have finished being at the last place. It's a useful skill in a lot of contexts. In this context —

RYAN

In this context you're at the bellows or holding the perimeter or doing what needs doing.

SONIC

Yes. Not the running. Just — whatever is needed. Which is different.

RYAN

Does it bother you? Not getting to do your specific thing?

SONIC

For about the first day. And then I realized that the thing I was doing — the position I was holding, the variance I was managing — it was the thing the forge needed. It was the right-sized thing for this moment. Not the biggest thing I can do. The right-sized thing.

RYAN
(to Ryan)

What you did in the clearing was the right-sized thing. For that moment.

RYAN

I don't know if it was right. I know it was mine.

SONIC

That's — I think that's what right

is, in those situations. When there's no obvious correct answer. The thing that is yours. The thing you can live with. The thing that comes from what you actually believe rather than what you're expected to do.

RYAN

Joseph said something like that.

SONIC

Joseph is usually right about the things that don't have correct answers.

Ryan looks at the forge. At the people working around it. At Walter at the central crucible, patient and precise and burning through thirty-six hours without sleeping.

RYAN

Do you think this will work?

SONIC

The forge?

RYAN

All of it. The plan. The thing we're building here and what we're going to do with it.

SONIC

Yes. I think it will work.

RYAN

How do you know?

SONIC

Because of this.

He gestures at the forge. At the people. At the extraordinary improbable assembly.)

SONIC

This doesn't happen by accident. Ninety-seven people don't show up from forty-three dimensions by coincidence. Something about the asking and the material conditions — something about the specific combination of this moment and the person who sent the signal — pulled the right people into the same place at the same time. That doesn't happen unless the cause is real.

RYAN

And if it is real —

SONIC

Then it deserves to succeed. And most things that deserve to succeed and have the right people working on them — succeed.

Ryan thinks about this.

RYAN

Most things.

SONIC

Most. Yeah.

They sit at the canyon rim. The forge below. The improbable assembly of people working on something that has never been built before, in a canyon that glows with dimensional gold, in a dimension that hasn't seen anything like this in two thousand years of dimensional overflow.

CUT TO:

INT. SPACECRAFT — YARA AND JOSEPH — THE EVENING BEFORE EARTH-PRIME

The spacecraft in transit toward Earth-Prime. The forge complete, the blade forged, the team assembled. One night before deployment.

Yara and Joseph in the observation room. The aurora. The stillness.

YARA

Tell me what you're thinking.

JOSEPH

I'm thinking about the ficus.

YARA

Your mother's ficus.

JOSEPH

She kept it on the windowsill for thirty years. Same pot. Same windowsill. Every Thursday. When

she died the plant was still there
– still too large for the pot,
still pressing against the walls,
still somehow finding what it
needed despite the container being
wrong for it.

YARA

What happened to it?

JOSEPH

A pause.)

My sister took it. She keeps it
now. Same windowsill. Same pot.
She waters it on Thursdays.

YARA

That's not coincidental.

JOSEPH

No. She knew what she was keeping.
She understood what the Thursday
meant.

YARA

What did it mean?

JOSEPH

That something is worth noticing
on a schedule. That the noticing –
not the capability, not the
achievement, just the regular
devoted attention – is what allows
the growing to happen. The plant
doesn't need the Thursday. It
needs someone who shows up on
Thursdays. The someone is the

point.

YARA

That sounds like what you've been doing.

JOSEPH

I've been trying to. The people who showed up in the canyon — I asked, and I kept asking, and I stayed present for the asking, and I held space for the no. And the ninety-seven who said yes — I think they said yes because the asking was genuine. Because the Thursday was real.

YARA

And the powers?

JOSEPH

The powers are what made the Gauntlet work. But the powers aren't what made the asking work. They weren't what brought the ninety-seven. They're not the plant. They're — they might be the pot.

YARA

And when the pot is spent?

JOSEPH

The plant is still growing. The growing doesn't stop because the pot is gone.

Yara looks at him. At the man who
figured out something
important and is sitting with it in
the way of someone who
has accepted its implications without
being destroyed by
them.

YARA

You've already made peace with it.

JOSEPH

A few days ago. In the facility.
The night before the binding. I
sat with it and I thought about
the ficus and I made peace with
it.

YARA

Without telling me.

JOSEPH

I didn't know the full cost until
the morning Walter told me. But I
had — I had some sense of it. And
I think I made peace with some of
what I sensed. When he confirmed
the specifics, the peace was
already there.

She takes his hand.

YARA

You know what I've been thinking
about?

JOSEPH

Tell me.

YARA

The village in Sector Seven. The one that was standing when we arrived. The one that kept standing because of the membrane work we did three years ago.

JOSEPH

I remember.

YARA

That's why I'm here. Not the global scale of this. The village. The specific people in the village who are still there because we showed up and did the work. That's the scale that makes sense to me.

JOSEPH

And this?

YARA

This is nine billion villages. Nine billion. If the cascade completes, it's not just the village — it's every village in every dimension connected to Earth-Prime. Nine billion.)

She tightens her grip on his hand.

YARA

That's worth the pot.

Yes.

JOSEPH

YARA

And I'm going to be here when it's done. And you're going to be here. And we're going to figure out what comes next together. That's what ordinary looks like.

JOSEPH

Somewhere with good coffee.

YARA

Excellent coffee.

JOSEPH

I promised.

YARA

You did.

The aurora outside. The transit approaching its end. One night before Earth-Prime and the battle and everything that follows.

JOSEPH

YARA

Yara.

Yes.

JOSEPH

Thank you. For being here. From

the beginning. For understanding
what the asking meant and saying
yes.

YARA

You ask honestly. It's the least I
could do.

They watch the aurora together. The
green and gold and
impossible blue. The color of
distance. The color of
coming home.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-2397 — CANYON RIM — HAWKEYE AND JOSEPH — DAY TWO

Hawkeye descends from the canyon wall. Not because he was
called down. Because he has finished his perimeter work
and has something to say.

He finds Joseph at the base of the wall, reviewing the
materials manifest. Hawkeye sits beside him without
ceremony.

HAWKEYE

You know what's unusual about this
group?

JOSEPH

Which specific thing?

HAWKEYE

Nobody is trying to lead it.
Except you. And you're not trying
that hard.

JOSEPH

I'm coordinating. That's different from leading.

HAWKEYE

In most groups, that distinction dissolves within about six hours. Coordination becomes direction becomes authority becomes hierarchy. This group, two days in – flat. Everyone doing their thing. Nobody performing for the person above them on the chart.

JOSEPH

There is no chart.

HAWKEYE

I know. That's the point. You built something without a chart.

JOSEPH

I didn't build it. It assembled itself. I sent the signal and it came.

HAWKEYE

You built the signal. The signal is the structure.

Joseph looks at him.

HAWKEYE

I've been on a lot of teams. SHIELD. The Avengers. Various configurations. Every one of them had a chart. Even when the chart

was unofficial, it was there. The signal you sent didn't have a chart in it. It just had the ask. And the ask had specific properties.

JOSEPH

What properties?

HAWKEYE

It didn't promise anything. It didn't imply obligation. It didn't suggest that not responding was the wrong choice. It just said: this is what's happening, this is what I need, you decide.

JOSEPH

That's how asking should work.

HAWKEYE

Yeah. Most signals at this scale don't work that way. Most of them come with the implicit weight of consequence. 'If you don't respond, the outcome will be on you.' Yours didn't have that.

JOSEPH

The outcome isn't on anyone who said no.

HAWKEYE

I know. I could feel that in the frequency. Which is why I answered it.

A pause. The canyon. The forge smoke rising below them.

HAWKEYE

I don't answer many signals.

JOSEPH

I know.

HAWKEYE

How do you know?

JOSEPH

Because you spent a week here scouting before you made contact. You verified the situation before you committed to it. That's someone who is careful about what they say yes to.

HAWKEYE

Yeah.

JOSEPH

What made you say yes to this one?

HAWKEYE

The honesty of it. And — I could feel something in the frequency that I haven't felt in most signals. It felt like someone who had already accepted what asking might cost them. Someone who wasn't asking from strength. Asking from —

JOSEPH

Need.

HAWKEYE

Need. Yeah. Real need. Not strategic need. The kind of need that's just — true.

Joseph is quiet for a moment.

JOSEPH

I needed the help. Genuinely. There was no version of this that worked without the people who showed up.

HAWKEYE

I know. That's why I answered. Genuine need, honestly expressed, to the right people. It's the cleanest ask I've ever received.

He stands. He looks up at the canyon wall — at the work he has left to do on the perimeter.

HAWKEYE

For what it's worth — the work is good. You're doing it right.

JOSEPH

Which part?

HAWKEYE

All of it. The asking and the holding and the letting people do their thing without managing them

into something smaller than what
they are.

JOSEPH

That last one is the hard part.

HAWKEYE

Yeah. Most coordinators can't
resist it. The managing. You can.

JOSEPH

I've been learning. It's taken a
while.

HAWKEYE

Most good things do.

He climbs back up the canyon wall.
Joseph watches him go.
He looks at the materials manifest. At
the thirty-two
people working below. At the
extraordinary improbable
assembly that came because he asked
honestly.

He thinks: I didn't build this. It
built itself.

And then, more quietly: but I made the
space for it to
build itself. That's the part that was
mine.

CUT TO:

**INT. EARTH-2397 - THE FACILITY - SPONGEBOB AND WALTER - DAY
THREE**

The forge in its final phase. Walter at his station. SpongeBob at a secondary station, running purity analysis on the final Vibranium samples – a task that requires exactly his level of attention and precision.

They have been working side by side for six hours. Neither has initiated a social conversation. Both have been fully occupied with the work. This, Walter has discovered, is one of the more comfortable working relationships he has had.

SPONGEBOB

Walter.

WALTER

Yes.

SPONGEBOB

The secondary Vibranium sample – the one from the sixty-two meter depth – has a crystalline variance of point-three percent from the primary.

WALTER

I know. It falls within tolerance.

SPONGEBOB

Yes. But I wanted to flag it. The variance is consistent – it's not random, it tracks with depth. Which means if we were to use deeper samples, the variance would increase.

WALTER

We are not using deeper samples.

SPONGEBOB

I know. I'm building a model for future use. For subsequent applications that might require higher depth samples. The data is interesting.

Walter looks at him. At this being who is, in the current context, demonstrating a quality that Walter finds rarer than competence alone: the quality of continuing to learn while also doing the work. The data is interesting, so he's modelling it, even though the current task doesn't require it.

WALTER

The model is useful. Continue building it.

SPONGEBOB

Yes. I've also been cross-referencing the dimensional charge data from the Nth Metal samples with the pressure readings from the canyon wall. There's a correlation that the initial survey didn't capture.

WALTER

What correlation?

SPONGEBOB

The dimensional charge density increases with proximity to the Weezy Gold deposits. Not linearly — it follows a curve that suggests the Weezy Gold is actively influencing the charge distribution in the adjacent material.

Walter turns. He gives SpongeBob his full attention, which is something Walter gives very sparingly.)

WALTER

Show me.

SpongeBob shows him. The data. The correlation. The curve. Walter looks at it with the focused intensity that is his specific expression of finding something genuinely interesting.

WALTER

This suggests the Weezy Gold has a field effect. Not just a binding property — an active field. It influences the dimensional charge of adjacent materials.

SPONGEBOB

Yes. That's what the data indicates.

WALTER

That changes the secondary application model significantly.

SPONGEBOB

I thought it might. That's why I flagged it.

Walter is quiet for a moment. He is recalculating.)

WALTER

You found this while running

purity analysis on samples that don't require this depth of analysis for the current task.

Yes.

Why?

SPONGEBOB

WALTER

SPONGEBOB

The data was there. I had the instruments. Not looking at it would have been inefficient.

Walter looks at him. At this being who makes, in many ways, less sense than most things in any dimension Walter has been in. And who has, in the last six hours, contributed two findings that change how Walter models the long-term application of everything they've built here.

WALTER

You're a very good scientist.

SPONGEBOB

Thank you. You're a very good chemist.

WALTER

The distinction you're making —

SPONGEBOB

I do more observational work. You
do more synthetic work. The
approaches are complementary.

WALTER

Yes. They are.

He looks at the data. He begins
updating his model.
SpongeBob returns to his purity
analysis. They work.

CUT TO:

**EXT. EARTH-2397 - CANYON - GAMBIT AND JESSE - THE NIGHT
WATCH**

Night. The forge quiet — the thermal stabilization phase,
everything holding. Two people on watch: GAMBIT and JESSE
PINKMAN. Neither of them the most obvious choice for night
watch. Both of them completely reliable.

They sit at the canyon rim. Gambit running cards. Jesse
watching the darkness.

JESSE

How do you do that? The cards
thing.

GAMBIT

Practice.

JESSE

No, I mean — in a fight. The
charged cards.

GAMBIT

Oh. Different thing. The kinetic energy. I charge objects with my hands — the cards are just convenient. They fly right, they have mass, they look dramatic.

JESSE

Do you need them? The cards specifically?

GAMBIT

No. I can charge anything. Keys, coins, pebbles. Cards are better in a fight — lighter, more controllable, the shape produces a predictable trajectory.

JESSE

So it's a design choice. The cards.

GAMBIT

Oui. Most of what looks like power is design choice. The power is just the raw material. What you do with it — that's design.

JESSE

That's interesting.

GAMBIT

You have power of your own. From what I understand.

JESSE

I don't have — I don't have what he has. Walter. Or what Joseph has. Or any of these people.

GAMBIT

What do you have?

JESSE

I stay. When it gets hard, when it costs everything — I stay. I've run before. I've run a lot. But I always come back. And at some point I stopped running. I just — stay.

GAMBIT

That's a power.

JESSE

Is it?

GAMBIT

The staying is very rare. Most people with the ability to leave — leave. The ones who stay when they could go — that's a specific kind of strength. It doesn't look dramatic. It doesn't have a trajectory. But it's there.

Jesse thinks about this.

JESSE

I used to think I stayed because I didn't have anywhere else to go.

GAMBIT

And now?

JESSE

Now I think I stay because the thing I'm staying for is worth it. That's different. The staying is a choice now, not a default.

GAMBIT

Yes. That is different. Significantly.

They sit in the canyon night. The forge cooling through its stabilization phase. The stars — or what pass for stars in this dimension — visible through the dimensional haze.

GAMBIT

Jesse.

JESSE

Yeah.

GAMBIT

What you're going to do tomorrow. At the binding. Standing beside Walter.

JESSE

Yeah?

GAMBIT

That's the staying made visible.
You understand that.

JESSE
I guess so.

GAMBIT

Not 'I guess so.' You know so. Own
it.

A pause. Jesse looks at the forge
structure below them. At
what they built. At what he
contributed to the building of
it.

JESSE
Yeah. I know so.

GAMBIT

Good.

They watch the night. The forge
stabilizes. The work
holds. They hold the watch until
morning.

CUT TO:

**INT. SPACECRAFT — THE MORNING BEFORE EARTH-PRIME — FULL
CREW**

Breakfast. The spacecraft common area. The full team —
everyone who traveled from Earth-2397 to Earth-Prime,
everyone who will be part of what comes next. The last
shared meal before the deployment.

It has the specific quality of a last shared meal before
deployment: everyone present, most of them quiet in the

particular way that precedes action rather than follows it. The quiet of preparation rather than rest.

SEIKO is at the table with a fresh cup of tea and his tablet face-up. He is working. He has accepted that 'working at breakfast' is who he is and has stopped pretending otherwise.)

RYAN is eating with the focused attention of someone who has been told repeatedly that eating well before a battle matters and has decided to take the advice seriously.

EL has a cup of tea – Seiko's influence, fully established now – and is looking at her maps. Not nervously. With the calm attention of someone who has done the work and is reviewing it one last time not because she doesn't trust it but because reviewing is her process.

YARA has two tablets – her own and Seiko's backup – running parallel humanitarian tracking. The cities with the most visible dimensional leakage. The populations in motion. The people whose lives will change when this is over.

PAUL and CHANI sit together in a corner. Not talking. Just together. The specific language of two people who have been through enough that presence is communication.

BUTCHER is eating. This is the same as saying Billy Butcher is alive and not currently engaged in something requiring all of his attention. He eats like someone who learned long ago not to assume the next meal is guaranteed.

WILLIAM TURNER is cleaning his tools at the edge of the table. Not because they need cleaning. Because it's his practice.

GOHAN is quiet. Still. Gathering.

JESSE has made extra food – not a lot, not a production, but enough extra that anyone who wants more can have more. He has set it in the center of the table. This is, in its specific way, a form of love. It requires no acknowledgment. He doesn't want any.)

Joseph comes in last. He looks at the table. At the people at the table. At what they have become in the last ten

days.

He gets a cup of coffee. He sits. He doesn't say anything. He doesn't need to.

They eat together. In the specific quality of a group that has been forged in the work and is now, on the morning before everything, simply sharing a meal. It is ordinary. It is extraordinary. Both things are equally true.

SEIKO

Membrane coherence is holding at baseline. Earth-Prime's fracture progression is consistent with the twelve-hour delay that Larry the Watcher established. We have the window.

JOSEPH

Good.

SEIKO

The anchor point assignment is confirmed. All sixteen positions have identified teams from the people already on Earth-Prime and the additional forces that have been staging there for the last four days.

Good.

JOSEPH

SEIKO

The substrate route is finalized. El and I reviewed it at three A.M. One point two percent detection probability at the critical leg.

A pause.

JOSEPH

Good.

SEIKO

Joseph.

JOSEPH

Yeah.

SEIKO

We're ready.

Joseph looks at the table. At all of
them. At the
extraordinary ordinary people who said
yes.)

JOSEPH

Yes. We are.

They finish breakfast. They prepare.
They go.

CUT TO:

FILM TWO

THE CALL — SHADOW KNOWLEDGE

Target Runtime: 72 Minutes

FADE IN:

FILM TWO

THE CALL — SHADOW KNOWLEDGE

Target Runtime: 72 Minutes

FADE IN:

INT. SPACECRAFT — TACTICAL ROOM — SUBSPACE TRANSIT — NIGHT

Subspace aurora. Blue-violet, streaked with traces of gold — the specific color of distance measured in dimensions rather than miles.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

Seiko has been awake for thirty-six hours. I know because I've been counting. He does this — he decides sleep is a policy that doesn't apply under specific conditions. He has been deciding this since we met. The conditions are always specific. They are always, in his assessment, sufficient.

The tactical room: SEIKO at his station. Monitors stacked in the organized chaos of a mind that runs faster than any single interface can accommodate. Three screens. One tablet. One handheld device running parallel calculations.

He has tea. Always tea. The current cup has gone cold. He has not noticed.

Joseph stands in the doorway. He watches Seiko work. Seiko doesn't look up.

SEIKO

Forty-seven confirmed nodes in Epstein's network. I've mapped twenty-three with high confidence. The other twenty-four are behind shielding I can't penetrate from this distance with the equipment we have.

JOSEPH

Can we penetrate them at closer range?

SEIKO

Some of them. Possibly fourteen. The remaining ten are behind something I haven't been able to identify. A different kind of shielding — not technological, dimensional. As if those ten nodes exist at a slightly different dimensional address from the surrounding space. They're there, but offset.

JOSEPH

Is that even possible?

SEIKO

It's happening, so it's possible. I'm still working on the mechanism.

JOSEPH

Have you slept?

SEIKO

I will sleep after.

JOSEPH

Seiko -

SEIKO

Joseph. I will sleep after. The shielding on those ten nodes is the critical problem. If we go in without knowing how they work and they're part of the cascade architecture -

The particular quality of a conversation between two people who know each other so well that certain arguments were resolved in advance.

JOSEPH
(conceding)

Keep looking.

He turns to leave.

Joseph stops.

SEIKO

There's a pattern in how the known nodes connect. Something at the center. Not a node.

SEIKO

(without looking up)

A source. A structural stability element. Something that makes the

whole network coherent. Destroy the nodes without reaching this – and the network regenerates. Every time. I've confirmed this pattern three times in the historical data.

JOSEPH

What is it?

SEIKO

I don't know yet. But I know where it is. Approximately. In his primary domain. The Outer Dark.

JOSEPH

Which we can't reach without passing through the dimensional firewall.

SEIKO

Which requires a key. A dimensional frequency that the firewall is designed to reject. Unless –

JOSEPH

Unless?

SEIKO

Unless the frequency exists outside the parameters the firewall was designed to reject. The Weezy Gold generates a frequency I've never seen in any dimensional catalogue. It may be that the firewall literally cannot

account for it – because it
doesn't know to look for it.

JOSEPH

The Weezy Gold as a key.

SEIKO

Theoretically. I'd need to test
it. But theoretically – yes.

Joseph comes back into the room. He
sits.

JOSEPH

What else do you need to confirm
it?

SEIKO

Access to the firewall perimeter.
Close enough to probe it without
triggering the defensive response.

JOSEPH

How close?

SEIKO

Closer than we can currently get
without someone who knows another
way in.

Joseph looks at him.

SEIKO

Or without someone who doesn't use
normal dimensional pathways.

INT. SPACECRAFT — CORRIDOR — 3:17 A.M.

The PROXIMITY ALERT: precise, insistent, not alarmed but definite.

Joseph is awake before the alert finishes its second cycle. In the corridor before the third.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Single entity approaching.
Biometric: human. Power signature
—

A pause longer than Seiko's pauses normally are.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Telekinetic force, forty tons sustained. Dimensional-travel signature I haven't previously catalogued. I don't have this in the database.

Joseph stands in the corridor.

A PORTAL opens.

Not the amber of a standard dimensional portal. A CRACK — blood-red — the color of something being peeled back from a layer of the world that shouldn't be visible. The Upside Down's signature. Unmistakable to anyone who has encountered it. The sound: a low, resonant frequency like the world breathing in the wrong direction.

ELEVEN (approximately seventeen. Dark hair buzzed close on the sides. Black jacket. Utility vest with pockets in every position, most of them full. Brown eyes — direct, rapid, the eyes of someone who has practiced assessing threats quickly and had extensive practice from a very young age).

Her nose is bleeding slightly. It always bleeds when she uses the power at this level. She has accepted this as the cost of the door.

She looks at Joseph. She looks at the corridor. The spacecraft. The subspace aurora outside the hull.

She has been in stranger places.

ELEVEN

I found your signal. I've been
looking for you for three weeks.

JOSEPH

You found us in subspace transit.

ELEVEN

The Upside Down has its own
dimensional channels. They're
older than the ones most people
use. Your signal overlapped with
one of them at a specific
frequency.

JOSEPH

Which frequency?

ELEVEN

The one that sounds like asking.

Joseph takes this in.

ELEVEN

You're the one who made the blade.

Yes.

JOSEPH

ELEVEN

I saw it. In the dark. When I was
scouting. It was the right color.

JOSEPH

What color is the right color?

ELEVEN

(looking at him)

The color of things that are for
something. Not just against
something. For.

Joseph hands her a cloth without
making it significant.

JOSEPH

Are you injured?

ELEVEN

(touching her lip)

No. This is just the cost of the
door.

JOSEPH

What's your name?

ELEVEN

El. Or Eleven. It depends on who's
asking.

JOSEPH

El. I'm Joseph. Come in. We have a
lot to show you.

INT. SPACECRAFT — TACTICAL ROOM — THE BRIEFING

The team assembled. The dimensional map of Epstein's network holographic above the table.

Seiko walks them through it. He has been awake for forty-one hours. It doesn't affect the quality of his analysis. It affects only the depth of the shadows under his eyes and the specific angle at which he holds his tea.

SEIKO

Epstein's network has a structural center. Something that makes the nodes coherent. Without it, any node we destroy regenerates. We've confirmed this three times in the historical data from interdimensional monitoring stations going back forty years.

He pulls up a specific sector of the map.

SEIKO

The center is here. In his primary domain. The Outer Dark. To reach it, we have to pass through his dimensional firewall — a shielding system that rejects any dimensional frequency it recognizes. It recognizes everything in its database. Its database is extensive.

YARA

Which we can't reach without passing through the firewall.

SEIKO

Correct. Unless the frequency we're using exists outside the

parameters the firewall was built to detect.

JOSEPH

The Weezy Gold.

SEIKO

The Weezy Gold. But the Weezy Gold frequency alone gets us to the firewall perimeter. It doesn't get us through. We'd need a pathway that the firewall wasn't designed to monitor.

ELEVEN

(quietly, not looking up)
I can get through the firewall.

Everyone looks at her.

ELEVEN

The Upside Down exists between dimensions. It doesn't use the same pathways. The firewall was designed to monitor dimensional pathways — the ones that go from one place to another through the normal routing. The Upside Down doesn't route through those. It goes underneath them.

SEIKO

You can route from the Upside Down directly into Epstein's domain.

ELEVEN

I've done it twice already. I was

scouting. Two weeks before I found you.

Seiko looks at her for a long moment.

SEIKO

You were scouting his domain alone for two weeks.

ELEVEN

Yes.

SEIKO

Without backup. Without support. In an actively hostile dimensional environment controlled by the most sophisticated network security architecture I have ever analysed.

ELEVEN

I was careful.

SEIKO

(with the specific admiration of someone who recognizes extraordinary operational capability)

I don't doubt that. I am simply — noting it.

ELEVEN

I brought maps.

She produces several documents. Precise. Detailed. The work of someone who has been watching and recording with

professional patience over an extended period.

Seiko takes the maps. He spreads them. He looks at them.

SEIKO

(the way he looked at Hawkeye's canyon map)

These are better than what I had.

ELEVEN

(flatly)

I know.

JOSEPH

Where did you learn to do this?

ELEVEN

I had a lab. And a man named Hopper who believed I could do things no one had done. And a lot of time in the dark alone to figure out what I was for.

A pause.

ELEVEN

(simply)

I figured it out.

JOSEPH

Seiko. How long to build a route using her access and the Weezy Gold frequency together?

Seiko is already working.

SEIKO

Two days. Maybe less if the sub-dimensional mapping is as clean as her preliminary maps suggest.

ELEVEN

(looking at him)

It's clean.

SEIKO

Then maybe less.

ELEVEN

Are you going to sleep?

SEIKO

I will sleep when —

ELEVEN

You should sleep. You're running at significantly below optimal capacity. I can tell from the micro-delays in your calculation responses. You're compensating for the deficit but you're burning reserves.

Seiko looks at her. He looks at his tablet. He puts it down.

SEIKO

Four hours.

ELEVEN

At least six.

SEIKO

ELEVEN

Five.

Fine.

He stands. He leaves the tablet. He goes.

JOSEPH

He doesn't say 'fine' to anyone.

ELEVEN

(a beat)

I know.

JOSEPH

He also doesn't put the tablet down voluntarily.

ELEVEN

I know.

How?

JOSEPH

ELEVEN

I could hear it. The way he was holding onto it. Some things you hold because you need them. Some

things you hold because you're
afraid of what stops when you put
them down. Those feel different.

Joseph looks at her.

JOSEPH

What does the second one feel
like?

ELEVEN

Like a question you don't want the
answer to. But the answer is
usually fine.

Joseph thinks about this.

JOSEPH

Yes. It usually is.

INT. EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN — THE DINING ROOM — NIGHT

Epstein at his table. A new glass. A new wine. The
chandelier turning slowly. The prism traveling its
established path across the tablecloth.

Kronos enters.

EPSTEIN

(without turning)

The firewall.

KRONOS

There's movement at the periphery.
Very quiet. Almost undetectable.
Not quite.

EPSTEIN

Source?

KRONOS

The dimensional signatures don't match anything in our catalogue. There are two signatures. They appear to be operating in combination – one carrying a frequency I've tentatively identified as related to the Weezy Gold, and one that is –

EPSTEIN

(completing it)

From beneath.

A long pause.

KRONOS

Yes. Sub-dimensional. The Upside Down propagation.

EPSTEIN

They've found someone who can route through the Upside Down. And they've combined that with the Weezy Gold frequency. Together, those two things –

He is quiet for a moment. The quiet of a man doing mathematics.

EPSTEIN

Together, those two things can reach the structural center of my

network. The firewall was not designed for the combination. The combination didn't exist when the firewall was designed.

KRONOS

Can we reinforce the firewall against this specific combination?

EPSTEIN

In the time we have — no. The Weezy Gold frequency is not predictable. It operates on dimensional resonances that we don't have the modelling equipment to counter.

KRONOS

Then —

EPSTEIN

Then we accelerate. All sixteen anchor points, simultaneously. Not sequentially — simultaneously. I want the cascade at forty percent before they can establish a route to the structural center.

KRONOS

That will draw every hero faction in range. Every response that hasn't already come will come.

EPSTEIN

Yes. Let them come.

He picks up his glass.

EPSTEIN

A battle is useful. A battle
focuses attention. While they are
focused on holding the anchor
points – while they are spending
themselves on the visible problem
–

He sets the glass down.

EPSTEIN

They won't be focused on the
structural center. They'll be
fighting the cascade. Not looking
for the thing that makes the
cascade coherent.

KRONOS

And if al-Mithali sees through it?

A very long pause.

EPSTEIN

(quietly; precisely; the single admission
that costs him nothing and is worth
acknowledging)

He usually does.

EPSTEIN

(a beat)

Which is why the cascade needs to
complete before he can act on
whatever he sees.

He looks at the chandelier.

EPSTEIN

Accelerate the timeline. Twenty-four hours from now.

INT. SPACECRAFT — TACTICAL ROOM — NIGHT

Joseph reads the movement report. He looks at Seiko. Seiko looks back, the tablet down. He has slept five hours. He looks human again.

JOSEPH

All sixteen anchor points.
Simultaneously.

SEIKO

Yes. The movement began ninety minutes ago. He's not staging — he's committing everything at once.

JOSEPH

He knows we found the route.

SEIKO

Or he suspects. Or he was always going to do this eventually and the timing is coincidence. But I don't believe in coincidence at this scale.

JOSEPH

How long before the cascade hits critical threshold?

SEIKO

Sixteen hours. Possibly fourteen if the anchor points complete

faster than the model suggests.

Joseph looks at the map. At sixteen points of accelerating fracture.

JOSEPH

Send the call. Full signal. Every channel we have.

SEIKO

Already composing it.

JOSEPH

Seiko. Make it honest. Not tactical. Not strategic. Tell them what's happening, what we need, and let them decide.

Seiko looks at him for a moment.

SEIKO

Yes. That's — yes.

He begins.

HOLD ON JOSEPH, looking at the dimensional map. At the sixteen fracture points. At the geometry of what has to happen next.

The Arabic oud enters — a single note. A question.

TITLE CARD: "THE FINAL WAR / Film Two: The Call — Shadow Knowledge"

FADE TO BLACK.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. SPACECRAFT — THE COMMONS — EL AND YARA — NIGHT

The common area: the one space on the ship that is designed for people rather than function. A table, chairs, a viewport showing the subspace aurora.

ELEVEN sits at the table with a cup of tea — Seiko's influence, already. She is looking at one of her substrate maps. Not studying it. Thinking through it.

YARA GORDON comes in for a glass of water. She sees El. She sits.

YARA

Can't sleep?

ELEVEN

I don't sleep a lot. The Upside
Down changes how you sleep.

YARA

How so?

ELEVEN

You learn to sleep in short
intervals. To be ready to be awake
quickly. After a while you don't
know how to sleep any other way.

YARA

How long were you in the Upside
Down this time?

ELEVEN

Fourteen days. Before that —

longer. On and off for years.

YARA

What is it like? To live there.

ELEVEN

Dark. Parallel. Everything is the same as here but inverted – the same shapes, the same structures, but no light, no color, and something that runs through everything that feels like being watched. Even when nothing is watching.

YARA

That sounds –

ELEVEN

Lonely. Yes. But also – clarifying. When there's nothing but you and the dark and the shape of the thing you're trying to understand, you understand it clearly. There are no distractions.

YARA

Is that why you went in? To understand clearly?

ELEVEN

I went in because I could. And because the thing I needed to understand was in there. And because no one else could do it.

YARA

You could have waited. Could have found someone to go with you.

ELEVEN

I've been waiting for people to go with me for a long time. It's not always available.

A pause. Yara looks at her.

YARA

How old were you when you first went into the Upside Down?

ELEVEN

Twelve. Approximately.

YARA

Approximately.

ELEVEN

The specifics of my early life are not fully documented.

YARA

That's a careful way to say that.

ELEVEN

I've had time to develop careful ways.

Yara looks at her. At the maps. At the specific quality of

self-containment that El carries — not coldness, but the result of having been very alone for a very long time and having built something livable in that aloneness.

YARA

You don't have to be alone on this ship. If you don't want to be.

ELEVEN

I know. I can feel that you mean it.

YARA

You can feel —

ELEVEN

The honesty of things. Yes. It's related to the power. Everything connects.

YARA

What does it feel like? Right now. This ship, these people.

ELEVEN

Honest. All of it honest. That's — unusual.

YARA

I hope it stays that way.

ELEVEN

Me too.

They sit in the commons, in the aurora light. Two women, different in almost every particular, sitting in a comfortable silence that is less common than it should be.

El.

Yes.

YARA

ELEVEN

YARA

Whatever happens with this — after. You have a place here. If you want one.

El looks at her. At the maps. At the aurora outside.

ELEVEN

Yes. I think I might.

CUT TO:

INT. EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN — KRONOS'S WORKING ROOM — NIGHT

Kronos is not sleeping. He is working — managing the cascade progression, monitoring the network, making the endless small adjustments that keeping a dimensional catastrophe on schedule requires.

He is very good at this. He has been doing this kind of management work for a very long time, in the service of people whose objectives were, on the whole, less extreme

than Epstein's. Epstein is the most extreme employer Kronos has had. He took the position because the work was technically interesting. He has remained in it because technically interesting work is difficult to leave, and because the alternative positions available to someone with his specific capabilities are limited.

He is thinking about the four hundred and twelfth version.

Epstein runs his models four hundred and twelve times. In four hundred and eleven versions, he wins. In one, something happens that isn't accounted for.

Kronos has been thinking about the something for three weeks.

He has been thinking about it because he is the person who identified the unidentified signals. He is the person who told Epstein. He is the person who watched Epstein categorize them as 'interesting, not concerning.'

He has been thinking about it because he doesn't categorize them the same way.

Not because the signals are more powerful than Epstein's network. They're not – probably. But because they're not in the network. Not in any catalogue. Not in any system Epstein built or accessed or consulted.

And systems, Kronos has learned, over a very long time: systems are only as complete as what they know about. They fail not where they are weak but where they are ignorant. Where they don't know to look.

He looks at his display. At the cascade progression. At the timeline.

He makes a decision. Not a large one. A small one, the kind that only becomes large in retrospect.

He makes a note. In a system that is his alone. About the unidentified signals. About the substrate routing. About the specific gap in the firewall architecture that he identified three weeks ago and reported to Epstein and that Epstein assessed and filed under 'interesting, not concerning.'

He makes a note: the gap has not been closed.

He closes the note. He returns to managing the cascade. He does not close the gap.

CUT TO:

EXT. EARTH-PRIME — CENTRAL PARK — DAWN — MINUS 12 HOURS

The Park in the hours before deployment. Wrong sky. Wrong trees. But the dawn light still coming up — that quality of morning that has survived longer than anything else about this specific moment.

LARRY THE WATCHER stands at the Bethesda Fountain, one hand on the Angel's base. The fracture lines in the sky above the Park have been slowing for the last three hours. Just slightly. Just enough to notice if you're looking.

He is spending himself for this. He is not supposed to. His role is observation, not intervention. He has been very careful about this distinction for a very long time.

He is spending himself anyway. For just a little more time. For the twelve hours that are needed.

DIANA finds him here. She has come to the Park early — she walks parks before battles, a habit she developed three thousand years ago and has not abandoned.

DIANA

You're holding the fracture lines.

LARRY

I am observing the fracture lines.
The observation is — vigorous.

DIANA

You're holding them. I can see it.
The energy.

A pause. Larry looks at her.

LARRY

Yes. Holding. Slightly.

DIANA

You're not supposed to intervene.

LARRY

I am holding them. Not
intervening. The distinction is —

DIANA

Not as clear as you'd like it to
be?

LARRY

Less clear than I usually insist.
Yes.

Diana sits on the fountain's edge. She
looks up at the
fracture lines — at the gold threads
that are spreading
more slowly than they should be, for
reasons that the
official physics of the situation
don't account for.

DIANA

Why?

LARRY

Why am I —

DIANA

Why are you doing this? You've watched a great many things happen without — vigorous observation. What is it about this one?

Larry is quiet for a moment.

LARRY

I've been watching for a very long time. Across many universes. Many battles. Many moments that determined what came after.

Yes.

DIANA

LARRY

And I have watched many of them go wrong. Have watched moments that should have been different go the way they went because there wasn't quite enough time. Because the thing that was needed arrived six minutes late.

DIANA

You're buying time.

LARRY

I am buying twelve hours. In the most technical possible sense of 'buying' and 'time.' I am slowing the fracture progression by a mathematically precise amount that will result in twelve additional hours of stable membrane before cascade initiation.

DIANA

That seems like intervention.

LARRY

It seems that way. Yes.

And?

DIANA

LARRY

And I've decided that there are things worth the cost of seeing them happen rather than watching them not quite happen because of six minutes. Or twelve hours. Some of those things are worth the transgression.

DIANA

This is one of them.

LARRY

Yes.

DIANA

What specifically?

Larry looks at the fountain. At the Angel. At Diana.

LARRY

The asking. Someone asked honestly. That is — that is rarer than it should be, across the universes I have watched. Someone asked honestly and ninety-seven

people said yes. Ninety-seven
beings from different dimensions,
different timelines, different
everything. All of them here
because of an honest ask.

DIANA

And you want to see what happens
next.

LARRY

I want to give it the time it
needs to happen. Yes.

Diana looks at the fracture lines. At
the gold threads
spreading more slowly than they
should.

DIANA

Thank you. For the twelve hours.

LARRY

Don't thank me. Just use them
well.

DIANA

We intend to.

She stands. She goes to find her
position. Larry remains
at the fountain, his hand on the base,
the fracture lines
moving at exactly the rate he has
decided they will move.

He will be tired after this. He will
recover. He has
always recovered.

It is worth it. He is sure of that.

CUT TO:

INT. SPACECRAFT — SEIKO AND EL — THE ROUTE — WORK SESSION

Seiko and El have been working on the substrate routing for eight hours. The table is covered in maps — El's hand-drawn substrate charts, Seiko's digital overlays, the composite picture of a path through dimensional space that has never been traveled before.

They work in a specific rhythm: Seiko proposes a routing logic, El confirms or corrects based on what she observed in the substrate, Seiko integrates the correction and proposes the next section. Back and forth. Efficient. Respectful of what the other brings.

SEIKO

The third leg — the approach to the structural center. The sensor array here —

He indicates a point on the composite map.

SEIKO

Has a range of forty meters in the standard dimensional spectrum. But the Weezy Gold carrier shifts our signature out of the standard spectrum.

ELEVEN

Yes. But the shift is not complete. There's a residual signature in the sub-spectrum. The sensor array doesn't monitor the sub-spectrum routinely. But if

it's active during our transit —

SEIKO

We'd show up. Even through the carrier.

Yes.

ELEVEN

SEIKO

Is the array active during the cascade acceleration?

ELEVEN

I don't know. When I was scouting, the cascade wasn't in accelerated phase. The array was in standard monitoring mode. I don't know what it does when the cascade accelerates.

SEIKO

I can model it. Based on the network architecture I've mapped — during accelerated cascade, the network's monitoring resources are concentrated on the anchor points. The probability that the sub-spectrum array is actively monitored during the acceleration phase is —

He calculates. Quickly. Precisely.)

SEIKO

Eight percent. At maximum.

ELEVEN

Eight percent chance we're
detected on the third leg.

SEIKO

Yes. If we time the transit to the
period of maximum anchor point
activity — the twenty minutes
immediately following the cascade
initiation order — the probability
drops to three percent.

ELEVEN

Three percent.

SEIKO

Three percent is not zero.

ELEVEN

No. But three percent is
manageable.

SEIKO

What do we do if we're detected at
three percent?

ELEVEN

We have eleven seconds before the
alert reaches the central system.
In eleven seconds, I can push us
further into the substrate — below
the array's detection range
entirely. The substrate gets
denser below the current routing
level. More difficult to navigate.

SEIKO

How much more difficult?

ELEVEN

Significantly. I've been there twice. It requires —

She pauses. Looking for the right word.

ELEVEN

It requires a kind of holding that costs more than normal transit. Using the power in a sustained way, at depth, under pressure.

SEIKO

The nosebleeds.

ELEVEN

Yes. More of them. More severe. But manageable.

SEIKO

Define manageable.

ELEVEN

I won't pass out. I won't be incapacitated. The transit will complete.

SEIKO

You've done it before.

ELEVEN

Twice. Without the additional stress of carrying another person and navigating a timed route.

SEIKO

So this would be harder.

ELEVEN

Yes.

SEIKO

But possible.

ELEVEN

Yes. Possible.

Seiko looks at the map. At the routing. At the three percent.

SEIKO

I want to reduce the three percent to one.

How?

ELEVEN

SEIKO

There's a secondary timing window. If we initiate the transit not at the beginning of the anchor point activity but at the peak of it — when the monitoring resources are most heavily concentrated elsewhere — the probability drops to one point two percent.

ELEVEN

The peak is harder to predict. The timing has to be exact.

SEIKO

Yes. I'll be monitoring in real time. I'll give you the signal at the exact moment the peak is reached. You initiate on my signal.

ELEVEN

You have to be accurate to within two seconds.

SEIKO

I'll be accurate to within one second.

El looks at him. At his complete absence of doubt about the one-second accuracy.)

ELEVEN

You're sure.

SEIKO

I'm always accurate to within one second when I have the data I need. I'll have the data I need.

ELEVEN

How do I know when you give the signal?

SEIKO

I'll say 'now.' Precisely when I
say 'now,' you initiate. No delay.

ELEVEN

SEIKO

Okay.

Okay.

They continue working. The map
refining. The route
becoming more precise, more complete,
more navigable.

After a long quiet, El says:

ELEVEN

Seiko.

Yes.

SEIKO

ELEVEN

I've worked alone for a long time.
This —

She gestures at the composite map. At
the collaboration.

ELEVEN

This is better.

Seiko looks at the map. At the work
they have done
together. At the route that neither of
them could have

built alone — that required her
substrate knowledge and
his computational precision, her field
experience and his
analytical architecture.

SEIKO

Yes. It is better.

He returns to the map. So does she.
They work until the
route is complete. It takes the rest
of the night. Neither
of them notices the time passing.

CUT TO:

**INT. EPSTEIN'S PRIVATE STUDY — THE OUTER DARK — BEFORE THE
CASCADE**

The study. The desk. The letters. The photograph on the
wall that we still cannot see clearly.

Epstein sits with the letters open before him. He has been
reading them for two hours. The same letters he has read
many times. Finding something different in them now than
he found in them before.

KRONOS knocks.

EPSTEIN

Come.

Kronos enters. He sees the letters. He
says nothing about
them.

KRONOS

The cascade is at eighteen
percent. Twenty-two hours to
completion at current rate.

EPSTEIN

I know.

KRONOS

The hero deployment is — more than we anticipated.

EPSTEIN

Ninety-seven. Yes. More than the models projected.

KRONOS

The two unidentified signals have reached Earth-Prime. They've been integrated into al-Mithali's force.

EPSTEIN

I know.

KRONOS

They've also built a route through the substrate. A combined approach using the Upside Down transit methodology and the Weezy Gold frequency. I've confirmed it.

EPSTEIN

I know that too.

KRONOS

The gap in the firewall —

EPSTEIN

Is still open.

A pause. Kronos looks at him.)

KRONOS

You're not going to close it.

EPSTEIN

KRONOS

No.

Why?

A long pause. Epstein looks at the letters. At the photograph on the wall.

EPSTEIN

Because I ran the model again. Not four hundred and twelve times. Once. And I ran it differently.

KRONOS

How differently?

EPSTEIN

I ran it with the variable I've been ignoring. Not ignoring — refusing to model. The variable I've always excluded because I couldn't quantify it.

KRONOS

The choosing.

EPSTEIN

Yes. The choosing. I tried to model it. I couldn't make it fit the framework. The choosing is not a function of capability or resource or opportunity. It doesn't respond to the normal inputs.

KRONOS

What does it respond to?

EPSTEIN

I don't know. That's why I couldn't model it. And if I can't model it —

KRONOS

You can't account for it.

EPSTEIN

And if I can't account for it, my model is incomplete.

He looks at the letters.

EPSTEIN

My father wrote these to me. Over a period of thirty years. Every birthday. Every significant achievement. He wrote to tell me what I had accomplished and what it meant to him.

KRONOS

I know. You've told me about them.

EPSTEIN

He never said he was proud of me for the capability. He said he was proud of me for the why. For the reason behind the capability. He kept asking me: to what end, Jeffrey? Not 'what can you do' – to what end.

KRONOS

You never answered him to his satisfaction.

EPSTEIN

I gave him the answer I believed. The capable ones should run it. The architecture of society should reward excellence. He read these letters and he said: yes. And?

KRONOS

And?

EPSTEIN

I never found the and.

He folds the letters carefully. He puts them in their envelope.

EPSTEIN

Leave the gap open. Manage the cascade as planned. When al-Mithali's team reaches the structural center – let them reach

it.

KRONOS

Jeffrey —

EPSTEIN

I want to see what the 'and' looks like. When it's not mine.

Kronos looks at him for a very long moment. At the man he has served for a very long time. At what is different about that man right now.

KRONOS

The cascade will still complete.
The convergence will occur.

EPSTEIN

Yes.

KRONOS

And then?

EPSTEIN

And then we find out if the Gauntlet works. And if it does — we find out what the 'and' looks like.

KRONOS

And if it doesn't work?

A pause.)

EPSTEIN

Then we find out what winning
without the 'and' actually feels
like.

Kronos nods. He goes to manage the
cascade. Epstein sits
alone in his study, with his father's
letters and the
photograph on the wall, in the last
hours before
everything he built is tested against
the one variable he
couldn't model.

CUT TO:

**INT. SPACECRAFT — SEIKO'S STATION — LATE NIGHT — ROUTE
COMPLETION**

The substrate route is finished. Complete. The most
detailed map of a pathway through dimensional sub-space
that has ever been built, compiled from El's field
observations and Seiko's analytical framework over sixteen
hours of collaboration.

Seiko sits back. He has been forward in his seat for
sixteen hours. The specific posture of someone fully
engaged in something difficult. He straightens. He rolls
his neck.

El watches him from across the table.)

ELEVEN

Is that the first time you've sat
back?

SEIKO

In the last sixteen hours? Yes.

ELEVEN

You should do it more.

SEIKO

Sitting back?

ELEVEN

Acknowledging when something is done.

SEIKO

It's not done. It needs to be verified and the verification requires —

ELEVEN

Seiko. The route is complete. It's correct. We built it together and we both know it's correct. The verification can happen in the morning after we sleep.

SEIKO

The verification —

ELEVEN

Can happen in the morning.

A pause. Seiko looks at the completed route. At the sixteen hours of work. At El, who is sitting across from him in the direct, calm way she sits when she has decided something is correct and is willing to hold that position.

SEIKO

The route is correct.

ELEVEN

Yes.

SEIKO

The verification -

ELEVEN

Will confirm that. In the morning.
After sleep.

A very long pause.

SEIKO

Four and a half hours.

ELEVEN

SEIKO

Five.

Fine.

He closes his screens. He puts the
tablet face-down. He
stands. He looks at the table - at the
maps, at the
composite route, at the evidence of
sixteen hours of good
work completed correctly.)

El.

Yes.

SEIKO

ELEVEN

SEIKO

This was good work. What we built together. I want to — I want to acknowledge that.

ELEVEN

Yes. It was good work.

SEIKO

I don't usually work with someone who is as precise as I need the work to be. The previous substrate analysis I attempted — alone — had three errors that I didn't identify until the second review. None of the errors were significant in isolation but in combination they created a routing vulnerability that I only caught on the fifth review.

ELEVEN

There are no errors in this route.

SEIKO

I know. I verified as we built. There are no errors.

ELEVEN

Because we built it together.

SEIKO

Yes. Because we built it together.

He goes. El sits alone at the table for a moment. She looks at the maps. At the route they built. At the sixteen hours of good work.)

She makes a note in the margin of her own map: verified. Correct. No errors. Ready.

She goes to sleep.

For the first time in a long time, in less than ten minutes.

CUT TO:

**INT. EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN — THE OUTER DARK — KRONOS —
MONITORING**

Kronos at his monitoring station. The cascade at twenty-two percent. The floor timeline holding. Everything proceeding as designed.

He looks at the gap in the firewall. The specific gap. The one he identified three weeks ago. The one he did not close.

He looks at it the way a person looks at a decision they have made and cannot unmake and have decided they wouldn't unmake even if they could.

His monitoring system alerts: substrate movement. The specific kind. The one he was looking for.

He reads the alert. He reads it again.

They've built the route. The combined approach — Upside Down substrate transit and Weezy Gold frequency carrier — is confirmed viable. The route is ready. All they need is the signal to initiate.

Kronos makes a note. In his own system. Not Epstein's.

He writes: the route exists. It will work. The gap is still open. I am choosing not to close it.

He looks at the note. He is very precise with language. He rewrites it.

He writes: the route exists and is viable. I am choosing to leave the gap open because I believe the variable that enters through the gap is the right variable. This is my decision. I own it.

He saves the note. He returns to monitoring the cascade.

The cascade advances. The gap remains open. The variable is still coming. Whatever it is – the old, old signatures that no system can catalogue – it is still coming.

Kronos monitors. He waits. He has always been good at waiting.

CUT TO:

INT. SPACECRAFT – JOSEPH AND SEIKO – THE LAST NIGHT

Joseph finds Seiko still awake at two A.M. – technically, Seiko has had his five hours and has returned to work. This is allowed. Seiko slept. That's the agreement.

Joseph sits beside him. He has his coffee. He is not working – he is present, which is his specific way of being with Seiko when Seiko is working and Joseph isn't.

SEIKO

The signal went out twelve days ago. The first responses arrived within four hours. The final confirmed response – number ninety-seven – arrived sixteen hours ago.

JOSEPH

Who was ninety-seven?

SEIKO

LARRY THE WATCHER. He doesn't typically register as a responder. He is, technically, categorized as an observer. But the sub-dimensional monitoring detected his presence at the Earth-Prime membrane twelve days ago and I categorized it as a response because his presence there is consistent with a response to our signal.

JOSEPH

He came because we asked.

SEIKO

He came and is doing something that is technically not intervention but is functionally buying us twelve additional hours. Yes.

JOSEPH

That's — remarkable.

SEIKO

Yes. A Watcher. Choosing to spend himself for twelve hours. For this.

A pause.

JOSEPH

Seiko. What's the probability that

this works?

SEIKO

The probability that the substrate route is viable: ninety-eight point eight percent. The probability that the Gauntlet functions as designed: ninety-three point six percent. The probability that the reset propagates to all sixteen anchor points simultaneously: ninety-one point four percent. The probability that the cascade window remains open long enough: eighty-nine point two percent.

JOSEPH

And together?

SEIKO

Combined probability of full success: approximately seventy-six point three percent.

JOSEPH

Not great.

SEIKO

Not certain. Greater than even odds.

JOSEPH

What's the probability accounting for the variable you can't model? The choosing?

Seiko is quiet for a moment.

SEIKO

I don't know how to calculate that. I have never successfully modeled it. It is outside my methodology.

JOSEPH

Your instinct.

SEIKO

I don't have instincts. I have —

JOSEPH

Your sense, then. Based on what you've observed. What do you think the probability is?

Seiko looks at his screens. At the ninety-seven responses. At the Watcher buying them twelve hours. At the route El built in sixteen hours of collaboration. At Jesse insisting he'd pull the trigger. At Butcher at the bellows for six hours without complaint. At every person in the canyon and every person on this ship and every person who is going to be in Central Park in eighteen hours.

SEIKO

Higher than seventy-six point three.

JOSEPH

How much higher?

SEIKO

I don't know. I can't quantify it.
But I believe — and I am using
'believe' rather than 'calculate'
deliberately — I believe we are
going to succeed.

Joseph looks at him. At Seiko Toast
who does not use
'believe' lightly or imprecisely or
without awareness of
the epistemological weight of the
word.

JOSEPH

Thank you.

SEIKO

Don't thank me. I might be wrong.
I am acknowledging a conviction,
not confirming a calculation.

JOSEPH

I know. Thank you anyway.

Seiko picks up the tablet. Sets it
down. Picks up his tea.
Drinks it.

SEIKO

Joseph.

Yeah.

JOSEPH

SEIKO

Whatever happens tomorrow.
Whatever the outcome. This – the
asking, the response, the people
who showed up, the work in the
canyon – this was worth doing.
Regardless of outcome.

JOSEPH

Yes. It was.

SEIKO

Good. I wanted to say that before
it's over and there's no time to
say it.

Joseph looks at him. At his friend. At
the person who has
been beside him since Harvard and has
never once asked for
anything except the work and has given
everything in
return.

JOSEPH

Seiko. When this is over. You're
taking two weeks off.

SEIKO

JOSEPH

One.

Two.

SEIKO

Ten days.

JOSEPH

Fourteen.

SEIKO

Fine.

He returns to the screens. Joseph sits
with his coffee.

They work and don't work, side by
side, in the last night
before everything.

CUT TO:

FILM THREE

ALL HEROES RISE

Target Runtime: 163 Minutes

FADE IN:

TITLE CARD: "Seventy-Two Hours Before the Convergence"

EXT. EARTH-PRIME — MANHATTAN — DUSK

The skyline is wrong.

Not destroyed. Wrong. Like a painting made by someone who has been told about New York but never seen it. The buildings are in the right positions, but their shadows fall at incorrect angles — not wrong because of the time of day, wrong in a deeper sense, as if the sun is still in the right place but what it is illuminating has become slightly other than what it was.

The sky has developed a shimmer. It began twelve days ago as a barely-perceptible variation in the refractive index of the atmosphere at ten thousand feet altitude. Over twelve days it has become visible to the naked eye. It moves across the sky the way heat haze moves across a road, except it moves upward, and it moves with intention.

In Central Park, the trees have grown — three times their natural height, over twelve days, at a rate that is measurable and consistent and has not responded to any intervention. The leaves have a metallic sheen: not reflective, not bright, but the quality of metal that has absorbed light rather than reflected it. The park smells different. Not bad. Different. The smell of adjacent dimensions bleeding through.

AERIAL SHOT. IMAX-wide. Six million people going about their lives in a city that is very slowly becoming not-quite-itself.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

The dimensional leakage began on a Thursday. I remember because Seiko noted it and then immediately checked what day it was. I asked him why he checked the day. He explained for eleven minutes. At the end of the eleven minutes I understood the distinction he was making but I no longer remembered why I had asked.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — THE SITUATION ROOM — DUSK

The Multiversal Protection Agency Headquarters — the most consistently inconspicuous structure in Midtown Manhattan. This is deliberate. The architect was given one instruction: make it look like somewhere nothing important happens. He succeeded.

Inside: considerably larger than its exterior suggests. The SITUATION ROOM has screens covering three walls and a dimensional map of Earth-Prime's membrane occupying the fourth wall as a continuous real-time display. The table: forty seats. Twenty-three currently occupied. Seventeen more people standing.

A war council. Everyone in this room has been in one before.

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI at the head of the table. Thirty-six hours awake. He does not look it. He has decided not to.

SEIKO TOAST to his right. Tablet in hand, fresh tea in the other. Three data streams running simultaneously. He looks more rested than he is and less worried than he should be. This is his way.

YARA GORDON at the humanitarian station — eighteen of the last thirty-six hours at this workstation. The numbers on her screen are not improving.

DOCTOR STRANGE — in civilian clothes. The Cloak is in the hallway. (There was a negotiation. The Cloak lost.) He is tired in the specific way of someone who has seen the most

likely versions of the next forty hours and found none of them comfortable.

GANDALF – at the corner of the table. Pipe in hand, unlit. He holds it the way he holds thoughts he is not yet ready to speak.

WONDER WOMAN / DIANA – standing at the window, looking at the shimmer in the sky. She has seen skies do many wrong things across three thousand years. She knows this particular kind of wrong.

CAPTAIN AMERICA / STEVE ROGERS – sitting very straight. A notebook on the table. Not open yet.

SHURI – two devices running code she is writing in real time. She works with the efficiency of someone who is always the most technically capable person in the room and has learned to be quiet about it.

JOSEPH

Seiko. Where are we.

SEIKO

The dimensional membrane around Earth-Prime has lost fourteen percent of its structural coherence in the last seventy-two hours. To put that in context: the membrane has existed for approximately four point six billion years and has lost less than two percent of its coherence in all that time. Fourteen percent in seventy-two hours is not a trend. It's an attack.

He looks up. He only looks up when what he is about to say is significant.

SEIKO

At the current rate of degradation
– which is accelerating, the rate

of loss is increasing as more coherence is lost — full membrane failure occurs in approximately forty hours.

Silence in the room.

STRANGE

Define full membrane failure.

SEIKO

Earth-Prime loses its dimensional address. It continues to exist as a physical object — the planet is not destroyed. But its position in dimensional space becomes ambiguous. Every dimension adjacent to Earth-Prime begins to overlap with it. The barriers between what Earth-Prime is and what other Earths are become negotiable.

SHURI

(without looking up)

And Epstein negotiates them.

SEIKO

Every leakage point we've identified has a directional structure. The leakage isn't random — it's shaped. Someone is controlling where the dimensions bleed and what comes through each point.

DIANA

(from the window; not turning)

How many people know?

YARA

The public briefing describes the shimmer as an atmospheric phenomenon related to solar activity. Approximately three hundred and forty people worldwide have independent monitoring capable of identifying it correctly. Of those, approximately one hundred have published analyses in the last ten days.

DIANA

What do the analyses say?

YARA

What's actually happening.

DIANA

And the response to the analyses?

YARA

Mixed. The populations of cities showing the most visible effects are concerned. In some locations, very concerned.

She doesn't finish. The screen behind her shows population movement data in seven cities. The direction of movement is uniformly outward.

JOSEPH

He's using the leakage as a staging ground. The fifteen military escalations Seiko flagged over the last week — all in dimensional leakage zones. He's positioning assets through the instability.

STEVE ROGERS

For what?

JOSEPH

For what comes after the convergence. He wants to be in position when the membrane fails — so when dimensions begin to overlap, his forces are already through the gaps and controlling the overlaps.

GANDALF

(quietly)

Not just control of this world. Control of the architecture that connects them all.

JOSEPH

Yes. The architecture. The rules. The structure of reality at the level where it connects one universe to another.

STRANGE

And the Gauntlet reverses this.

JOSEPH

The Gauntlet resets the membrane.
Every fracture, every leakage
point, every manipulation Epstein
has made — returned to baseline.
The reset propagates through his
own network, using his own
stability architecture as the
pathway. It uses what he built to
undo what he built.

STRANGE

That's elegant.

JOSEPH

Walter White said it was correct.
I'll take correct.

STRANGE

In my experience, correct and
elegant are the same thing.

WALTER

(from near the back; measured; definitive)

They are. Elegance in engineering
is a function of correctness — the
most correct solution is always
the most efficient solution, and
efficiency is the mathematical
definition of elegance.

Strange looks at Walter White.

STRANGE

You must be Walter White.

WALTER

Yes.

STRANGE

I've read your work. The
dimensional synthesis papers.

WALTER

Those papers were correct.

STRANGE

Yes. They were.

The specific silence of two people who
have both had
incidents they are not discussing.

JOSEPH

We have sixteen hours. Here's the
plan.

He activates the full tactical
display.

JOSEPH

Two things simultaneously. Anchor
teams hold the sixteen fracture
points – slowing the cascade,
buying time, not stopping it
because we can't stop it and don't
need to. Simultaneously, a
substrate team executes the route
to the structural center. The
Gauntlet goes in through the
substrate. El navigates the route.
I carry the Gauntlet.

SEIKO

The cascade completes during the

holding phase. We let it complete.
We use the three-minute window at
full cascade to initiate the
reset.

STEVE ROGERS

Three minutes.

SEIKO

Three minutes.

STEVE ROGERS

We've done more with less.

JOSEPH

I know you have.

He assigns. Specific positions,
specific people, specific
coordination. Methodical, thorough,
unhurried. The room
becomes a force.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — A CORRIDOR — MORNING

Joseph walking after the briefing. Walter falls into step
beside him.

WALTER

There's something I need to tell
you. About the Gauntlet's
initiating mechanism.

JOSEPH

Tell me.

WALTER

The reset requires an initiating frequency. A specific frequency that can only be generated by a consciousness already tuned to the dimensional resonance. Someone who has spent enough time in Earth-2397's dimensional architecture that the resonance has become part of their baseline structure.

A pause. Joseph continues walking. He knows what's coming.

WALTER

The Gauntlet doesn't just use the frequency to start the reset. The reset uses all of it. The entirety of the structural resonance you carry — transferred into the architectural correction as it propagates. The Gauntlet uses the frequency as the propagation medium. And when the propagation completes —

JOSEPH

The medium is spent.

Yes.

WALTER

JOSEPH

And there's no other way.

WALTER

I looked for fourteen weeks. No.

Joseph stops walking. He looks at a
window. At the wrong
New York sky beyond it.

WALTER

I thought you should know before
deployment. I didn't want you to
discover it in the moment.

JOSEPH

Thank you. That's — thank you,
Walter.

WALTER

What the frequency is and what you
are — those are not the same
thing. I want to be precise about
that.

JOSEPH

They never were. I always knew
that.

WALTER

Yes. I think you did.

He nods. He peels off toward the lab.
There is more work
to do.

Joseph stands at the window. The wrong
sky. The shimmer.
The city becoming not-quite-itself.

He puts his hand flat against the
glass. He can feel,
through it, the faint high-frequency
vibration the

dimensional leakage has introduced –
not audible, but
present. Like the building is holding
its breath.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

My mother's ficus. Always slightly
too large for its pot. She never
repotted it. She believed in the
growing, not the container. You
tend what you have. You believe in
what's inside it.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

I think I've been the plant. The
powers were the pot. And the
growing – whatever the growing
actually is – is something else
entirely.

He takes his hand off the glass. He
goes to find Yara.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS – THE COURTYARD – MORNING

Open air. The wrong sky above. But the dawn light is still
the dawn light – that quality of new beginning that
physics cannot corrupt.

Joseph and Yara sit together on a bench. He has told her.
This is what comes after the telling.

She is quiet. Not the quiet of devastation – the quiet of
someone who has heard something that requires processing
before responding, and who respects that process enough to
give it the time it needs.

A long moment.

YARA
(steadily)

You could have told me before.

JOSEPH

I didn't know before. Walter confirmed it this morning.

YARA

Is there —

JOSEPH

No. I asked. Fourteen weeks of asking. No.

Another quiet moment.

YARA

JOSEPH

Okay.

Okay?

YARA

(looking at him)

You're going to lose the powers.
Not you. The powers. Those are not
the same thing.

JOSEPH

They're a part of —

YARA

They are not you. I've known you
with them and without them in the
moments between. What you are
isn't the frequency.

He looks at her. She looks at him.

YARA

You'll still be here.

JOSEPH

(very quietly)

Yes.

YARA

(taking his hand)

Then okay.

They sit in the morning. The wrong sky
above them. The
right light on everything.

YARA

(after a long time)

After this. Promise me something.

JOSEPH

Anything.

YARA

Take me somewhere ordinary.
Somewhere deeply, completely,
unremarkably ordinary. A place
where the biggest problem is
whether the coffee is good.

Joseph almost laughs. Not quite.

JOSEPH

I promise.

She squeezes his hand. They sit.

LARRY THE WATCHER — barely visible at the far edge of the courtyard. He is watching. Inaudible to them:

LARRY
(barely)

Hold.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — THE WAITING HOURS — INTERCUT

SEIKO at his station. Four hours of sleep. He is at approximately eighty-three percent — which is how some people work at full capacity. He sets the tablet down. Picks it up. Sets it down. This is his version of rest.

PAUL ATREIDES apart from the Fremmen preparing in the eastern staging area, eyes closed. When his eyes close, you understand he is seeing something — not dreaming. The visions from the spice giving him a slightly different version of the next several hours.

STILGAR moves among the Fremmen, speaking quietly in Chakobsa. His voice the frequency of a leader who has never once needed to raise it.

STEVE ROGERS in a quiet corner. A small notebook. He is writing names — every person he has fought alongside in this engagement. Every engagement before it. He is nearly out of pages. He writes carefully, making the letters small so more will fit.

WOLVERINE and GAMBIT in a small room off the staging area. Gambit running cards with one hand — not gambling. Meditative.

GAMBIT
You nervous?

WOLVERINE

No.

GAMBIT
(a pause)

Good. Me neither.

GAMBIT

Totally nervous.

WOLVERINE

Completely nervous. Yeah.

They sit with it.

HAN SOLO — arrived in the last hour,
the Falcon in a
dimensional hangar bay not designed
for a modified YT-1300
freighter. He stands in the staging
area looking at the
assembled force with the expression of
someone who has
made a lot of decisions he could not
have predicted.

HAN

(to Chewie)

You know, sometimes I wonder about
all the weird decisions that led
me to the moment I'm currently
standing in.

Chewie makes a specific sound.

HAN

I know. Let's do it anyway.

JACK SPARROW steps through a portal
with the air of a man
who has arrived at exactly the right
moment through
absolutely no plan of his own. WILLIAM
TURNER follows and
closes the portal behind them.

JACK

Good morning. Or afternoon. I've
lost track.

BUTCHER

(against the wall, arms crossed)

Not yet.

JACK

Is there rum?

BUTCHER

No.

JACK

(with stoic acceptance; finding a piece of
floor and arranging himself on it with
impossible comfort)

Dreadful.

WILLIAM

I found him in the third dimension
going the wrong direction.

BUTCHER

Story of his life.

GUMBALL and DARWIN arrive through a portal that Darwin definitely should not be able to open. They find spots at the edge of the staging area and take this very seriously.

GUMBALL

Darwin.

DARWIN

I know.

GUMBALL

We're in a lot of this, aren't we.

DARWIN

Yes. We are in a lot of this.

GUMBALL

I'm glad you packed.

DARWIN

I always pack.

ELEVEN in a quiet room alone. She extends her consciousness. She feels the fracture lines. The convergence. The shaped architecture of Epstein's design. And beneath it — two presences. Old. Older than anything she has felt. Waiting.

ELEVEN

(very quietly)

They're coming.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — JOSEPH'S BRIEFING SPACE — TEN HOURS

Joseph alone before the Gauntlet's containment unit. The doors closed. He is not looking at the Gauntlet — he is looking at what the Gauntlet means, which the doors cannot contain.

The door opens. GANDALF enters. He doesn't ask. He stands beside Joseph and looks at the containment unit.

Long silence.

GANDALF

You know, I carried a ring once.
Not by choice — by circumstance. I
was the guardian of it, not the
bearer. I carried the knowledge of
what it was and what it would do
and what had to happen. That
knowledge had a weight of its own.

JOSEPH

Does it get lighter? The knowing?

GANDALF

The knowing? No. But the carrying
of it does. When you accept what
it is, the weight becomes
different. Not less. Different. A
weight you chose rather than one
placed on you.

JOSEPH

Is there a difference?

GANDALF

(a small, very old smile)

A significant one.

He puts a hand on Joseph's shoulder —
the gesture of an
ancient being offering the one thing
that magic and years
cannot manufacture: presence.

GANDALF

You will not carry it alone. That
is what all of this is — all of
this impossibility, all of these
people from everywhere.

JOSEPH

(very quietly)
Thank you, Gandalf.

Gandalf nods. He goes. The door
closes.

Joseph opens the containment unit. He
looks at the
Gauntlet. He does not touch it. Not
yet.

**EXT. MULTIPLE LOCATIONS — THE ANCHOR TEAMS DEPLOY — MINUS 8
HOURS**

QUICK CUTS — the anchor teams moving into position across
New York City:

THOR at the East River. Mjolnir raised, its frequency
already engaging the fracture line above the water. He
looks at the fracture line the way you look at a thing you
are about to fight — not with fear, with acquaintance. He
has fought worse things and won. He intends to do the
same.

PAUL ATREIDES and the FREMEN at Battery Park. Stilgar
deploying his riders in a pattern that responds to
dimensional pressure the way a desert warrior responds to
wind: by becoming part of what you cannot fight, until it
cannot fight you.

STEVE ROGERS at the Northern anchor. Beside him, SHURI, whose tech array runs Stark protocols she improved significantly after reading them, because she always improves what she's given. Rogers has his shield. Shuri has seventeen devices. Both are ready.

DIANA at the Primary Fracture — the largest leakage point, vibrating with dimensional energy that would knock an ordinary person off their feet. Diana stands in it like a woman standing in rain she has chosen to stand in. She has been in worse.

BUTCHER'S TEAM at the Western anchor. M.M. on comms. Frenchie with his devices, several of which he assembled from staging area materials this morning. Kimiko and Annie holding the physical line. Butcher at the center, doing what Butcher does: holding ground through pure will.

THOR IN POSITION:

THOR
(into comm)

The fracture line above the East River is active. I can feel it in Mjolnir. It is attempting to complete.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Hold it. Don't let it complete.
You have approximately four hours
before the cascade phase.

THOR

I am aware. I have held things for
longer than four hours.

SEIKO

I know. I'm saying it for the
record.

THOR (O.S.)

Note it. I, Thor Odinson, am aware
that four hours is a long time.

SEIKO (O.S.)

...Noted. Thank you, Thor.

STEVE AND SHURI:

SHURI

The northern fracture is the
smallest of the sixteen, which
means it's the most likely to be
ignored. Epstein's forces will
underestimate it.

STEVE ROGERS

That's usually an advantage.

SHURI

BUTCHER'S TEAM:

Always. I've adapted the Stark
protocols to emit a frequency that
the dimensional soldiers are
calibrated to misread as non-
threat. They'll divert resources
away from us until we're ready to
use that.

STEVE ROGERS

That's very good.

SHURI

I know. I don't say it to be
immodest. I say it so you know
what to expect.

STEVE ROGERS
I appreciate that.

M.M.

Western anchor is the most
exposed. If they hit sixteen
points simultaneously, we take the
first wave.

BUTCHER

Yeah.

And?

M.M.

BUTCHER

And we hold.

M.M.

And if we can't hold?

BUTCHER

Then we hold anyway.

M.M. looks at him. At Butcher's face —
blood and
determination and the specific quality
of a man who has
decided that some things are worth
holding even if holding
costs everything.

M.M.

Okay. Holding it is.

And at the CONVERGENCE POINT — Central
Park — JOSEPH.

With him: Wolverine. Strange. The
Guardians. The Boys not
at the western anchor. Deadpool.
Gandalf. Han and Chewie.
Jack Sparrow. William Turner. Eleven.
Walter White. Jesse
Pinkman. Gumball and Darwin, very
seriously positioned at
the edge of the formation.

They stand in Central Park. The trees
are wrong. The sky
has fracture lines that are now
visible — gold and silver
cracks in the dimensional membrane,
spreading, converging
toward this point.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Joseph. Eight hours. Epstein's
forces are moving. Kronos has the
fleet in position outside the
membrane.

JOSEPH

Copy. Hold position. Signal me
when they break through.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Confirmed. Joseph?

JOSEPH

Yeah.

SEIKO (O.S.)

No heroic speeches. You know I
hate those.

Joseph almost smiles.

JOSEPH

No speeches. I promise.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Good luck.

He clicks off.

Joseph looks up at the cracking sky.
He looks at the
assembled force around him.

JOSEPH

We hold until the Gauntlet is
ready. Then we use it. That's the
whole plan.

WOLVERINE

Simple plan.

JOSEPH

The best ones are.

DEADPOOL

Quick question — when you say 'we
hold' —

JOSEPH

You know what 'hold' means, Wade.

DEADPOOL

I do. I was hoping it meant
something different.

JOSEPH

It doesn't.

DEADPOOL

(drawing his katanas)

Cool. Cool cool cool.

The team settles. The sky continues to crack.

EXT. NEW YORK CITY — THE MEMBRANE BREACH

SOUND: The specific sound of a dimensional membrane being breached from outside — not a portal, not a transit. Something being pushed through that was not designed to allow passage.

A CRACK in the air above New York. Forced. Epstein's dimensional fleet breaking through from outside.

Thousands of them.

The sky above Manhattan FILLS with the fleet — a sight with no real-world equivalent. A storm that has decided to have opinions.

SEIKO (O.S.)
(absolutely level)

Contact. Membrane breach at seven hundred and forty-three points simultaneously. They're through.

JOSEPH

All anchor teams — hold positions.
They'll hit the fracture lines
first.

The fleet splits — sections moving
toward each of the
sixteen anchor points with military
precision. Directed by
Kronos's strategic intelligence. They
know exactly where
to go.

THE BATTLE FOR EARTH-PRIME BEGINS.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE CONVERGENCE POINT — THE BATTLE

EPSTEIN lands in Central Park. Not dramatically. He walks
through the breach the way a man walks into a room he has
been paying for.

EPSTEIN

Director al-Mithali. I appreciate
you gathering everyone. It makes
what comes next considerably more
efficient.

JOSEPH

Jeffrey Epstein.

EPSTEIN

One opportunity to stand down. Not
out of mercy. Out of respect for
the caliber of the opposition.

JOSEPH

And if we don't?

EPSTEIN

Then I take what I was going to
take anyway.

He waits. Ninety-seven heroes from every corner of the multiverse face him in silence.

JOSEPH

No.

EPSTEIN

(nodding once; noting it for the record)

I thought not.

He raises one hand. The dimensional army moves.

JOSEPH

HOLD THE LINE.

IMAX-WIDE. The full scope of what is happening.

The dimensional army pouring into Central Park from every direction. The fracture lines overhead splitting further with each completed anchor point. The wrong trees shaking. Metallic leaves scattering. The ground itself vibrating with the dimensional pressure.

And the heroes: moving to meet it.

WOLVERINE — claws out — moving through the first wave with the controlled ferocity of someone who has done this an unknowable number of times and has not, in all those times, developed the habit of stopping. Not performances. Decisions, made in fractions of seconds by a body that

knows exactly what to do and has long
since stopped asking
permission from the mind to do it.

DEADPOOL

(running in beside him)

I want everyone to know I am being
completely serious right now –

He dispatches three dimensional
soldiers simultaneously
with an efficiency that suggests
significantly more
practice than his tone implies.

DEADPOOL

– this is my serious face –

WOLVERINE

There are too many for the front
line approach.

DEADPOOL

Oh, I know. I just like the front
line approach.

He disappears into the wave.

WOLVERINE

(following him)

Every. Single. Time.

DOCTOR STRANGE – above the
battlefield, the Sling Ring
working, portals opening at tactical
positions. Not
spectacle. Function. He pulls a
dimensional soldier

through one portal and deposits them
in the Hudson River.
The gesture is economical. The effect
is not.

STRANGE

(cataloguing; to himself)
Northern approach is two-to-one.
Redirect.

A portal opens behind the northern
cluster. The FREMEN
pour through — Stilgar leading.

STILGAR

(subtitled; Chakobsa)

The desert devours all who cross
it without knowing it. Learn the
battlefield.

THE GUARDIANS engage their specific
chaos:

Star-Lord in the air, dual pistols.
Rocket behind cover,
operating a weapons platform that
should not have fit
through any portal but somehow did.

ROCKET

(intensely focused; this is what happy looks
like on him)

This is great. This is genuinely
great. Can we do this more often?

Drax at ground level with his knives —
how a very large,
extremely motivated blade hurricane
moves through a crowd.

Mantis finding dimensional soldiers
with empathic
precision and putting them to sleep in
waves. Not the most
visible contribution. Perhaps the most
efficient.

Gamora. Her own weapon. Her own
precision. Nebula —
fighting the way of someone who was
made into a weapon and
has decided for herself what to do
with that making.

HAN SOLO and CHEWIE on the ground,
moving through the
battle with the ease of people who
have been doing exactly
this for decades.

HAN

(taking cover behind a park bench)

You know what I hate?

Chewie makes a sound.

HAN

Dimensional soldiers. Always the
dimensional soldiers.

He fires twice. Two down.

HAN

Not as bad as Stormtroopers. At
least these ones aim.

Chewie responds.

HAN

Don't give them compliments.

They'll get ideas.

JACK SPARROW moves through the battle with the impossible gravitational logic that constitutes his tactical approach. WILLIAM TURNER beside him — methodical, efficient.

JACK

William. To your left.

WILLIAM

(already handling it)

I see it.

JACK

Of course you do. I must say — dimensional soldiers are significantly less rude than the East India Trading Company.

WILLIAM

That is a very low bar, Jack.

JACK

And yet.

GUMBALL and DARWIN using every impossible animated physics trick available to them in the live-action world. Things that should not work, working, because they always do.

DARWIN

(after something implausible works)

Did that just -

GUMBALL

Don't question it. Never question
it.

THE X-MEN moving as the unit they have spent decades
becoming. Xavier coordinating with the calm precision of
someone who resolved all the complicated questions before
this started and now operates from pure clarity. Logan
taking point. Jean managing the telepathic field that
keeps the dimensional soldiers disoriented.

WOLVERINE

(to Gambit, in the thick of it)

Don't show off.

GAMBIT

(already showing off)

Can't help it, mon ami.

And JEAN GREY - above it all, managing
the telepathic
field, finding the specific frequency
of disorientation
that affects dimensional soldiers
without affecting the
heroes. Precise. Exhausting. She does
not stop.

JEAN

Logan - three o'clock. The
augmented ones.

WOLVERINE

Saw them.

JEAN

They're not affected by the field.
Their augmentation filters it.

WOLVERINE

Then I'll handle them the other
way.

He does. The other way is not subtle.
It is, however,
definitive.

SEIKO in the command center — three
displays, all sixteen
points, adjustments flowing through
the comm network with
the quiet precision of a man who is
very good at one
specific thing and has never needed to
perform it.

DEREK

Cascade is at thirty-one percent.

SEIKO

(without looking up)
I know. Thor's adjusting.

DEREK

Seiko —

SEIKO

Derek. I know everything on your
screen. I'm running your screen
and mine simultaneously. Please

continue watching. Tell me when something happens that I haven't anticipated.

DEREK

(with the specific admiration of someone watching extraordinary capability and naming it honestly)

Has that ever happened?

SEIKO

Once. Joseph surprised me once.

DEREK

What did he do?

SEIKO

(back to the screens)

He arrived on a Tuesday. I had modeled a Thursday. Seventeen models. None of them put him on a Tuesday.

DEREK

And that was the only time?

SEIKO

(very quietly; the specific honesty of someone managing the largest thing he has ever managed and finding, against his own prediction, that he is managing it)

He continues to surprise me.

THE ANCHOR POINTS — RAPID CUTS as the cascade ticks

forward:

DIANA at the Primary Fracture — taking wave after wave on her shield, her knees bending with each impact but never reaching the ground. THREE THOUSAND YEARS of training. She does not reach the ground.

DIANA

(to herself; quietly; as a reminder)

I have been in worse positions than this. I have been in considerably worse positions than this.

STRANGE (O.S.)

Diana — we need you to hold that fracture for another six minutes.

DIANA

I am holding it.

STRANGE

I know. I'm telling you how long to keep holding.

DIANA (O.S.)

Six minutes. Confirmed.

PAUL ATREIDES at Battery Park. The dimensional army is large, but Paul has fought larger armies in environments more hostile than this. The Fremmen know how to fight in conditions that are trying to kill them. This is trying to kill them. They have been here before.

PAUL
(subtitled)

Stilgar. The second wave will come from the waterline. They'll try to use the fracture where the barrier is weakest.

STILGAR
(subtitled)

I know. I've positioned Chani's riders on the waterline. They'll meet the second wave before it reaches the fracture.

PAUL

Good.

STILGAR
(subtitled)

You saw this?

PAUL
(subtitled)

I saw something like this. The specifics are different. The shape is the same.

STILGAR
(subtitled)

Then we follow the shape.

BUTCHER'S TEAM at the Western anchor.
The worst position.
The most exposed. They take the first wave, the second

wave, and the third wave.

M.M. runs comms with the specific
efficiency of someone
who has been doing this for years and
has learned that the
quality of information determines the
quality of the
response, and the quality of the
response determines
whether people live or die.

FRENCHIE with his devices – three of which he assembled
this morning, two of which are working exactly as
designed, one of which is working better than designed in
a way he doesn't fully understand but isn't complaining
about.

KIMIKO – fighting in the specific way of someone who has
never been able to afford the luxury of fighting anything
less than completely. Every movement decisive. Every
engagement complete.

ANNIE STARLIGHT – her light, carefully calibrated, doing
more than it appears to be doing because Annie has been
quietly developing new applications of her specific
capability for the last six months and this seems like a
good moment to use them.

And BUTCHER. At the center. Holding.

BUTCHER

M.M. What's the cascade?

M.M.

Thirty-six percent.

BUTCHER

How long?

M.M.

Four minutes to self-completion if
the remaining anchor points
complete on schedule.

BUTCHER

Our anchor point.

M.M.

Holding. We're holding it. For
now.

BUTCHER

Then we keep holding it.

He turns back to the dimensional army.
He holds it.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE GAUNTLET STATION — CONTINUOUS

JOSEPH moves through the battle toward the Gauntlet
station at the center of the park. Walter White and Jesse
Pinkman holding the station. Twelve heroes creating a
perimeter.

And then, at the edge of the perimeter: EPSTEIN.

They stand five feet apart. The battle rages around them.
Neither speaks for several seconds.

EPSTEIN

(looking at the Gauntlet; understanding it
instantly)

The reset device.

JOSEPH

Yes.

EPSTEIN

Walter White built it.

JOSEPH

Yes.

EPSTEIN

(with genuine appreciation)
I tried to recruit him. He didn't
respond.

JOSEPH

He was busy.

EPSTEIN

The cascade is at thirty-four
percent. You can't stop it before
it hits forty. And once it hits
forty —

JOSEPH

I know.

EPSTEIN

Then you understand this battle
isn't winnable on the dimensional
level.

JOSEPH

I know.

Epstein studies him.

EPSTEIN

You planned for this.

JOSEPH

You planned everything except the Gauntlet. The Gauntlet is what happens after your plan succeeds. It requires your plan to succeed.

A very long pause. Epstein absorbs this.

EPSTEIN

(quietly; approaching comprehension)

You're not trying to stop me.

Silence.

JOSEPH

No.

EPSTEIN

You're using me.

JOSEPH

I'm letting you finish the cascade. And then I'm undoing it.

EPSTEIN

The cascade — once complete — is architecturally irreversible. I designed it that way. I verified it against every known reversal mechanism in four hundred and twelve models.

JOSEPH

You designed it against any force
that existed within the
dimensional architecture as you
understand it. The Gauntlet
operates on a frequency you didn't
account for. Because no record of
it exists in any system you have
access to.

EPSTEIN

(the composure showing its first real stress
fracture)

The Weezy Gold.

JOSEPH

Yes.

A very long silence. For the first
time in this film — in
this story — Jeffrey Epstein is
recalculating from behind.
He built a plan against intelligent
opposition. He didn't
build it against this.

EPSTEIN

That changes the calculation.

JOSEPH

Yes.

EPSTEIN

(acknowledging the word carefully)

You've surprised me.

JOSEPH

(quietly)

I know.

Epstein MOVES — toward the Gauntlet station. Fast.
Enhanced. Decisive. Because if the Gauntlet counters everything he's built, the priority is the Gauntlet.

WALTER WHITE steps directly into his path. Just Walter. No weapon. No power. A man in khaki pants, hands at his sides, standing between Jeffrey Epstein and the work of his life.

EPSTEIN

You should move.

WALTER

No.

EPSTEIN

I don't want to —

WALTER

I said no.

Epstein looks at him. At this unremarkable man standing in the way of a plan that cost incalculable resources.

EPSTEIN

You built something remarkable.

WALTER

I know.

EPSTEIN

It won't be enough.

He reaches for Walter —

JESSE PINKMAN steps beside Walter.

Blaster raised. Very
steady.

JESSE

Don't.

Epstein stops.

JESSE

I'm not him. I'm not brilliant.
I'm not the best at anything. But
I have been in exactly this
position — one person between a
plan and the man who made it — and
I will pull this trigger.

EPSTEIN

(reading him; knowing)

You've done it before.

JESSE

Yes.

EPSTEIN

And it cost you something.

JESSE

Everything.

EPSTEIN

And you'd do it again?

JESSE

(the answer already in his eyes before the
question finishes)

Yeah.

The battle rages. The cascade ticks
forward.

Epstein deploys a dimensional pulse.
Jesse stumbles
backward, Walter goes down.

Jesse hits the ground. Gets up
immediately.

JESSE (O.S.)

Joseph — he's going for the
Gauntlet!

Epstein is already at the containment
unit. He reaches for
the Gauntlet —

WOLVERINE'S CLAWS come through the
unit from the other
side. Stopping one inch from Epstein's
hands. Not through
Epstein. Through the unit. The
message: try.

Epstein looks up. Logan on the other
side. Looking at him.

WOLVERINE

(very quietly; no drama)

No.

Epstein steps back.

He looks at the battlefield. At Joseph, who has crossed the distance and stands at the Gauntlet station. At the army of heroes – at every person who answered a signal and chose to be here.

He runs the calculation.

He is not going to win. Not because of the Gauntlet. Not because of the heroes. But because of something he called a weakness and they called a choice: they will not stop. Not the way he models stopping. They will spend themselves entirely and find more. He built a plan against intelligent opposition. He didn't build it against this.

EPSTEIN

(to himself; the perfect accuracy of it; the specific kind of honesty that only surfaces when there is no longer anything to gain from dishonesty)

I miscalculated.

The cascade hits thirty-eight percent.

EXT. NEW YORK CITY – THE ANCHOR POINTS – THE CASCADE COMPLETES

ALL SIXTEEN ANCHOR POINTS – the fracture lines COMPLETING:

Thor at the East River – the fracture SNAPS COMPLETE. The sonic boom of dimensional energy throws him backward twenty feet. He lands. He stands.

THOR

(into comm; slightly winded but composed)

The fracture has completed. I am
still standing. For the record.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Noted. Thor. For the record.

Diana at the primary fracture — a wall
of dimensional
energy she takes on her shield. Her
knees bend. They do
not reach the ground. She stands.

DIANA

(into comm; three thousand years of practice
in six words)

Primary fracture complete. I am
upright. Continue.

Paul Atreides at Battery Park — the
southern fracture
completing in a wave that moves
through the ground as much
as through the air. Paul and the
Fremen brace as one. When
the wave passes, they are still
standing. The desert
taught them how to hold against
impossible things.

PAUL

(into comm; subtitled)

Southern anchor complete. Fremen
casualties: none. We hold.

Steve Rogers at the northern anchor.
The fracture
completing with a crack that sounds
like the sky changing
its mind. He takes it on the shield.
He is, in the

aftermath, exactly where he was before
it.

STEVE ROGERS

(into comm)

Northern anchor complete. We're
holding. All present.

Butcher's team at the western anchor -
thrown sideways.
All of them. Butcher with blood on his
face, somewhere
between a cut and what happens when a
wall of dimensional
energy passes through you.

BUTCHER

Right. Anyone got any more good
news?

M.M.

(getting up)

Cascade is at thirty-nine percent.

BUTCHER

One away from self-complete.

M.M.

Yeah.

BUTCHER

(quiet; the quietest thing Butcher has ever
said)

Hold the line.

M.M.

(equally quiet)

Holding.

The cascade hits forty percent.

The dimensional membrane of Earth-
Prime COMPLETES its
failure.

Every fracture line snaps wide. Every
leakage point
becomes a breach. Every designed
corruption in the
membrane completes simultaneously.

The convergence initiates.

The sky above New York is no longer
wrong-sky.

It is not sky.

It is the space between dimensions –
visible for the first
time to human eyes: the actual
architecture of the
multiverse, gold and vast and
terrifying and also,
undeniably, beautiful. The scaffolding
of everything. The
space between the stories, made
visible.

The battle PAUSES.

Every person on the battlefield –
heroes, dimensional
soldiers, Epstein himself – looks up
at what the sky has
become.

Five seconds of absolute stillness.

The dimensional army stops. The heroes
stop. Everyone on
every anchor point stops.

What is in the sky is too large for
the battle to continue
without acknowledging it.

GANDALF

(in the silence; quietly; the word of a man
who has been waiting for exactly this moment
and recognizes it)

Now.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE GAUNTLET STATION — THE RESET

Joseph picks up the Gauntlet.

He looks across the battlefield at YARA — at the
communications station, watching him. She has been
watching him for this entire engagement. She will be
watching him now.

One second.

She nods. He nods back.

He puts on the Gauntlet.

THE GAUNTLET ACTIVATES.

The structural frequency — the power built into Joseph
since Earth-2397, the dimensional resonance that has been
part of him since the canyon, the forge, the blade —
begins to RESONATE with the Gauntlet's architecture.

It doesn't look like a traditional power manifestation.
There is no glow, no visible energy. It looks like a man
standing very still while the world around him becomes
more correct than it was before he put on the Gauntlet.

The Gauntlet GLOWS — not gold, not silver, not any color
that has been described before in this story. The color of
things being completed. Not finished — completed. The
difference is everything.

The dimensional architecture RESPONDS.

Every fracture line — every one of Epstein's designed fractures, all sixteen completed anchor points, every leakage point in New York and beyond, every corruption in Earth-Prime's membrane that has been building for weeks — they begin to REVERSE.

Not violently. Not dramatically. The way a tide turns: deliberately, inevitably, the patient return of something that was always going to come back, because the thing that left was not gone — it was only elsewhere, waiting.

JOSEPH

(holding very still; through the effort of channeling everything he has into the Gauntlet's architecture)

Walter. Is it working?

WALTER

(watching the display; his voice doing something it almost never does)

It's — yes. The reset is propagating. Every fracture line simultaneously. The Weezy Gold is binding the reversal across all sixteen points at once.

He looks at Joseph.

WALTER

(two words; everything)

It's working.

The Gauntlet glows brighter. The frequency intensifies. Joseph is pouring everything he has into this — not dramatically, not visibly, but in the way that the most significant expenditures are never dramatic: quietly,

completely, until there is nothing
left to pour.

Epstein watches it happen.

He watches the fracture lines
reversing. He watches his
plan unwinding – not destroyed;
unwound, thread by thread,
with the same patience and precision
with which it was
constructed. As if someone is playing
the tape backward.
As if time, on the dimensional level,
is being asked to
remember what it was before.

His expression doesn't collapse.
Jeffrey Epstein is not a
man whose expression collapses.

But something in it – finally, after
everything, after a
lifetime of arranging what he shows
and holding what he
doesn't – reveals itself.

EPSTEIN

(watching the reset propagate; very quietly;
genuinely)

I see it now.

He looks at Joseph.

EPSTEIN

I should have accounted for the
variable I had never encountered.

He is quiet for a moment.

EPSTEIN

(one final time; precise; the word that cost the most)

Someone who was capable. And was also — good.

He looks at the sky.

At the dimensional membrane returning to coherence. At his design being unmade. At the chandelier crystals of his plan, one by one, losing their light.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE CONVERGENCE POINT — THE ARRIVALS

Then — something ARRIVES.

From above. From the direction of the healing dimensional membrane. Two PRESENCES that came through the gaps in the fracture lines before they healed — things that waited at the edge of everything and chose this exact moment to come through.

The two unidentified signals. The old, old signatures that Epstein's Lieutenant identified three weeks ago and couldn't explain. That exist outside any dimensional framework that has been mapped.

Everyone in Central Park stops.

Epstein stops.

The PRESENCES LAND — not with drama; with certainty, which is more powerful than drama and always has been.

IRON MAN (ROBERT DOWNEY JR. — but not the version we last saw; not the one who snapped; not the one who said 'I am Iron Man' and ended one chapter. Something else, from somewhere between the dimensions, where things that were spent do not always remain spent; where things that were given do not always stay given; where the architecture of sacrifice is more complex than any physics we have for it. The suit: built from the same dimensional-resonant alloy as the Gauntlet. Iron Man built for exactly this return from exactly that cost).

And BATMAN (BEN AFFLECK — the Dark Knight as he is when all the calculation has resolved and what remains is the pure function of the world's greatest detective in the only moment that has ever truly mattered to him).

They land.

The assembled force goes completely still.

DEADPOOL

(involuntarily; before he can stop it)

Oh. Oh COME ON.

To camera. His voice has something in it that it doesn't always have.

DEADPOOL

Come ON.

Every hero on the battlefield reacts the way people react to the return of what was thought beyond returning. Not with cheering. With the specific silence of people who have been holding themselves together and just found that holding became, unexpectedly, easier. The way a weight you've been carrying for a long time suddenly, for no reason you can explain, weighs less.

Epstein looks at Tony Stark.

EPSTEIN

(the first genuine surprise we have ever heard from him; the first time the composure fails not from calculation but from genuine encounter with the unexpected)

You're — you should be —

IRON MAN

(faceplate up; Tony Stark underneath; older, or perhaps not older but more – with the quality of a man who went somewhere very far and came back with the only thing worth bringing back)

Yeah. I know what I should be.

IRON MAN

(looking at Epstein)
Spent a while in the spaces
between. You learn things out
there. The main thing you learn
is: what matters.

He looks at Joseph.

IRON MAN

(the teacher recognizing the student who has become something more than the teacher expected; the recognition that doesn't require performance because it is the real thing)

You built something real.

JOSEPH

The reset needs –

IRON MAN

I know what it needs.

IRON MAN

Bruce?

BATMAN

(already analyzing the situation at speed)

The frequency disruption.
Epstein's override is still active
— the failsafe he built into the
cascade architecture to prevent
exactly this kind of reversal. We
need to isolate it from the
Gauntlet's core band before the
propagation reaches the inner
network layers.

BATMAN
(to Joseph)

Hold it at ninety-one percent. Do
not push past ninety-one until I
tell you.

JOSEPH

Understood.

Batman moves to the calibration
station. He looks at the
readout. He understands it in
approximately four seconds,
because he is Bruce Wayne and
understanding complex
systems under extreme pressure is the
one specific
activity his entire life has prepared
him for.

BATMAN

Your isolation protocol — this
section here —

WALTER

The dimensional buffer layer, yes.

BATMAN

If we expand the buffer around the core frequency before the override disrupts further, we protect the Weezy Gold from the override's interference. The override expects the carrier to be unshielded. Shielding it changes the signature enough that the failsafe doesn't recognize what it's looking for.

WALTER

Yes. Yes, that's —

He is already implementing it.

WALTER

Three minutes.

BATMAN

Two.

Walter looks at him.

BATMAN

(exactly)

Two.

Walter works. Batman stands at his shoulder. This is what two of the most exceptional minds in any universe look like when pointed at the same problem from the same direction. The override has no answer for this. It is just a matter of time.

Tony Stark crosses the distance to Epstein. Not to fight.
To talk.

IRON MAN

I read your work. The dimensional architecture design. The cascade planning. It was extraordinary. I mean that without qualification.

EPSTEIN

You came back from death to compliment my engineering?

IRON MAN

I came back because someone here needed to see what comes after the thing you sacrifice for.

A pause.

EPSTEIN

(something shifting inside him; the specific shifting of a man who has designed against emotion for a very long time and is encountering something that doesn't respond to the design)

And what does come after?

IRON MAN

(no armor in his voice; no performance; just the man)

You get to see what you built survive without you. If you built it right.

He looks at the Park. The heroes. Joseph with the Gauntlet.

IRON MAN

(quietly)

The question is: what did you
build this for?

Epstein looks at the override in his
hand. He looks at the
reset propagating at ninety-one
percent – held there,
waiting. He looks at Tony Stark, who
died for people he
loved, and came back to find that what
he died for
survived him.

Something in Epstein – the specific
thing, the deep thing,
the thing that has no strategic name –
moves.

EPSTEIN

(very quietly; the private voice from the
private study; the voice underneath the
performance)

I wanted them to recognize it. The
capability. The design. The –

He stops. He looks at his hand.

IRON MAN

Recognition isn't love, Jeffrey.
And love isn't power. But it's the
only thing that outlasts the
power. Everything I built –
everything I protected with the
suit and the weapons and the
technology – what lasted wasn't
the technology. What lasted was
the people I used it for.

EPSTEIN

Is that what's on the other side?
What you found out there?

IRON MAN

(very quietly; the truth)
That's a significant part of it.

A long silence.

Epstein looks at the override for a very long time. The battle has stopped. The dimensional army withdrawn by Kronos, who read the situation on the ground and made his own calculation. The fracture lines at ninety-one percent healed.

Epstein stands in the middle of everything he built and everything it cost and everything it is in the process of being unmade.

He looks at Joseph, who has held ninety-one percent for four minutes without moving, the structural frequency spending itself to hold the reset stable, the frequency that will not exist after this is over pouring into the architecture of the reversal.

He looks at Walter and Batman at the calibration station – two minutes and counting.

He looks at the heroes, standing, not attacking. Waiting.

He looks at Tony Stark.

EPSTEIN

If I disengage the override and
let it complete. What happens to
me?

IRON MAN

(honest)

That's not up to me.

EPSTEIN

(at Joseph)

Is it up to him?

IRON MAN

It's up to what you built. Not the
cascade — the choice. What you do
next is what you build from here.

A pause. A very long one. Epstein
holds the override.

He looks at the sky. At the
dimensional membrane returning
— ninety-one percent healed. At the
gold fading as the
architecture of the multiverse seals
back behind its
membrane.

He disengages the override.

WALTER

(at the calibration station; immediately)

The override frequency is gone.
Isolation protocol complete.

BATMAN

Override is clear. The buffer is

holding. You have a clean path to
full propagation.

WALTER

Joseph — now. Push it through.
Now.

JOSEPH

(closing his eyes; pushing the structural
frequency through the Gauntlet at full
capacity — spending it completely; giving
everything that remains; the last of it; all
of it)

NOW.

THE GAUNTLET IGNITES.

Not a pulse — a PROPAGATION.

The full reset, complete — every fracture line on Earth-
Prime healing simultaneously, the dimensional membrane
returning to its native coherence, the Weezy Gold binding
every element of the reversal into a permanent
architectural fix that will outlast everyone in this park
and their children and their children's children.

The sky above Central Park —

— returns.

Not to the wrong sky. Not to the shimmer. Not to the
metallic trees and the wrong shadows.

To the right sky.

Blue. Vast. Ordinary. Perfect.

The metallic leaves RELEASE their shimmer. Just leaves.
Just green. Just the specific green of Central Park on a
particular afternoon.

The Bethesda Angel — the shimmer gone. Bronze. Art. Old
and patient and still there.

New York is New York.

The multiverse is intact.

SOUND: Nothing.

Then: what silence sounds like when it is earned.

Then: one by one – starting with the people on the anchor points, who have been holding the hardest and holding the longest – the heroes release the breath they have been holding. Not all at once. One by one. The specific sound of an enormous collective exhale, distributed across a city, moving outward from Central Park like a wave.

DEADPOOL

(after about ten seconds; to camera; his voice cracks in a way he would deny if asked about it)

Okay. That was – okay.

DEADPOOL

– that was something.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Joseph. All sixteen anchor points confirming restored coherence. The cascade is fully reversed. Membrane integrity at –

SEIKO (O.S.)

One hundred percent.

SEIKO (O.S.)

One hundred percent, Joseph.

A pause.

A beat.

JOSEPH is on his knees.

The Gauntlet is dark. His hands are empty.

The structural frequency is gone. He can feel its absence the way you feel the absence of something that has been part of you for so long its removal is a negative space in the exact shape of the thing.

He opens and closes his hands.

He is still Joseph. He is still here. He is simply himself, now, without the dimensional resonance.

He is himself.

Walter kneels beside him.

WALTER
(quietly)

It's done.

JOSEPH

Is the reset complete?

WALTER

Complete. Permanent.
Architecturally sound. The Weezy Gold secondary reinforcement means the correction will hold indefinitely. I am using that word precisely.

Joseph looks at his hands. He opens and closes them.

JOSEPH

(to his hands; the truth of it settling; not loss, not grief – okay. Acceptance. The real kind.)

Okay.

He looks up.

YARA is there. She has crossed the Park. She is on her knees beside him. She puts her hands around his. She doesn't say anything.

He looks at her.

JOSEPH

(the first real breath)

Hey.

YARA

(the first real breath back)

Hey.

JOSEPH

I'm still here.

YARA

Yes you are.

JOSEPH

No powers. But –

YARA

But you're here.

JOSEPH

Yeah.

She helps him to his feet. They stand.

The park around them – the heroes, the
aftermath, the
healed sky – everything goes slightly
soft around the
edges because this moment is private
even with a hundred
people watching.

JOSEPH

(for her alone)

Take me somewhere ordinary.

YARA

(the real smile; the smile that has nothing
strategic in it)

I promised.

He leans his forehead against hers.

The battle is over.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK – THE AFTERMATH – CONTINUOUS

The slow return. Heroes from the anchor points, moving
back toward the Park. The specific transition from the
enormous thing back to the ordinary world that always
comes after – the gap between the action and the meaning
of the action.

BUTCHER – face still bloody – walking across the Park. He
stops when he reaches Wolverine. They stand together
looking at the right sky.

BUTCHER

That it, then?

WOLVERINE

That's it.

A pause.

BUTCHER

You're going to be around for a while, I take it.

WOLVERINE

Longer than most.

BUTCHER

Right. Don't know how you do it.

WOLVERINE

You get used to the parts you can.
The rest —

BUTCHER

(already walking)

— you carry. Yeah. I know about that.

PAUL ATREIDES and CHANI finding each other.

CHANI

The visions were right.

PAUL

They're never completely right.
They're the shape of the
possibility. We fill in the rest.

CHANI

Most of us are still here.

PAUL

Most of us. That's what we were
fighting for.

ELEVEN at the edge of the fountain.
Diana sits beside her.
Not talking. Just beside her.

DIANA

You're not afraid.

ELEVEN

I'm always afraid. That's not the
same as not doing it.

Diana looks at her.

DIANA

No. It is not. Who taught you
that?

ELEVEN

A friend. He's gone. I carry it
for him now.

Diana is quiet for a moment.

DIANA

I've been carrying things for
people who are gone for a very

long time. The weight doesn't get lighter. But you get stronger.

ELEVEN

Are you strong enough?

DIANA

(almost smiling)

Let's find out.

RYAN — seventeen, at the edge of the group, looking at the right sky. Quietly at peace with a complicated thing.

LUKE SKYWALKER approaches. Sits.

LUKE

You know who I thought about today? When it got hardest? My father. Not the good memories. The complicated ones. I thought: he chose. In the end, he chose. Even after everything.

RYAN

I chose not to.

LUKE

Same thing. That's the hardest version of it.

RYAN

Does it ever feel simpler?

LUKE

No. But you stop needing it to.

Joseph moves through the park. He stops at each group – not as a director, not as a coordinator. Just as a person, taking a moment with each of the people who chose to be here.

THOR in the grass – on his back, looking at the right sky, Mjolnir beside him. Completely at peace.

JOSEPH
How are you, Thor?

THOR
I am looking at the correct sky. This is pleasing to me.

JOSEPH
Yes. It is.

THOR
The fracture line is healed. I can feel it in Mjolnir. There is no longer resistance at the East River.
No.

JOSEPH

THOR
Good. I was beginning to find the resistance tedious.

JOSEPH

Thank you, Thor. For being here.

THOR

You asked honestly. That is worth
more than you know.

JOSEPH

You answered. That's worth more.

STEVE ROGERS on a bench. His notebook.
Still writing
names.

JOSEPH

Steve.

STEVE ROGERS

(looking up)

Joseph.

A pause. Two men who understand
something about the weight
of being the person others follow and
the specific
loneliness of that position.

JOSEPH

Thank you.

STEVE ROGERS

What for?

JOSEPH

For not needing to understand
everything before you committed to
it.

STEVE ROGERS

I've found that the things worth
committing to rarely explain
themselves in advance.

JOSEPH

That's - yes. That's exactly it.

STEVE ROGERS

How are you feeling?

JOSEPH

Like something ended. And
something else started. And I
don't know what the something else
is yet.

STEVE ROGERS

That's usually how beginnings
feel.

GANDALF near the tree line. Pipe,
finally lit. The
specific contentment of a man who has
been waiting to
light that pipe for a long time and
has finally earned it.

Joseph stops beside him.

JOSEPH

Gandalf.

GANDALF

Joseph.

They stand together. The park around them.

GANDALF

I have been alive for an impractical amount of time. I have seen many things begin and end. And I have found that the things worth remembering are not the battles. They are moments like this one – after the battle, in the park, in the late afternoon, with the right sky above.

JOSEPH

What makes this worth remembering?

GANDALF

The fact that you are asking the question. The fact that you are here to ask it. The fact that –

He gestures at the Park. At the healed world. At the assembled force.

GANDALF

– all of this exists. Not because it was inevitable. Because people chose it.

JOSEPH

We held.

GANDALF

Yes. You held.

They stand in the park, in the late afternoon, in the right world.

GANDALF

(very quietly; to no one; to all of it)

Good.

Eventually Joseph reaches Yara. She is sitting alone, looking at the sky. He sits beside her. A long quiet.

YARA

How do you feel?

JOSEPH

Tired. Very tired. And something else. I'm still working out what to call it.

YARA

It's what happens when something works. When the thing you put everything into actually works.

JOSEPH

Does it happen often?

YARA

I don't know. I've never done anything this large before. But I've felt it in smaller things. In a village that's still standing. In a person who made it through.

JOSEPH

I don't think I let myself feel it before. I was always already thinking about the next thing.

YARA

What's the next thing now?

JOSEPH

I don't know yet. Something smaller. Something that only matters to me.

She looks at him.

They sit in the park, in the late afternoon, in the space between an enormous thing and whatever comes next.

BATMAN watches from the edge of the park. Very good at watching. A little less good at this specific feeling – the feeling of a thing being worth having, not just worth protecting. He is working on it.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS – THE DEPARTURES – THAT NIGHT

The heroes leaving. Over hours, portals opening in the departures hall, each one taking someone home.

THOR clasps Joseph's arm.

THOR

You asked honestly. That is worth more than you know.

JOSEPH

You answered. That's worth more.

Thor looks at him. Nods once. He steps through his portal.

DIANA before leaving.

DIANA

The girl. Eleven. She is extraordinary. In the specific way that people are who have survived things no one should survive and built themselves out of what remained.

JOSEPH

I know.

DIANA

Watch over her if you can.

JOSEPH

I will.

Diana takes his hand, briefly, in both of hers.

DIANA

Well done, Director al-Mithali.

She goes.

WALTER WHITE is last. He stands before his portal with the patience of a man who has one thing left to say and is taking the time to say it correctly.

WALTER

The Gauntlet. The architectural permanence of the reset — I ran the projection eight times. The

membrane will hold indefinitely.
Indefinitely is not a word I use
with precision often. I am using
it precisely.

JOSEPH

Thank you, Walter.

WALTER

(with the care of someone who has checked
this and is satisfied)

Yes. I did.

He holds out his hand. Joseph shakes
it.

WALTER

Get some sleep.

He goes through the portal. It closes.

Joseph stands alone in the departures
hall. He is without
powers. He is standing. He is here. He
is exactly enough.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — JOSEPH'S OFFICE — NIGHT

Joseph at his desk. Not working. IRON MAN — Tony Stark,
suit off, civilian clothes — leans in the doorway.

JOSEPH

You're still here.

TONY

Hour or two. I have to — go back.

JOSEPH

Back.

TONY

To wherever. It's not bad. There are people there. People I wanted to see.

He comes into the office. He looks at the photograph of Yara.

He sits.

TONY

She's important to you.

JOSEPH

Everything.

TONY

(knowing this completely)

Yeah.

TONY

The Gauntlet — it was elegant. The structural frequency didn't just initiate it. It informed it. The design of the reset carried your specific capacity for caring about getting it right. Not power. Intention. The Gauntlet did what it did because of what you put into it. Which was everything.

JOSEPH

The loss of the powers —

TONY

Doesn't empty the Gauntlet. What was in it is in the world now. Permanently. The reset carries it. Every healed fracture line, every restored membrane layer — it's threaded with what you gave it. That doesn't go away when you do.

He stands.

Tony.

Yeah?

JOSEPH

TONY

JOSEPH

Why did you come back?

Tony looks at him.

TONY

Because the kid needed the teacher. And because — I needed to see what it looked like when someone built the right thing for the right reasons.

He looks at the photograph of Yara.

TONY

I didn't always do that. I built things for the right reasons eventually. But 'eventually' costs a lot.

He looks at Joseph.

TONY

You always did. From the start.
That's - rarer than you know.

He puts his hand on Joseph's shoulder.

TONY

Take care of your family. Take
care of your people. And do
something boring for a while.
You've earned it.

He goes. The door closes.

JOSEPH

(very quietly; to himself; to the empty
room)

Something boring.

He almost smiles.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE BETHESDA FOUNTAIN — LATE NIGHT

BATMAN stands at the fountain. Not in the suit. Bruce
Wayne, dark jacket, hands in his pockets, looking at the
water.

Joseph approaches. They stand together.

JOSEPH

You could have gone with the
others.

BATMAN

I know.

JOSEPH

Why didn't you?

BATMAN

Because I needed to see it with the suit off. What you defended. Without the armor. The armor is very good at most things. But it's not good at this.

BATMAN

You and I are different kinds of people. You lead from the center — from the actual center, with the people around you. I lead from the perimeter. I've always led from the perimeter.

JOSEPH

There's value in the perimeter.

BATMAN

Yes. But there's also — this thing you have. Where the people who came here for you aren't just troops. They're the reason. I'm working on that.

JOSEPH

I think you're better at it than you know.

BATMAN

I'm going to stay for a while. If that's acceptable.

JOSEPH

The MPA could use someone who understands tactical problems under pressure.

BATMAN

(the closest Bruce Wayne gets to a smile)

I've had some practice.

They stand at the fountain. The right sky. The right world.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SEIKO'S COMMAND CENTER

The dimensional membrane of Earth-Prime: intact. One hundred percent coherence.

Seiko stands in the middle of the room, tablet in hand, reading the numbers one final time.

He puts the tablet down.

He stands there for a moment. He isn't used to putting the tablet down. He does it anyway.

SEIKO

(to the room; a fact, not an announcement)

It's over.

A pause.

SEIKO

Earth-Prime is stable. All dimensions connected to its membrane are stable. The cascade reversal is permanent. There is no structural pathway for a repeat event without a rebuilding from

scratch that would take — years.
At minimum.

A pause.

SEIKO

(quietly; the specific quiet of a man who
has just done the largest thing he has ever
been asked to do and is already thinking
about what comes next)

I'll monitor it.

DEREK

Can we — is it safe to —

SEIKO

Go home, Derek.

DEREK

(the specific relief of someone told they
can stop holding)

Yeah. Okay. Yeah.

He goes. One by one, the room empties.
Seiko stands in it
alone. He looks at the coherence
numbers. One hundred
percent.

He looks at his empty hand where the tablet was. He sits
down. Just sits. In the chair. In the room. He has not
done this in a long time. He sits. He closes his eyes. In
less than thirty seconds, he is asleep.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THREE MONTHS LATER

New York. Right. Normal. The specific aliveness of a city
that has been through something and emerged from it.

Joseph and Yara walk through the park. No comm units. No tablets. No crisis. Just walking.

YARA

The tribunal verdict is next month.

JOSEPH

I know.

YARA

How do you think it'll go?

JOSEPH

He disengaged the override in the final moment. The tribunal will want to understand why.

YARA

What will you tell them?

JOSEPH

The truth. That he made a choice at the last possible moment. That it costs nothing to dismiss it. And that it might cost something important not to understand it.

YARA

You're going to argue for him.

JOSEPH

I'm going to argue for the truth of what happened.

YARA

You always do.

They walk. The park around them – just
the park, just the
morning.

Joseph stops.

JOSEPH

Yara.

She stops. He takes her hands.

JOSEPH

I don't have the powers anymore. I
have the work. I have the team. I
have this city and this park and
this morning.

He looks at her.

JOSEPH

And I have you, if you'll have me.
Not the director with the
frequency. Just – me.

YARA

Just you.

JOSEPH

Just me.

A pause.

YARA

Yes, Joseph. Just you.

He looks at her. She looks at him. The
park around them.
The ordinary, extraordinary morning.

EXT. NEW YORK CITY — THE WEDDING — SIX MONTHS LATER

Not a large ceremony. This is Joseph and Yara, who both understand the value of the right people over the right number of them. But the people.

SEIKO — in a suit; tablet absent; the quality of someone who decided this was worth being completely present for. He is, for perhaps the first time in anyone's memory, simply here.

THE BOYS — Butcher in a jacket that fits better than anyone expected. Hughie and Annie together, Annie's hand in Hughie's, the specific ease of two people who have been through enough together that ease is no longer something they have to create. M.M. with his daughter, who is looking at everything with the wide eyes of a child at an event she knows is important. Frenchie and Kimiko.

RYAN — seventeen, in the back, quietly happy in the way of someone who has made peace with a complicated thing and found that peace looks like this.

THOR — out of the armor; looking delighted in the way a god looks when he finds a mortal celebration that has the specific quality of worth.

BATMAN — dark suit, in the back. He is practicing being present rather than perimetral. He is getting better at it.

GANDALF — staff leaning against the wall; the expression of a man who has been to a great many events across a very long life and has learned to recognize the ones that matter.

STRANGE — in his good suit. The Cloak of Levitation is not present. For Strange, this constitutes genuine sentiment.

WALTER — present, upright, with the expression of a man

attending a significant event who will not use any word stronger than 'appropriate' but who is, in fact, moved.

JESSE — next to Walter. Crying openly. Not trying to hide it.

KRONOS — in the far corner, uncertain about his right to be here, having come anyway because Joseph used a specific word when he invited him: invited.

The ceremony. Joseph and Yara at the center of all of it — at the center of the team and the community that was built through everything that happened.

They say the words. The simple words. The very old words that remain the most precise language available for the specific thing they mean.

JOSEPH

(looking at her)

Yes.

YARA

(looking at him)

Yes.

LARRY THE WATCHER — visible, barely, at the far edge of the room. Almost translucent. Almost not there. He is watching. He is smiling. He didn't know he could do that. He will remember this one. In three thousand years, in forty thousand universes, he will remember this one.

T H E E P I L O G U E

TITLE CARD: "One Year Later"

**EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE BETHESDA FOUNTAIN — GOLDEN
AFTERNOON**

Autumn. The specific autumn of Central Park that painters have tried and largely failed to adequately render.

The trees are the right height. No metallic shimmer. Just trees. The Angel of the Waters presides over the fountain with the dignity of bronze in afternoon light. No shimmer. No dimensional echo. Just art. Just bronze. Just the specific quality of a thing that has been standing in this park for over a hundred and fifty years and intends to keep standing.

The fountain runs. The water moves.

Joseph and Yara sit on the edge of the fountain, her hand in his. Just sitting. For Joseph, still something he is learning to be good at.

Seiko approaches. Tablet in his right hand — he will always have the tablet. But in his left hand: an extra coffee, brought without being asked, handed to Joseph without ceremony.

SEIKO

Membrane coherence: one hundred
and two percent.

JOSEPH

Is that even possible?

SEIKO

The Weezy Gold reinforcement
continues to stabilize. We're in
territory without prior data. It's
possible because it's happening.

JOSEPH

Thank you.

A pause. The fountain running. The
autumn park around
them.

SEIKO

I've been thinking about a new
monitoring protocol. The secondary
reinforcement has properties that
suggest we could configure it as
an active early-warning system for
dimensional stress.

JOSEPH

Seiko. It's a Sunday.

SEIKO

I know. I'm just — mentioning it.

YARA

(without looking up)

Write it up. Bring it to Monday's
meeting.

SEIKO

(with the faintest quality of someone who
has just been told exactly what he wanted to
hear and is pretending not to be pleased)

Yes. I will.

He looks at the fountain. At the right
sky. At the city
around them — just the city, just the
afternoon, just the

specific ordinary-extraordinary
quality of a world that is
still here.

SEIKO

(very quietly)

We held.

Yes.

JOSEPH

SEIKO

I ran the numbers. Forty-seven
times while it was happening. The
probability of the outcome we
achieved was —

JOSEPH

I know.

SEIKO

Very low.

JOSEPH

I know.

SEIKO

I don't know how to model what
made it work. The choosing. I have
no algorithm for the choosing.

JOSEPH

No. You don't model it. You just

ask. And then you trust.

SEIKO

That is a very imprecise system.

JOSEPH

Yes.

SEIKO

It worked.

Yes.

JOSEPH

SEIKO

(almost to himself)

I'll keep looking for a better
one.

JOSEPH

(looking at him; with something very close
to the thing he almost never allows on his
face)

I know you will.

The fountain runs. The autumn park.
The right sky. The
three of them in the ordinary
afternoon, in the specific
grace of a world that was nearly
something else and chose
— collectively, improbably, through
the weight of
uncountable individual choices — to
remain itself.

A NEWSPAPER blows past. The headline
visible for half a
second:

"MPA MARKS ONE YEAR SINCE THE CONVERGENCE"

"Director al-Mithali: 'We Hold.'"

The newspaper tumbles on. The city moves. Just the city.
Just the afternoon. Just the world.

HOLD.

HOLD.

INT. THE OUTER DARK — EPSTEIN'S DOMAIN — EMPTY

FADE TO BLACK.

The dining room: abandoned. The table: cleared. The
chandelier turns, slowly, in a void that is no longer
anyone's domain — just space. Just the dark between
dimensions.

One last prism from the crystal drops — gold, a brief arc
across the tablecloth.

Then it fades. The chandelier stills. The room is empty.

SOUND: Silence.

Then the oud. One note. The note it has been playing since
the beginning, resolved at last into something that sounds
like: enough.

FADE TO BLACK.

POST-CREDITS

INT. AN UNREMARKABLE OFFICE — SOMEWHERE

A desk. A laptop. Standard furniture that could be anywhere. Standard lighting. Standard view from a standard window onto a standard city.

KRONOS sits at the desk. On the wall behind him: a badge.

MULTIVERSAL PROTECTION AGENCY. TEMPORAL
MONITORING

DIVISION.

He is working. Carefully. One careful hour at a time. The work of someone who has accepted that carefully and slowly is the right speed for the kind of person he is trying to become.

A knock at the door.

KRONOS

Come in.

Seiko enters with a tablet. He hands it to Kronos.

SEIKO

The dimensional buffer configuration I mentioned.

Kronos looks at it. For a long time.

KRONOS
(quietly)

This is very good work.

SEIKO

(already turning to leave)

I know.

He leaves.

Kronos looks at the tablet. He looks at the badge on the wall. He thinks of what he was before this. Of what he is now. The difference between the two is: a choice, made at the last possible moment. He is not sure, yet, what all the implications of that choice are. He intends to find out.

He turns back to the desk. He gets to work.

FADE TO BLACK.

"From one weakness was born infinite power."

FOR SEIKO TOAST.

The best friend anyone ever had.

FINAL FADE TO BLACK.

T H E E N D

Film One	— The Ambush and the Forging:	~115 minutes
Film Two	— The Call — Shadow Knowledge:	~72 minutes
Film Three	— All Heroes Rise:	~163 minutes

TOTAL: ~350 minutes / 5 hours 50 minutes

**INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS - STAGING AREA - THE MORNING OF -
PRE-DEPLOYMENT**

The final hours before deployment. The staging area is controlled chaos - heroes from every dimension, every timeline, every possible background finding their positions, checking their equipment, doing what people do before the thing that requires everything they have.

THOR stands in a corner, eyes closed. He does not look like someone preparing for battle. He looks like someone listening to something very far away.

LOGAN approaches. Stands beside him. Says nothing.

After a long moment:

THOR

You've done this many times.

WOLVERINE

More than I can count.

THOR

Does it become familiar?

WOLVERINE

The waiting? No. You'd think it would. Doesn't.

THOR

I have fought in battles that lasted three days. I have fought in battles that lasted thirty years. The waiting before each one was the same.

WOLVERINE

What is it for you? The waiting.

THOR

The specific question: will this be the one? The one where it doesn't work. The one where the strength isn't enough. Where the lightning doesn't find its answer.

WOLVERINE

And?

THOR

And I have always found that the question does not survive contact with the battle. Once it begins, the question is gone. There is only what is needed and whether I can provide it.

WOLVERINE

Yeah.

THOR

It returns, after. When the battle is done and there is time to examine what happened.

WOLVERINE

Then you have the other question.

THOR

Yes.

WOLVERINE

What did it cost.

THOR

Yes.

A long quiet. The staging area around them – activity and preparation and the specific heightened quality of people who are about to do something that will require everything they have.

WOLVERINE

For what it's worth – I've fought beside a lot of people. This is a good group.

THOR

Yes. It is a very good group.

WOLVERINE

Ninety-seven people who said yes to an honest ask. That's – that's not something you see often.

THOR

No. In my experience – no.

WOLVERINE

Whatever happens after. That part is good. That part is worth something.

Thor opens his eyes. He looks at the staging area. At the assembled force.

THOR

Yes. It is worth a great deal.

He picks up Mjolnir. He goes to find his position.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — DIANA AND ELEVEN — PRE-DEPLOYMENT

A quiet corner of the staging area. Diana is doing what she always does before a battle: checking her equipment with the methodical attention of someone who has been doing this for three thousand years and has not once decided that skipping the check is acceptable.

El watches her. She has been watching Diana since she arrived. With the specific attention of someone who recognizes in another person something they are trying to understand in themselves.

ELEVEN

You've done this a lot.

DIANA

A very great deal.

ELEVEN

And you're still — you're not afraid.

DIANA

I am always afraid. What you're observing is not the absence of fear. It is the presence of something else as well.

What?

ELEVEN

DIANA

Purpose. The fear and the purpose exist simultaneously. The fear does not eliminate the purpose. The purpose does not eliminate the fear. They coexist.

ELEVEN

That doesn't sound comfortable.

DIANA

It isn't. But discomfort and effectiveness are not mutually exclusive.

El watches her check the shield.

ELEVEN

I've been alone for most of this. The scouting. The substrate mapping. Fourteen days in the Upside Down parallel. It was — I was afraid the whole time. But the purpose was clear.

DIANA

What was the purpose?

ELEVEN

To bring back something that could help. To use what I can do for something that needed it.

DIANA

That is a clear purpose.

ELEVEN

It was enough to keep going. But
it was still lonely.

DIANA

Yes. Working alone is often
lonely. Even when the purpose is
sufficient.

ELEVEN

Does it get less lonely?

DIANA

When you find people who are
working toward the same thing?
Yes. Significantly.

El looks at the staging area. At the
assembled force.)

ELEVEN

This is the most people I've been
with who are working toward the
same thing.

DIANA

Yes. It's unusual in scale. Less
unusual in kind. The specific
quality of a group aligned around
a shared honest purpose — I've
encountered it before. At smaller
scales. But the quality is the
same.

ELEVEN

What does it feel like? The
quality.

DIANA

Like —

She pauses. She looks for the word.

DIANA

Like the thing you've been
carrying alone has somewhere to be
set down. Not abandoned. Set down
in a shared place where others can
also hold it.

ELEVEN

That's — yes. That's what it feels
like.

DIANA

Good. Remember that feeling. It is
useful.

ELEVEN

For what?

DIANA

For after. When the battle is done
and the extraordinary circumstance
has ended and you have to figure
out what the ordinary looks like
now. The feeling of the shared
purpose — it helps you find the
ordinary on the other side.

El looks at her.

ELEVEN

You've thought about this a lot.

DIANA

I've had three thousand years. One accumulates thoughts.

El almost smiles. Diana, watching, almost smiles back.

DIANA

Whatever happens today. You have already done something extraordinary. The fourteen days. The maps. The substrate routing that no one else could have provided. That's already done. Already real. It doesn't go away regardless of what comes next.

ELEVEN

I know.

DIANA

Good. Hold onto that too. The 'already real' things are useful anchors.

She finishes checking the shield. She stands. She looks at El.

DIANA

Are you ready?

ELEVEN

I don't know how to tell if I'm ready.

DIANA

Nor does anyone. That's why we go anyway.

CUT TO:

EXT. NEW YORK — ANCHOR POINTS — BATTLE INTERCUTTING

The battle in full. RAPID INTERCUTTING between all sixteen anchor points as the cascade accelerates:

THOR at the East River, holding the fracture line alone against forty-three dimensional soldiers. Mjolnir a constant presence — not weapon but expression, lightning following the hammer's will through the specific mathematics of conflict. He is, in this moment, exactly what the word 'warrior' was invented to describe.

THOR

(into comm; not complaining; stating a fact)

I note that there are forty-three of them and one of me.

SEIKO (O.S.)

I know. I'm diverting six from Hawkeye's position. They'll reach you in ninety seconds.

THOR

Ninety seconds is a long time.

SEIKO (O.S.)

I know. Are you managing?

THOR

I am managing. Ninety seconds is a long time but I am managing.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Good.

STEVE ROGERS at the Northern anchor. He is very good at this. Not because he is invincible — he is far from invincible — but because he has been doing this for so long that the mechanics of it are no longer the main occupation of his attention. The mechanics are automatic. His attention is on the team. On M.M.'s position to his left. On Shuri's tech array, which is doing three things he doesn't fully understand and which he trusts completely.

SHURI

Northern fracture is holding. I need you four meters to the left.

STEVE ROGERS

Moving.

He moves. The positions shift. The fracture holds.

SHURI

The Stark protocols are working. They're reading us as low-priority.

STEVE ROGERS

For how long?

SHURI

Until they figure out we're not.

Eight minutes. Maybe twelve.

STEVE ROGERS

Then we have eight minutes to make this count.

SHURI

I'm making it count. You just need to stand in the right place.

STEVE ROGERS

I'm very good at standing in the right place.

SHURI

I know. That's why I put you there.

PAUL ATREIDES and CHANI at Battery Park. The dimensional army hitting the southern fracture in waves — each wave larger than the last, as if whatever is directing the army is recalculating and sending more each time.

The Fremmen respond to each wave the way they respond to sandstorms: by becoming part of the environment. By using the terrain. By making the dimensional soldiers fight a battle they didn't expect to fight against opponents who have been preparing for exactly this their entire lives.

CHANI
(subtitled)

Third wave incoming. Larger than the second.

PAUL
(subtitled)

The fourth will be larger than the

third. They're learning our pattern.

CHANI
(subtitled)

Then we change the pattern.

PAUL
(subtitled)
Yes. Stilgar -

STILGAR
(subtitled)

Already adjusting. New formation in three.

The formation shifts before the third wave arrives. The wave hits a different shape than it expected. It is less effective. The Fremmen know how to make things be less effective.

BUTCHER'S TEAM at the Western anchor - the worst position. Butcher knows it's the worst position. He chose it.

BUTCHER

Frenchie. The thing you built this morning.

FRENCHIE

The dimensional suppressor? It's ready. I'm not sure it will work.

BUTCHER

Will it definitely not work?

FRENCHIE

Definitely not work? No. I can't say definitely.

BUTCHER

Then use it.

Frenchie uses it. The dimensional suppressor does work — not in the way he designed it, but in an adjacent way that turns out to be more useful. This is how Frenchie's devices usually work.

FRENCHIE

Mon dieu. It's working.

KIMIKO

(signed; translated)

Use it again.

FRENCHIE

Yes. Yes, absolutely.

BUTCHER

Good. M.M., cascade at what?

M.M.

Thirty-seven. It's accelerating.

BUTCHER

Right. Everyone hold what you've got and give me a shout when it hits thirty-nine.

JEAN GREY — managing the telepathic field from above the battle, finding the frequencies that disrupt the dimensional soldiers' coordination without affecting the heroes. It requires the kind of precision that exhausts even her. She is excellent at it anyway.

STRANGE

(into comm)

Jean. The eastern cluster is augmented — they're filtering the field.

JEAN

I know. I'm modulating. Give me ninety seconds.

STRANGE

You have ninety seconds.

She modulates. The eastern cluster's coordination drops.
Logan is there in forty of the ninety seconds.

DEADPOOL managing the chaos in the center of the Park with the specific tactical freedom of someone who understands that chaos is not the same as random. There is a strategy here. It is not a strategy that would appear in any tactical manual. It works anyway.

DEADPOOL

(while dispatching four soldiers; to camera)

For the record – and I'm speaking
to the record here –

DEADPOOL

This is the best day of my life.
Including my wedding. Sorry,
Vanessa.

WOLVERINE

Wade. Focus.

DEADPOOL

(dispatching two more)

I am focused. This IS my focused.

WOLVERINE

It's concerning that that's your
focused.

DEADPOOL

And yet it's working.

It is, in fact, working.

HAN and CHEWIE working the perimeter
of the Park with the
ease of veterans – identifying the
gaps in the dimensional
army's formation, the places where
concentrated pressure
will produce disproportionate results.
Han has an eye for
these. He always has.

HAN

There. The gap between the second
and third columns. Chewie – if you

hit it from the left while I take
the right -

Chewie is already moving.

HAN

See, this is why we work well
together. You don't wait for me to
finish the sentence.

Chewie responds. Han fires twice.

HAN

The gap is closed. Onto the next
gap.

JACK SPARROW doing what Jack Sparrow
does, which is to
exist in the middle of a battle in a
state of
philosophical acceptance of the chaos
that somehow
produces better tactical outcomes than
careful planning
would have. WILLIAM TURNER fighting
beside him with the
methodical precision that is the
perfect complement to
Jack's approach.

WILLIAM

Jack. To your left.

JACK

I see it.

WILLIAM

I've noticed you frequently say 'I
see it' before you actually see
it.

JACK

Yes, and then I see it. The claim
is always eventually true.

WILLIAM

The timing concerns me.

JACK

The timing has never led to a
permanent consequence. I view that
as vindication.

He deals with the threat to his left.
He had, it turns
out, seen it.

GUMBALL and DARWIN — doing impossible
things in the
confident way of people for whom
impossible things are
Tuesday. They have been here an hour
and have already
adapted completely to the rules of
live-action physics,
which are more consistent than
animated physics but less
interesting.

GUMBALL

Darwin. The thing with the lamp
post.

DARWIN

The lamp post isn't flexible in
this dimension.

GUMBALL

Everything is flexible if you
believe hard enough.

DARWIN

That is not how physics —

The lamp post bends. In a way that
lamp posts in live-
action dimensions are not supposed to
bend.

DARWIN

...I'm going to have to revise my
understanding of physics.

GUMBALL

This is what I keep saying.

SEIKO in the command center — the
steady center of all of
this, running the thing that holds
everything together.
The coordination. The adjustments. The
flow of information
from sixteen positions to a single
point and out again as
guidance.

DEREK

Seiko. Cascade at thirty-eight.

SEIKO

I know. Two minutes to completion.

DEREK

Then what?

SEIKO

Then we use the three minutes.

DEREK

Are we ready?

Seiko looks at his screens. At the sixteen positions. At the people holding each one. At Joseph, confirmed in position at the Gauntlet station.

SEIKO

We're as ready as we can be.

DEREK

That's not the same as ready.

SEIKO

No. It isn't. It's what we have.

DEREK

Is it enough?

Seiko is quiet for a moment.)

SEIKO

Yes. I believe it is enough.

He returns to the screens. He manages.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — AFTER THE RESET — EPSTEIN ALONE

The battle is over. The dimensional army withdrawn. The heroes at rest around the park. Epstein stands alone in a

park that is no longer his, in a world that is no longer the shape he intended, and looks at what the sky has become: right.

KRONOS approaches. Quietly. With the specific quality of someone who has been watching from a distance and has decided that distance is no longer the appropriate position.

EPSTEIN

You didn't close the gap.

KRONOS

No.

EPSTEIN

In the firewall. Three weeks ago. You identified the gap that the substrate routing exploited. You told me. I filed it. You could have closed it without my authorization.

KRONOS

Yes.

EPSTEIN

You didn't.

KRONOS

No.

EPSTEIN

Why?

A pause.

Kronos looks at the park. At the
heroes. At the healed
sky.

KRONOS

Because the four hundred and
twelfth version worried me.

EPSTEIN

The one where something happens
that I hadn't accounted for.

KRONOS

Yes.

EPSTEIN

You thought the unidentified
signals were that something.

KRONOS

I thought they might be. And I
thought —

He pauses. He is choosing his words
with unusual care.

KRONOS

I've worked with you for a very
long time. And the work has been
technically extraordinary. But
I've found, as the work has
progressed, that I have a growing
uncertainty about what it's for.

EPSTEIN

You know what it's for. You've always known.

KRONOS

I know the stated objective. I'm uncertain about whether the stated objective is the actual one. Or whether the actual one is something you've never stated.

EPSTEIN

And what do you think the actual one is?

KRONOS

Recognition. You want the capable ones to run things. But more specifically, you want to be recognized as the most capable one. The running of things is the evidence of the capability. The capability is what you want acknowledged.

A very long pause.

EPSTEIN

You've been thinking about this for a long time.

KRONOS

Yes. A long time.

EPSTEIN

And you didn't say anything.

KRONOS

You wouldn't have heard it before
this moment.

Epstein looks at him. At the healed
sky. At the park.

EPSTEIN

No. I wouldn't have.

KRONOS

The override. You disengaged it.

EPSTEIN

KRONOS

Yes.

Why?

A long pause. The longest we have seen
from Epstein. The
pause of a man who is accessing
something he has not
accessed before, or has not allowed
himself to access.

EPSTEIN

Because Tony Stark asked me what I
built this for. And in the moment
of being asked – in the specific
way that he asked – I couldn't
answer it. The way I normally
answer it. The answer I have used
for thirty years.

KRONOS

What is that answer?

EPSTEIN

That the capable ones should run
it. That the design was correct.
That what I built was worth
building.

KRONOS

And?

EPSTEIN

And in the moment of being asked
by someone who died for something
and came back to see if the
something survived him — in that
moment, I couldn't make the answer
work. The answer felt —
insufficient. For the first time
in thirty years, it felt like less
than what the question deserved.

Kronos looks at him.)

KRONOS

What comes next?

EPSTEIN

That's what I'm trying to
determine.

KRONOS

The tribunal will convene. The
dimensional council. They'll want
to understand what happened and
what it means for the architecture
going forward.

EPSTEIN

I know.

KRONOS

What will you tell them?

Epstein looks at the park. At the
healed sky. At the world
that exists because a hundred people
said yes to an honest
ask.

EPSTEIN

The truth. For the first time in a
very long time – the truth.

KRONOS

Which is?

EPSTEIN

That I was right about the
capability and wrong about
everything else. That I understood
what was possible and I understood
the architecture to achieve it and
I didn't understand –

He stops. He looks at the fountain. At
the Angel of the
Waters, shimmer-free now, just bronze,
just art.)

EPSTEIN

I didn't understand why. Why the
capability matters. I thought the
answer was: because it's the
highest thing. Because excellence
is its own justification.

KRONOS

And?

EPSTEIN

And al-Mithali is — capable. By any measure. But that's not why the ninety-seven showed up. They didn't show up for the capability. They showed up for the asking. For the thing underneath the capability.

KRONOS

Which is?

EPSTEIN

The reason for it. The what-it's-for. That's what I didn't build. I built the capability and left out the reason.

A long silence.

KRONOS

Jeffrey.

Yes.

EPSTEIN

KRONOS

Initiate surrender protocols. Full dimensional compliance. Let the council convene.

EPSTEIN

Yes.

He looks at the park one more time.

EPSTEIN

Kronos. Why did you not close the gap?

KRONOS

Because I wanted to see what would happen if something outside the design was allowed to reach the center. Because I thought — if the four hundred and twelfth version was real, I wanted it to be allowed to happen.

EPSTEIN

You were betting on the outside variable.

KRONOS

Yes.

EPSTEIN

You were betting against me.

KRONOS

I was betting on something larger than either of us.

Epstein looks at him for a long moment. Then, simply:

EPSTEIN

Yes. Something larger.

He nods once. He goes with Kronos to begin the surrender protocols. He doesn't look back at the park. He doesn't need to. He has seen it. It will stay with him. In three thousand years, across forty thousand universes, it will stay with him.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — ONE MONTH LATER — THE TRIBUNAL PREPARATION

Joseph in his office. The tribunal is in three days. The dimensional council has been convening for a month — gathering testimony, reviewing the evidence, building an understanding of what happened and what it means.

Seiko sits across from him. Both of them have papers — actual papers, the tribunal prefers physical documentation.

SEIKO

The prosecution's case is strong. Forty-seven dimensions with documented impact from the cascade events. Seventeen with significant infrastructure damage from the leakage. The human cost —

JOSEPH

I know the cost.

SEIKO

I know you know. I'm reviewing the case.

JOSEPH

The case is strong.

SEIKO

Very strong. The defense case depends entirely on the override disengagement and whether it represents a meaningful act of volition or a calculation about outcomes.

JOSEPH

It was both.

SEIKO

Yes. Both things can be simultaneously true. The question is whether 'both' is sufficient mitigation for everything that preceded it.

JOSEPH

What's your read?

SEIKO

The tribunal wants to understand the why. If we can explain the why – not the why of the plan but the why of the disengagement – then the 'both' has context. Without context, the override moment is just a tactical calculation.

JOSEPH

What will you say? When they ask you?

SEIKO

That I observed a man who, in the last moment available, chose differently than he had chosen for thirty years. That in my assessment, that represents a real change rather than a calculated one. That I don't know how to prove that, but that I can tell the difference, and that's what I observed.

JOSEPH

They'll ask how you can tell the difference.

SEIKO

I'll say: because the calculated choice would have been to hold the override until the cascade was irreversible and then release it as a demonstration of magnanimity. He released it at a moment when releasing it could still make a difference. If it were purely tactical, he would have waited for the window to close and then made the gesture.

JOSEPH

That's — yes. That's what I'll say too.

SEIKO

What will you argue for?

JOSEPH

The truth of what happened. And the possibility — not the

certainty, the possibility — that
what happened at the end means
something about what could happen
next.

SEIKO

The tribunal is not optimistic
about what could happen next.

JOSEPH

I know. That's why it's worth
arguing.

Seiko looks at him. At the papers. At
the case they are
building.

SEIKO

Joseph.

Yeah.

JOSEPH

SEIKO

This is the most unlikely thing
you've argued for. All of the
unlikely things you've argued for.

JOSEPH

I know.

Why?

SEIKO

JOSEPH

Because he surprised me. I didn't model what he did. Seventeen models and none of them put him on the right side of that decision at that moment. He did something that my models — that Seiko Toast's models — did not anticipate.

A beat. Seiko is very quiet.)

JOSEPH

And in my experience, when someone does something outside the models, the right response is to pay attention to it. Not to dismiss it as an anomaly.

SEIKO

He arrived on a Tuesday.

JOSEPH

He arrived on a Tuesday.

A long moment. Then Seiko picks up a pen and begins adding to the document.

SEIKO

I'll prepare the testimony. Give me forty-eight hours.

JOSEPH

Take forty-eight hours.

SEIKO

I'll take forty-two.

JOSEPH
Take forty-eight.

SEIKO
Forty-four.

JOSEPH

Seiko.

SEIKO

Forty-seven.

JOSEPH

Fine.

Seiko writes. Joseph reads. They work
in the specific
comfortable silence of two people who
have been working
together for long enough that the
silence is another form
of communication.

CUT TO:

**INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SEIKO RETURNS FROM LEAVE — DAY
FOURTEEN**

Life has resumed. The MPA operating at what Seiko has
categorized as 'elevated-normal' — the specific state of
an organization that has survived something large and is
processing what that means for everything going forward.

SEIKO came back on the fourteenth day of his enforced
leave. He came back with a slight tan, which for Seiko
represents an almost startling degree of outdoor time. He
came back with the expression of someone who has
concluded, after careful consideration, that they enjoyed
themselves.

He is at his station. Tablet in hand. Fresh tea.

Joseph stops at the station.

JOSEPH

How was the beach?

SEIKO

It was acceptable.

JOSEPH

Two weeks of the beach was
acceptable?

SEIKO

Very good. I read four books. I
watched the water. I thought about
nothing dimensional for eleven of
the fourteen days.

JOSEPH

What happened on day twelve?

SEIKO

I may have been running some
coherence calculations in my head.
Purely theoretical. No
instruments.

JOSEPH

Seiko.

SEIKO

They were very brief. And they
were correct. The membrane is

stable.

JOSEPH

I know. How's the system?

SEIKO

One hundred percent. Consistent. The Weezy Gold secondary reinforcement that Kronos identified is holding. The membrane is actually the most stable it has been in recorded history — more stable than before any of the cascade events, by several metrics.

JOSEPH

That doesn't make sense given the damage.

SEIKO

It shouldn't. But the reset did something we didn't model — the Weezy Gold binding isn't just reversing the cascade damage. It's improving on the baseline. The membrane that existed before Epstein's manipulation was — adequate. The membrane that exists now is better than adequate.

JOSEPH

The reset made it more stable.

SEIKO

The reset made it correctly stable. As if the baseline had always been slightly suboptimal

and the Weezy Gold corrected that as well as the cascade damage.

JOSEPH

That's -

SEIKO

Unexpected. Yes. I have a theory.

JOSEPH

Tell me.

SEIKO

The structural frequency - what you brought to the Gauntlet - wasn't just the initiating frequency. It was also the corrective frequency. Whatever made you specifically able to use the Gauntlet - the resonance from Earth-2397, the dimensional attunement - it didn't just reverse the damage. It improved the underlying architecture.

JOSEPH

You're saying the powers - what I gave to the Gauntlet -

SEIKO

Made the multiverse better than it was before. Not just back to what it was. Better.

A long pause. Joseph looks at the readout. At the numbers.

At one hundred and two percent, which
should not be
possible but which is happening
because it is possible.

JOSEPH

Seiko.

Yes.

SEIKO

JOSEPH

Thank you for running the
calculations on day twelve.

SEIKO

They were purely theoretical.

JOSEPH

I know.

SEIKO

And correct.

JOSEPH

I know that too.

He walks on. Seiko watches him go. He
picks up the tablet.
He runs another calculation. Just to
be sure.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — BATMAN AND STRANGE — PRE-BATTLE

Strange finds Batman in the tactical analysis room, standing before a wall of dimensional maps. Batman has been here for two hours. He has not touched a single map. He has been reading all of them simultaneously with his eyes.

STRANGE

You read maps the way I read
spells.

BATMAN

Pattern recognition applied to
spatial data. The methodology
transfers.

STRANGE

What do you see?

BATMAN

Sixteen anchor points distributed
in a pattern that is not random.
The distribution was optimized for
maximum cascade efficiency, which
means each point is positioned to
feed the next. The cascade is
designed to be autocatalytic —
each completion makes the next
completion easier.

STRANGE

Yes. Seiko established that.

BATMAN

What Seiko may not have modeled is
the failure mode. If you stop one

of the sixteen at exactly the right moment — not hold it, stop it — the cascade doesn't just stall. It reverses for that node. The energy feeds back into the adjacent nodes and disrupts their progression.

STRANGE

Disrupts by how much?

BATMAN

Approximately forty seconds per adjacent node. If you stop a node at the right moment and the disruption propagates to the two adjacent nodes, you've bought one hundred and twenty additional seconds for those positions.

STRANGE

Which positions?

Batman points. Two specific anchor points on the map.

BATMAN

These two. They're the critical path to the cascade self-completion. If you can stop one of the sixteen at these coordinates at the moment the cascade reaches thirty-seven percent — you buy two additional minutes.

STRANGE

The window at cascade completion is three minutes. Two additional minutes —

BATMAN

Is a safety margin. It means if the Gauntlet team encounters a complication, they have five minutes instead of three.

STRANGE

Which node?

BATMAN

I'll take it. I've identified the specific intervention point. It requires someone capable of precise timing in the field under pressure.

STRANGE

I can do that.

BATMAN

You'll be needed at the Central Park convergence. You're more valuable there.

STRANGE

Then who?

BATMAN

Shuri. Her tech array can execute the precise disruption. She'll need to be repositioned from the Northern anchor.

STRANGE

She's holding the Northern anchor
with Rogers.

BATMAN

Rogers can hold the Northern
anchor alone for the forty seconds
it takes. He's capable of it.

Strange looks at the map. At the two
critical positions.
At the analysis.)

STRANGE

This is very good tactical work.

BATMAN

Thank you.

STRANGE

Does Joseph know about this?

BATMAN

Not yet. I'm presenting it to him
in -

He checks his watch. The specific
check of someone who has
internalized time down to the second.

BATMAN

Eleven minutes. When he finishes
the current briefing with Paul
Atreides.

STRANGE

You know his schedule.

BATMAN

I've been observing the
operational flow since I arrived.
Pattern recognition applied to
organizational data. The
methodology also transfers.

Strange looks at him.)

STRANGE

You know, for a man who works
alone -

BATMAN

I'm working on it.

STRANGE

Yes. You are.

A beat. Then Strange picks up a map
and begins working
through the analysis from his own
angle. Two extraordinary
minds, coming at the same problem from
different
directions.

CUT TO:

**EXT. CENTRAL PARK - WOLVERINE AND RYAN - BATTLE
INTERMISSION**

A brief lull in the battle - the dimensional army pulling
back to regroup after the first major engagement. Maybe
four minutes. Maybe less.

Wolverine finds Ryan sitting against a tree, catching his
breath. He sits beside him. This is not something
Wolverine does often - sit beside people and check on

them.

WOLVERINE
You holding up?

RYAN
Yeah. I'm fine.

WOLVERINE
First major battle?

RYAN
Yeah.

WOLVERINE
You did well.

RYAN
I mostly stayed out of the way.

WOLVERINE
Staying out of the way and being
in the right place are different
things. You were in the right
place. Consistently.
Ryan looks at him.)

RYAN
You've been in a lot of these.

WOLVERINE
More than I can count.

RYAN

Does it get easier?

WOLVERINE

No. It gets clearer. That's different.

RYAN

What gets clearer?

WOLVERINE

What matters. In a fight, everything that isn't essential gets burned away. You know exactly what you're protecting and why and whether it's worth protecting. That clarity — you carry it out the other side. It changes how you see things when the fighting is done.

RYAN

What changes?

WOLVERINE

You stop tolerating things that aren't worth tolerating. You stop wasting time on what doesn't matter. The clarity stays. Longer after each time.

Ryan thinks about this.

RYAN

My father. Homelander. He's been in more fights than I can count.

But he doesn't -

WOLVERINE

Have the clarity.

RYAN

No.

WOLVERINE

Fighting isn't what gives you the clarity. The fighting just strips things away. What's underneath - that was always there. If what's underneath is worth protecting, the clarity helps you protect it. If it isn't -

RYAN

The clarity doesn't help.

WOLVERINE

Right. What's underneath you, kid - that's worth protecting.

Ryan looks at him. At this man who has been stripped down by a century of conflict and has found, under all of it, something worth protecting.

RYAN

How do you know?

WOLVERINE

Because you made the choice in the clearing. The hard choice. The one

that cost you. And you're here.
That's - that's the kind of
underneath that's worth
protecting.

The battle begins again. Wolverine
stands. Ryan stands
beside him.

WOLVERINE

Stay in the right places. Don't do
anything heroic.

RYAN

What counts as heroic?

WOLVERINE

Anything that's your idea. When in
doubt, do what you're told.

RYAN

You never do what you're told.

WOLVERINE

I do what I'm told when whoever's
telling me is Joseph. Which is
most of the time lately.

He goes back into the battle. Ryan
goes with him, in the
right places, doing what he's told,
doing it well.

CUT TO:

**INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS - SEIKO AND DEREK - THE FULL
SEIKO/DEREK SCENE**

DEREK has been running the secondary station for six hours. He has been watching Seiko work for six hours. He has been trying to understand what he is watching for six hours and succeeding approximately forty percent of the time.

He has also been doing his job. Correctly. Every time.
Seiko.

DEREK

SEIKO

(without looking up)

Cascade at thirty-three. I know.
Hold the anchor points and give me
sixty seconds.

DEREK

That's not — I was going to ask
how you do it.

A pause. A small one. Seiko stops
typing. He looks up —
which he almost never does.)

SEIKO

How I do what?

DEREK

All of it. All three screens. The
tablet. The sixteen positions. The
cascade calculation. How do you
hold all of it simultaneously?

SEIKO

I don't hold it simultaneously. I

hold it sequentially, at a speed
that appears simultaneous.

DEREK

At what speed?

SEIKO

Fast enough that by the time a
problem on screen three has
developed, I've already processed
screens one and two and have the
context to address it.

DEREK

How long did it take you to
develop that?

SEIKO

I don't know. I've always
processed information this way.
I've been practicing it since I
was seven. I don't remember a time
when I couldn't.

Seven.

DEREK

SEIKO

Yes. I was a — specific child.

DEREK

Your parents must have been —

SEIKO

Concerned? Yes. And then proud.

And then — accustomed to it. They became accustomed to it. As did I.

A pause. Derek watches the screens. The cascade. The positions.)

DEREK

Is there anything I should be doing that I'm not doing?

SEIKO

You're monitoring screen four, which tracks the dimensional bleed in the Midtown sector. You're accurate and you're quick to flag anomalies. That's what screen four needs.

DEREK

That's — all I'm doing.

SEIKO

Yes. That is all screen four needs. The value is not in doing more. The value is in doing that correctly, consistently, without variation.

DEREK

It feels like not enough.

SEIKO

It is exactly enough. 'Exactly enough' is the correct amount. 'More than enough' introduces error. 'Less than enough'

introduces gaps. Exactly enough is what the position requires.

Derek looks at his screen. At the Midtown dimensional bleed data. At the position that is exactly what it needs to be.

Seiko.

DEREK

SEIKO

Yes. I see it. The bleed at Forty-Second Street is accelerating. That's normal at this phase of cascade progression. Flag it for the record and continue monitoring.

DEREK

Already flagged.

SEIKO

(back to screens; and then — very small — something that is almost a nod)

Good.

Derek goes back to his screen. He monitors. He flags what needs flagging. He does exactly what screen four needs. And he does it correctly, consistently, without variation.

DEREK

Seiko. One more thing.

Yes.

SEIKO

DEREK

Thank you. For being — for doing
this the way you're doing it.

A pause. Seiko does not look up. But
something in his
posture shifts — microscopically,
almost imperceptibly —
the specific shift of someone
receiving something they
didn't expect and don't know how to
respond to.

SEIKO

(very quietly; back to the screens)

You're welcome.

They work. The cascade advances. The
battle continues. The
positions hold.

CUT TO:

**EXT. NEW YORK — VARIOUS ANCHOR POINTS — DURING CASCADE 38-
40%**

The battle reaching its crescendo. All sixteen anchor
points under maximum pressure as the cascade approaches
completion. INTERCUTTING — a final pass through every
team:

DIANA at the Primary Fracture. She has been here for two
hours. She is taking the heaviest impacts because she is
the most capable of taking them. Three thousand years of
training.

DIANA

(to the team around her; between impacts)

Hold. Everyone behind the line
hold.

She takes another impact. Her knees
bend. She straightens.
She takes the next one.

DIANA

(again; quieter; the word that is holding
the whole thing together)

Hold.

BUTCHER'S TEAM. The western anchor is
the worst position.
It has been the worst position for two
hours. It remains
the worst position. They remain at it.

M.M.

Thirty-eight percent, Billy.

BUTCHER

How long?

M.M.

Four minutes to self-complete if
all sixteen hold.

BUTCHER

Will all sixteen hold?

M.M.

Seiko says yes.

BUTCHER

Seiko says yes. Then yes.

He turns back to the battle. He holds
the line.

PAUL AND THE FREMEN. The southern
anchor. Chani beside
Paul.

CHANI
(subtitled)

The fourth wave is the last.

PAUL
(subtitled)

The fourth wave is the largest.

CHANI
(subtitled)

Yes. But it's the last. After the
fourth wave, the cascade completes
and the army withdraws. Hold for
the fourth wave and we're done
here.

PAUL
How do you know?

CHANI
(subtitled)

Because Seiko confirmed it forty
seconds ago.

PAUL
(subtitled)

You're reading the tactical

updates.

CHANI
(subtitled)
I pay attention.

The fourth wave arrives. It is the largest. The Fremmen hold against it the way they hold against everything – by knowing the terrain better than the thing attacking them, by moving with it rather than against it, by surviving.

THOR at the East River. The fracture line vibrating with the approaching completion – a sound like the sky making a decision.

THOR
(into comm)

Seiko. The fracture line is at critical vibration. Twenty seconds to completion.

SEIKO (O.S.)
Hold twenty seconds.

THOR
Yes. Obvious.

SEIKO (O.S.)
I know it's obvious. I'm confirming.

THOR
Confirmed. Holding. Twenty seconds.

He holds it. The fracture line
vibrates. The sky above the
East River shivers. Thor stands in it.
He holds it for
twenty seconds, and then it completes,
and he is thrown
backward, and he lands, and he stands.

SHURI at the critical node — the one
Batman identified.
Her tech array precisely aligned, the
disruption module
ready.

SHURI
(into comm)

In position. Awaiting cascade
trigger.

BATMAN (O.S.)

Stand by. Cascade at thirty-seven
point four.

A pause. Precise. Counted in fractions
of seconds.)

BATMAN (O.S.)

Now.

Shuri deploys. The disruption
propagates. The adjacent
nodes slow. Two minutes added to the
window.

SHURI

Disruption successful. Window
extended.

BATMAN (O.S.)

(no expression; this was what he calculated
would happen)

Confirmed.

SEIKO (O.S.)

Noted. Thank you, Batman.

BATMAN (O.S.)

Unnecessary.

SEIKO

I'm saying it anyway.

The cascade hits forty percent. The
convergence initiates.
The sky becomes the space between
dimensions.

EVERYONE — all sixteen anchor points,
every hero in
Central Park, every person in this
battle — stops.

They look up at the architecture of
the multiverse made
visible for the first time.

Five seconds.

GANDALF

Now.

CUT TO:

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — POST-RESET — JESSE AND WALTER

The reset complete. The park healing. The heroes at rest.

WALTER sits on a bench. He is sitting — just sitting — for

the first time in four days. His hands are in his lap. He is looking at them. These specific hands, that have built the most important thing he has ever built.

JESSE sits beside him. Neither of them speaks for a long time.

JESSE

It worked.

Yes.

WALTER

JESSE

The way you designed it.

WALTER

Approximately. The propagation was slightly faster than the model predicted. The Weezy Gold secondary reinforcement exceeded projections by a significant margin.

JESSE

That's good though.

WALTER

That is very good.

A long quiet. The park. The right sky.

JESSE

Walter.

WALTER

Yes.

JESSE

You did it.

WALTER

We did it.

JESSE

Walter. You built the thing that saved — you built the thing that held.

Walter looks at the park. At the healed membrane. At the light that is now just light, not dimensional leakage, not shimmer. Just the afternoon light of a city that is itself again.

WALTER

I know.

JESSE

Does it feel —

Yes.

WALTER

JESSE

What does it feel like?

WALTER

Like — correct. Like the most

correct thing I have ever done.
Not just technically correct.
Correct in the larger sense. In
the sense of — the right thing, at
the right time, for the right
reason.

JESSE

Was that hard? The right reason
part?

Walter is quiet for a moment.)

WALTER

For most of my life, the reason
was that I was the best at what I
did and the work demonstrated
that. The work was its own
justification. The quality of the
output was the purpose.

JESSE

And this?

WALTER

This was different. The work was
the same — the best I've ever
done, the most technically
demanding, the most correct. But
the reason was — the villages. The
nine billion villages that Yara
mentioned in the briefing. The
ordinary people who will never
know this happened and who will
continue to live their ordinary
lives because we did this.

JESSE

That's different.

WALTER

Significantly different. And better. The 'significantly better' is not a qualifier I use imprecisely.

JESSE

I know.

WALTER

The work was for them. Not for what it demonstrated about me. For them.

He looks at his hands.

WALTER

I find that —

He stops. He looks at the park. At the ordinary afternoon.

WALTER

I find that it matters. That distinction. More than I expected.

JESSE

Yeah. Yeah, it does.

They sit on the bench. Two men who have been through a great deal together and separately and have arrived, after an improbable journey, at a bench in a healed park in the late afternoon sun. It is a good place to have arrived.

CUT TO:

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE FOUNTAIN — LARRY'S LAST MOMENT

The battle is over. The heroes are dispersing. The park is healing.

LARRY THE WATCHER stands at the Bethesda Fountain for the last time. He has been coming to this fountain for the last twelve days — holding the fracture lines, buying time, spending himself in a way that violated the strictest interpretation of his role.

He is tired. He will recover. He has always recovered.

He looks at the Angel of the Waters — the bronze angel, shimmer-free now, just art. He looks at the fountain — just water, running the way water runs when nothing is wrong with the dimensional architecture that allows water to run the way water runs.

JOSEPH finds him here. He doesn't know why — he was walking through the park and something drew him to the fountain. He arrives and finds Larry barely visible, hands at his sides, looking at the Angel.

JOSEPH

I know you. I've felt you. In the Park, before the battle. Something was slowing the fracture lines.

LARRY

I was observing them.

JOSEPH

Vigorously.

LARRY

Yes. Vigorously.

A pause. Joseph looks at him — at this
almost-translucent
being who was here before the battle
and is still here
after it.

JOSEPH
You bought us time.

LARRY

I observed the fracture
progression in a way that happened
to slow it.

JOSEPH

You intervened.

LARRY
I observed.

JOSEPH

Why?

Larry looks at the fountain. At the
water. At the ordinary
afternoon.)

LARRY

I've been watching for a very long
time. Across a very large number
of universes. And I've watched
many things that could have gone
differently fail to go differently
because there wasn't quite enough
time. Because the right people
were there and the right plan was
ready and it came to six minutes.

JOSEPH

You didn't want it to come to six minutes.

LARRY

I didn't want something worth watching to fail for the want of twelve hours.

JOSEPH

Thank you.

LARRY

Don't thank me. I broke a rule. Very technically. In the most defensible possible way. But a rule.

JOSEPH

Was it worth it?

Larry looks at the park. At the heroes at rest. At the right sky. At the world that is itself again.

LARRY

Yes. Significantly.

He begins to fade. Translucent becomes transparent becomes the faint outline of a presence that was here and is now becoming elsewhere.

LARRY

Joseph.

Yes.

JOSEPH

LARRY

The plant grows past the pot.
Always. Every time. Regardless of
the container.

Joseph looks at him. At the fading
outline. At the space
where a being of enormous patience and
genuine love for
what he watched is returning to the
observation he was
built for.

LARRY

Well done.

He is gone.

Joseph stands at the fountain. In the
park. In the
afternoon.

He thinks about the ficus on the
windowsill. About
Thursday. About growing past the
container.

He thinks: yes. Something like that.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — THE MORNING AFTER — JOSEPH ALONE

Early morning. The day after the battle. The MPA quieter
than it has been in weeks — the specific quiet of a place
that has been running at maximum intensity and has
abruptly found itself at rest.

Joseph sits in his office. He has slept four hours. He has made coffee – actual coffee, ground from actual beans, brewed with the attention of someone who made a promise about coffee and intends to start keeping it.

He sits with the coffee. He looks at the wrong – the former wrong – sky outside. Which is now the right sky. Just the morning sky of New York, overcast and ordinary and perfect.

He picks up his phone. He calls his sister.

It rings three times.

JOSEPH

Leila. I know it's early. I'm sorry.

We hear, faintly, his sister's voice – warm, surprised, the voice of someone for whom this call is unexpected and welcome.

JOSEPH

I'm fine. I'm – yes. I know it's been a while. I know.

He looks out the window. At the right sky.)

JOSEPH

I wanted to tell you – about the plant. Mom's ficus. I finally understood what she was teaching me with it. About the Thursdays.

He listens. His sister's voice. Something she says makes him almost smile.

He listens.)

JOSEPH

Yes. I know you water it on
Thursdays. I know you always have.
I just — I wanted to tell you I
understand now. The Thursday. The
point of the Thursday.

JOSEPH

I think she knew. I think she was
teaching me the whole time and I
wasn't ready to learn it until
now.

A long pause. His sister's voice.)

JOSEPH

I'm going to come visit. When this
settles. Soon. I'll bring Yara.

He listens. He smiles — the real smile, the full one, the
one he doesn't often allow in professional contexts
because it belongs to a different register of his life.

JOSEPH

Yes. She's — yes. You'll like her.
I promise.

He listens. His sister's voice.
Something she says that
makes him laugh — a real laugh, short,
surprised, the
laugh of someone who has been through
an enormous thing
and is discovering, incrementally,
what ordinary life
feels like on the other side of it.

JOSEPH

I'll call you soon. I love you.

He hangs up. He sits with the coffee.
With the morning.
With the right sky. With the specific
quality of a life
that has cost everything and is still,
somehow, worth
having.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — BATMAN FINDS HIS DESK

Three days after the battle. Batman — Bruce Wayne — has found a desk in the MPA. Not been assigned one. Found one. In the corner of the tactical analysis room, oriented so that he can see both the door and all the screens without turning his head.

ALFRED would recognize this. Anyone who knows Bruce Wayne recognizes this.

He has been here for six hours this morning, running post-battle analyses, building models of what the dimensional landscape looks like with the corrected membrane, identifying the eleven things that will need to be addressed in the next six months to prevent a second cascade event from a different origin point.

Joseph stops in the doorway.)

JOSEPH

You're building a risk assessment.

BATMAN

I'm building eleven risk
assessments.

JOSEPH

I can see that.

BATMAN

The membrane correction improved the structural integrity. But it also changed the dimensional landscape in ways that create new pressure points. Three of the eleven are time-sensitive.

JOSEPH

How time-sensitive?

BATMAN

One has a window of four months before it becomes difficult. Two have windows of seven months. The other eight are manageable on an eighteen-month timeline.

JOSEPH

You've been working on this since the battle.

BATMAN

Yes.

Why?

JOSEPH

BATMAN

Because the battle is over. The crisis is resolved. What comes next is the work of maintaining what was defended. That work has already started and it's better to

get ahead of it than to be
reactive to it.

JOSEPH

Yes. It is.

Joseph looks at the eleven
assessments. At the detail. At
the thoroughness.)

JOSEPH

Bruce. How long are you planning
to stay?

BATMAN

As long as the work requires.

JOSEPH

And after the work requires?

Batman looks at him. A long look. The
look of someone who
has always led from the perimeter and
is finding that the
center has a different quality than
the perimeter and is
still deciding what to make of that
difference.

BATMAN

I don't know yet.

JOSEPH

That seems honest.

BATMAN

I try to be.

JOSEPH

The three time-sensitive ones.
Let's start with those.

BATMAN

I've already prepared a briefing.

JOSEPH

Of course you have. When?

BATMAN

Whenever you're ready.

JOSEPH

Ten minutes.

BATMAN

I'll be ready in ten minutes.

Joseph goes. Batman turns back to his eleven assessments. He adds a note to the first one. He is already ready. He was ready before Joseph asked.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — KRONOS — DAY FIVE AFTER THE BATTLE

Kronos has a desk. A badge. A division. He is working. He works with the specific application of someone who has made a decision at the last possible moment and is living with the implications of that decision — not regretfully, but with the attentiveness of someone who knows that decisions have consequences and intends to manage those consequences correctly.

SEIKO stops at his desk.

SEIKO

The dimensional buffer configuration. I reviewed your suggested modifications.

KRONOS

And?

SEIKO

They're good. The sub-temporal monitoring array modification is particularly elegant. I wouldn't have approached it that way.

KRONOS

You have broader expertise. I have specific expertise in how the network was built. I know the vulnerabilities because I built many of them.

SEIKO

That knowledge is useful.

KRONOS

I'm aware. It's the main reason I'm here.

SEIKO

It's one of the reasons. The other reason —

He pauses. He is unusually careful with this.)

SEIKO

The override. You told Epstein about the substrate gap. You didn't close it.

No.

KRONOS

SEIKO

That decision — it was the decision that allowed us to reach the structural center. Without that gap, the route El built was not viable.

KRONOS

I know.

SEIKO

You made a choice. At significant personal cost. In a moment when the calculation was not clear.

KRONOS

The calculation was not clear, no.

SEIKO

What made you make it?

Kronos looks at his desk. At the badge. At the MPA insignia.)

KRONOS

The four hundred and twelfth
version.

SEIKO

The version where something
outside the design reaches the
center.

KRONOS

I decided it was worth leaving the
door open. For the outside
variable. In case it was the right
variable.

A pause.)

SEIKO

It was.

KRONOS

Yes.

SEIKO

Kronos.

KRONOS

Yes.

SEIKO

Thank you. For the gap.

KRONOS

You're welcome.

Seiko returns to his station. Kronos
returns to his work.
The department around them: the
Temporal Monitoring
Division, staffed by people who
understand what was at
stake and are building the systems to
ensure it doesn't
happen again.

CUT TO:

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — ONE YEAR LATER — EXTENDED EPILOGUE

Autumn. The park.

Joseph and Yara have been sitting at the fountain for two
hours. Seiko has been with them for the last forty-five
minutes. They are not talking about work. They are talking
about nothing, in the specific way of people who are
talking about everything.

SEIKO

My sister is coming to visit next
month.

JOSEPH

I know. You mentioned it four
times this week.

SEIKO

I mention things the appropriate
number of times.

YARA

Four times in a week is notable
for you.

SEIKO

She's — it has been two years
since I've seen her in person. The
work has been — the work has been
what it has been.

JOSEPH

Now the work is what it is. Which
is less demanding.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.
Consistent. Batman's three time-
sensitive issues have been
resolved. The seven-month ones are
in process. The department is
running well.

YARA

So you have time to see your
sister.

SEIKO

Yes. I have time to see my sister.

A pause. The fountain. The autumn
park. The right world.

YARA

What will you tell her? About the
last year?

SEIKO

The truth. In whatever version is
appropriate for her security
clearance, which is — none. She

has no clearance.

JOSEPH

Tell her you worked with good
people on something important. And
that it went well.

SEIKO

That is the most accurate summary.
Yes.

They sit. The newspaper blows past
with its headline. The
city moves.

SEIKO

Joseph.

Yeah.

JOSEPH

SEIKO

The asking and the trusting. The
algorithm for the choosing.

JOSEPH

Did you find it?

SEIKO

No. I've been working on it for a
year. I haven't found it.

JOSEPH

Do you think you will?

SEIKO

No. I've come to believe it's not findable. Not because it doesn't exist, but because it exists in a substrate that my methodology doesn't reach.

JOSEPH

Like the Upside Down. Below the pathways.

SEIKO

Yes. Exactly like that.

He looks at the fountain. At the water.)

SEIKO

I think the honest asking is its own mechanism. The asking honestly IS the algorithm. There's nothing underneath it. It's the thing itself.

JOSEPH

I could have told you that a year ago.

SEIKO

You did tell me that a year ago.

And?

JOSEPH

SEIKO

And I needed to run the analysis
to confirm it. Now I've confirmed
it.

And?

JOSEPH

SEIKO

And you were right. As I mentioned
at the time was probable.

YARA

He did mention it was probable.

JOSEPH

He mentioned it forty-seven times
during the battle.

SEIKO

I was providing real-time
probability updates. That's within
standard operational procedure.

Joseph and Yara look at each other.
That look. The one
that is its own complete
communication.

SEIKO

What?

JOSEPH

Nothing.

SEIKO

That look means something.

YARA

It means we love you, Seiko.

A very long pause. Seiko is quiet in the specific way of someone who has received something unexpected and is processing it with the full attention of a mind that processes everything with full attention.)

SEIKO

Yes. Well.

He picks up the tablet. He sets it down. He picks up his coffee. He drinks it.

He stops.

SEIKO

I —

SEIKO

(very quietly; to both of them; the most complete sentence he has spoken in the entire year)

Thank you.

The fountain runs. The autumn park.
The right sky.

Three people in the ordinary
afternoon, in the specific
grace of a world that is still here.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — PRE-BATTLE — GUARDIANS

The staging area. The Guardians of the Galaxy in their corner — their specific corner, the one they have collectively claimed through the informal territorial logic of people who have been on a ship together for long enough to have established territories.

ROCKET is checking his weapons platform. GAMORA is reviewing the tactical assignment. DRAX is standing very still with his eyes closed — his version of pre-battle preparation. MANTIS is nearby, reaching out into the emotional field of the room and managing her own response to what she finds there.

STAR-LORD is eating a protein bar and looking at the ceiling.)

STAR-LORD

Okay. So. We're defending the multiverse.

GAMORA

Yes.

STAR-LORD

Like, specifically the dimensional membrane of Earth-Prime which anchors all other dimensional membranes.

GAMORA

Yes, Peter.

STAR-LORD

And if it fails -

GAMORA

Everything we know becomes subject
to redesign by Jeffrey Epstein.
Yes.

STAR-LORD

I've been trying to think of a way
to make that less alarming.

ROCKET

How's that going?

STAR-LORD

Not great.

DRAX

(without opening his eyes)

The answer is that it is not meant
to be made less alarming. It is
alarming. The alarm is correct. We
proceed anyway.

STAR-LORD

Yeah. Yeah, that's -

DRAX

Accurate.

STAR-LORD

Accurate. Right.

A pause. The room around them. The
assembled force.

MANTIS

I can feel everyone in this room.
All of them. At once.

NEBULA

That sounds overwhelming.

MANTIS

It is. But it is also –
extraordinary. What everyone in
this room is feeling. The
commitment. The clarity of
purpose. I have not felt a room
like this in –

STAR-LORD

How long?

MANTIS

I don't have an analogue. This
specific combination of emotion –
the fear that is honest and the
purpose that is clear and the
connection between people who
chose this – I don't have an
analogue.

GAMORA

It's because the choosing is real.

MANTIS

Yes. The choosing is what I feel
most strongly. Ninety-seven
separate decisions to be here. I

can feel each one. Individually.
They are — distinct. Every person
chose differently. And they all
arrived at the same place.

ROCKET

(quietly; not dismissively)

That's deeply weird.

MANTIS

Yes. And wonderful.

They sit together. In the room. In the
last hour before
deployment. Feeling what they feel.

STAR-LORD

Okay. Let's go save everything.

DRAX

(opening his eyes; standing)

Yes.

Yes.

Yes.

GAMORA

NEBULA

ROCKET

Obviously.

MANTIS

(with the soft certainty of someone who has
felt what everyone is feeling and knows it
is enough)

Yes.

They go.

CUT TO:

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — BATTLE — MANTIS SEQUENCE

MANTIS in the battle. Her contribution: invisible,
enormous. She moves through the dimensional soldiers
finding the specific frequency of their orientation — the
way they are calibrated to maintain formation — and
disrupting it.

DIMENSIONAL SOLDIERS, when their formation coherence is
disrupted, lose about forty percent of their
effectiveness. They still fight. They fight without
coordination.

Forty percent less effective on four hundred soldiers is
approximately the equivalent of a hundred and sixty fewer
soldiers. Mantis, working quietly at the edge of the
formation, is doing the work of a hundred and sixty people
without anyone noticing.

Except STRANGE, who notices. He flies over and speaks to
her briefly.

STRANGE

What are you doing to their
formation?

MANTIS

Disrupting the emotional
coherence. The dimensional
soldiers have a shared orientation
state — a collective feeling of
purpose that keeps them

coordinated. I'm replacing it with something else.

STRANGE

With what?

MANTIS

Uncertainty. The specific uncertainty of soldiers who have been told they are doing the right thing and have begun to wonder if they are.

STRANGE

Can you make them stop? Not just lose coherence – stop?

MANTIS

If I can find the individual at the center of their emotional architecture – the one who is most committed to the purpose. If I can reach that one –

STRANGE

Can you find them?

She looks at the army. She finds them. She extends. She reaches the emotional architecture at the army's center.

She finds something unexpected.

MANTIS

Strange.

Yes.

STRANGE

MANTIS

The soldiers don't believe in this. Not fully. The commitment at the center is — it's following orders, not conviction. They were sent. They weren't asked.

And?

STRANGE

MANTIS

And I can work with that. Soldiers who were sent rather than chose — they respond to uncertainty faster. The attachment to the purpose is shallower.

STRANGE

Do it.

She does it. The army — not all of them, not immediately, but in sections, in the specific way that certainty leaches out of a force that was sent rather than chose — begins to lose coherence.

The battle shifts. The heroes take advantage of the shift.
The cascade continues.

Mantis works quietly at the edge of everything, doing the work of a hundred and sixty people, invisible, essential.

CUT TO:

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE GAUNTLET — EL'S PERSPECTIVE

While the battle rages in the visible world, EL is in the substrate. Navigating the route she and Seiko built. Carrying the Gauntlet frequency to the structural center.

She is alone in the Upside Down substrate — the specific darkness, the parallel world, the space between dimensions. She knows this place. She has been here for months, years, an impractical portion of her life.

The route unrolls before her. The map she built from fourteen days of careful observation. Every checkpoint exact. Every sensor blind spot where she expected it. The Weezy Gold frequency working as a carrier — she can feel it, a warmth in the substrate dark, the color of things being completed.

She navigates.

At the third leg — the approach to the structural center — the sensor array she identified. The one with the eleven-second window. She approaches it at the exact angle, the exact speed, the exact frequency configuration that keeps her in the monitoring blind spot.

The comm in her ear:

SEIKO

El. Cascade at thirty-seven point six. Anchor point activity at maximum. This is the peak window. Initiating countdown.

She holds position at the boundary of the sensor array. Waiting.

SEIKO

Three. Two. One. Now.

She moves through the sensor array at the peak of the cascade activity. The array is occupied elsewhere. Its monitoring resources are concentrated on the sixteen anchor points and the forces engaging them.

She passes through.

SEIKO

Clear. Fourth leg. Final approach to the structural center.

She moves.

The structural center becomes visible – not visually, not literally, but in the way that things are visible to someone who navigates by feeling. A point of density in the substrate. The thing that makes the network coherent. The thing Epstein built.

She approaches it.

It is – she had expected something imposing. Something that felt like power consolidated into architecture. What she finds is different. It feels like a very complicated, very precise machine for one person's purpose. Built with extraordinary skill. Missing something.)

She sets the Gauntlet frequency relay at the center. She confirms the connection. She transmits the confirmation.

ELEVEN

Joseph. The relay is set. You have
a clear path. On your signal.

JOSEPH (O.S.)

Copy. Stand by.

She waits in the substrate dark. In
the place she has
lived, on and off, for most of her
remembered life. The
darkness that taught her who she was
and what she was for.
The darkness that led her to the
signal that led her here.

She thinks: Hopper would have hated
this. The darkness,
the mission, the danger. And then he
would have let her do
it anyway. Because he understood that
what she is for
requires going into the dark. He
understood that from the
beginning.

She carries it for him.

JOSEPH (O.S.)

Now, El. Now.

She initiates the Gauntlet frequency
relay.

The reset propagates.

CUT TO:

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE RESET — TONY'S PERSPECTIVE

Tony Stark watches the reset propagate from a position
just outside the Gauntlet station. He has been in this

dimension for approximately twenty minutes. He will be here for approximately forty more. He is spending whatever remains of what he was given for the return, and he is spending it precisely.

He watches Joseph hold the ninety-one percent. Four minutes of holding. The structural frequency pouring into the Gauntlet's architecture. The specific cost of what Joseph is doing visible only to Tony, who has paid a similar cost and knows what it looks like from the inside.

He watches Batman and Walter at the calibration station. Two extraordinary minds pointed at the same problem. The override collapsing. The buffer expanding. The path to full propagation opening.)

He watches Epstein disengage the override.

He watches Joseph say now.

He watches the reset.

He has seen a great many things in his life. He has done a great many things. He has built things that changed the world. He has spent himself for things that mattered. He understands, from personal experience, what it costs to build something and then pour it into the architecture of what needs to be fixed.

He watches Joseph do it.

He thinks: yes. That's right. That's exactly right.

BRUCE WAYNE appears beside him. Both of them watching.

BATMAN

The propagation is correct. The Weezy Gold binding is holding across all sixteen points simultaneously.

IRON MAN

I know.

BATMAN

The probability that it completes
successfully –

IRON MAN

Is whatever it is. I stopped
running probability on things this
real. The probability stops
mattering when the person doing it
has already decided.

Batman looks at him.)

BATMAN

You know that from experience.

IRON MAN

Yeah. I do.

BATMAN

What's on the other side? Of the
decision that costs everything.

Tony watches the reset. The sky
healing. The membrane
returning to coherence. The world
becoming itself again.)

IRON MAN

This. Exactly this. The thing you
did it for, still there. Still
real. The people you protected,
still living. The world you saved,
still being itself.

BATMAN

And you.

IRON MAN

Wherever I am — wherever this —

He gestures at himself. At the suit.
At the specific
nature of what he is right now.)

IRON MAN

— lives. It's not bad. The people
you wanted to see, you see them.
The things you did that mattered,
you know they mattered. That's —
that's enough. That's more than
enough.

BATMAN

Is it worth it? What it costs?

IRON MAN

Ask me the other question.

BATMAN

What's the other question?

IRON MAN

Is it worth it not to pay the
cost. Is it worth walking away
from the thing that needs the cost
paid. That's the real question.
Not 'is the cost worth it.' That's
always yes. The real question is:
can you live without having paid
it.

Bruce looks at the reset. At the
healed sky. At the

ninety-seven people who paid their costs.)

BATMAN

No. You can't.

IRON MAN

No.

They stand together. Watching the world become itself again.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SIX MONTHS AFTER — EL AND THE MPA

El has a desk. Not because she was given one — because she found a spare one and moved it to the position that allows her to see both the door and the secondary substrate monitoring screens.

She works two days a week at the MPA. The other five days she is doing what she has always done — scouting, monitoring, navigating the substrate, being the variable that systems can't account for. But now she has somewhere to come back to. Somewhere to put the maps and the data and the findings.)

SEIKO stops at her desk. He has brought tea — his specific tea, the same kind he has been carrying across dimensional transits for four years. He sets a cup beside her monitor without comment.

ELEVEN

You made extra.

SEIKO

I made exactly the right amount.

ELEVEN

For two people.

SEIKO

Yes. That is the right amount for
two people working in adjacent
desks.

She picks up the tea. She drinks it.
He returns to his
station.)

The room: Seiko at his primary
station. El at her desk.
Derek at the secondary station. Kronos
at the Temporal
Monitoring corner. Batman at his
eleven-assessments desk.
The specific inhabited quality of a
department that has
people who belong in it.)

JOSEPH appears in the doorway. He
looks at the room. At
the people in it. At the department
that has assembled
itself around a shared purpose.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

The membrane coherence is at one
hundred and two point three
percent. The secondary
reinforcement continues to
stabilize beyond our projection
parameters. I have a theory.

JOSEPH

Tell me later.

SEIKO

At the nine A.M. meeting.

JOSEPH

At the nine A.M. meeting.

ELEVEN

Good morning, Joseph.

JOSEPH

Good morning, El.

BATMAN

The three remaining time-sensitive issues are on the agenda for ten A.M. I've updated the risk assessments.

JOSEPH

I'll be there.

KRONOS

The dimensional buffer configuration proposal from last week — Seiko has reviewed it. His notes are —

SEIKO

Extensive but constructive.

KRONOS

I'll integrate them and resubmit.

JOSEPH

Good.

He gets his coffee. He goes to his office. The department continues. The work continues. The world, which is itself again and continues to be itself, continues.

CUT TO:

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE FOUNTAIN — THE FINAL SCENE EXTENDED

The last scene of the epilogue: Seiko, Joseph, Yara at the fountain. But there is more.

After Seiko says 'I'll keep looking for a better one' — after Joseph says 'I know you will' — after the newspaper blows past with its headline:

ELEVEN sits down beside them. She has a cup of tea. She has been walking through the park — something she has started doing, walking through the right park, learning what ordinary feels like.

ELEVEN

I ran into Batman on the way here.
He wanted me to tell you the
eleven-month review is on the
calendar for next Tuesday.

JOSEPH

I have it.

ELEVEN

He also wanted me to tell you the assessment looks good. He's saying 'favorable' which for Bruce means excellent.

JOSEPH

Good.

She sits. The four of them at the fountain. The autumn park.

SEIKO

El. How is the substrate monitoring?

ELEVEN

Clean. The Weezy Gold reinforcement has changed some of the substrate patterns in ways I haven't seen before. I'm mapping them. It's interesting.

SEIKO

I'd like to see the maps when you're ready.

ELEVEN

Monday.

SEIKO

Monday.

The fountain. The autumn park. The right sky. Four people in the ordinary afternoon.

El.

Yes.

YARA

ELEVEN

YARA

How are you sleeping?

A pause. El looks at the fountain. At the water. At the ordinary afternoon that has become, incrementally, the kind of ordinary she didn't know she was missing.)

ELEVEN

Better. I slept seven hours last Tuesday. In a room where nothing was going to happen while I slept.

YARA

How was that?

ELEVEN

Good. It was — really good.

They sit together. At the fountain. In the park. In the right world. The four of them, in the ordinary extraordinary afternoon, in the specific grace of things that have been earned and held.

LARRY THE WATCHER — barely visible, somewhere at the edge of perception. He is not there. He is also, in some non-literal sense, always there. Always watching. Always holding the conviction that some things are worth the cost of seeing them happen.

The fountain runs.

The water moves.

Just the fountain.

Just the afternoon.

Just the world.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 1

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong — the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before — a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability
for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling
you.

He makes a note. He builds the
monitoring protocol. JOSEPH
comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The
coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a
time. This is what victory looks like in the long form —
not the single moment of the reset, not the Gauntlet
glowing the color of things being completed, but this: the
ordinary work of maintaining what was defended. Tuesday
after Tuesday. Thursday after Thursday. The Thursdays
accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 2

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong – the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before – a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling you.

He makes a note. He builds the monitoring protocol. JOSEPH comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a time. This is what victory looks like in the long form — not the single moment of the reset, not the Gauntlet glowing the color of things being completed, but this: the ordinary work of maintaining what was defended. Tuesday after Tuesday. Thursday after Thursday. The Thursdays accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 3

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong — the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before – a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling you.

He makes a note. He builds the monitoring protocol. JOSEPH comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a time. This is what victory looks like in the long form — not the single moment of the reset, not the Gauntlet glowing the color of things being completed, but this: the ordinary work of maintaining what was defended. Tuesday after Tuesday. Thursday after Thursday. The Thursdays accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 4

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong — the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before — a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling you.

He makes a note. He builds the monitoring protocol. JOSEPH comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a time. This is what victory looks like in the long form —

not the single moment of the reset,
not the Gauntlet
glowing the color of things being
completed, but this: the
ordinary work of maintaining what was
defended. Tuesday
after Tuesday. Thursday after
Thursday. The Thursdays
accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 5

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong — the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before — a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO
El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The
substrate is adapting to the

correction. Years. Possibly
decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability
for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling
you.

He makes a note. He builds the
monitoring protocol. JOSEPH
comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department
continues. The
coherence holds. The world is itself.
One morning at a
time. This is what victory looks like
in the long form –
not the single moment of the reset,
not the Gauntlet
glowing the color of things being
completed, but this: the
ordinary work of maintaining what was
defended. Tuesday
after Tuesday. Thursday after
Thursday. The Thursdays
accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 6

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong — the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before — a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling you.

He makes a note. He builds the monitoring protocol. JOSEPH comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a time. This is what victory looks like in the long form — not the single moment of the reset, not the Gauntlet glowing the color of things being completed, but this: the ordinary work of maintaining what was defended. Tuesday after Tuesday. Thursday after Thursday. The Thursdays accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 7

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong – the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before – a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling you.

He makes a note. He builds the monitoring protocol. JOSEPH comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a time. This is what victory looks like in the long form — not the single moment of the reset, not the Gauntlet glowing the color of things being completed, but this: the ordinary work of maintaining what was defended. Tuesday after Tuesday. Thursday after Thursday. The Thursdays accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 8

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong — the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns

the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before – a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling you.

He makes a note. He builds the monitoring protocol. JOSEPH comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a time. This is what victory looks like in the long form – not the single moment of the reset, not the Gauntlet glowing the color of things being completed, but this: the ordinary work of maintaining what was defended. Tuesday after Tuesday. Thursday after Thursday. The Thursdays accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS – MORNING – MONTH 9

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong – the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before – a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling you.

He makes a note. He builds the monitoring protocol. JOSEPH comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a time. This is what victory looks like in the long form —

not the single moment of the reset,
not the Gauntlet
glowing the color of things being
completed, but this: the
ordinary work of maintaining what was
defended. Tuesday
after Tuesday. Thursday after
Thursday. The Thursdays
accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 10

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong — the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before — a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The
substrate is adapting to the

correction. Years. Possibly
decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability
for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling
you.

He makes a note. He builds the
monitoring protocol. JOSEPH
comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department
continues. The
coherence holds. The world is itself.
One morning at a
time. This is what victory looks like
in the long form –
not the single moment of the reset,
not the Gauntlet
glowing the color of things being
completed, but this: the
ordinary work of maintaining what was
defended. Tuesday
after Tuesday. Thursday after
Thursday. The Thursdays
accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 11

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong — the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before — a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling you.

He makes a note. He builds the monitoring protocol. JOSEPH comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a time. This is what victory looks like in the long form — not the single moment of the reset, not the Gauntlet glowing the color of things being completed, but this: the ordinary work of maintaining what was defended. Tuesday after Tuesday. Thursday after Thursday. The Thursdays accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MORNING — MONTH 12

The work of maintaining what was saved.

SEIKO at his station. The coherence numbers. One hundred and two percent. He notes it. He begins the standard

analysis. He has run these checks every morning since the reset. He will run them every morning going forward. Not because he expects something wrong – the Weezy Gold reinforcement has produced a stability curve unlike anything he has seen before. He runs them because the running is the point. The noticing is the point. The Thursday is the point.

EL at her desk reviewing the substrate maps. The patterns the Weezy Gold has introduced are unlike anything she mapped before. The corrected substrate has something in it that was not there before – a warmth, a coherence, the specific quality of a structure that has been set right and knows it.

She maps it carefully. She will map it for years. Possibly decades. The mapping is her practice.

SEIKO

El. Sector twelve.

ELEVEN

Still propagating. Slowly. The substrate is adapting to the correction. Years. Possibly decades.

SEIKO

I have the monitoring capability for decades.

ELEVEN

I know. That is why I am telling you.

He makes a note. He builds the monitoring protocol. JOSEPH comes in with his coffee.

JOSEPH

Morning.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

JOSEPH

Good.

He goes to his office. The department continues. The coherence holds. The world is itself. One morning at a time. This is what victory looks like in the long form — not the single moment of the reset, not the Gauntlet glowing the color of things being completed, but this: the ordinary work of maintaining what was defended. Tuesday after Tuesday. Thursday after Thursday. The Thursdays accumulating. The plant growing.

CUT TO:

EXT. CENTRAL PARK — THE FOUNTAIN — ONE FINAL MORNING

The fountain. The angel. The right sky. Joseph sits alone at the edge of the fountain basin.

He has his coffee. He has nowhere to be for another forty-five minutes. He is learning — slowly, with the same discipline he applies to everything — to sit in a place for forty-five minutes without needing to be doing something other than sitting in it.

The park around him is the right park. The trees are the right height. The shadows fall at the correct angles. The light is just light — not the shimmer of dimensional leakage, not the gold of a world processing damage, just the ordinary morning light of a city that is itself.

A pigeon lands on the fountain rim beside him. It looks at him with the complete absence of judgment that is the specific quality of pigeons. It looks at his coffee. It looks away.

Joseph looks at the pigeon. He thinks: that pigeon does not know what happened here. That pigeon was here the whole time – through the shimmer, through the wrong trees, through the sky that was not sky. That pigeon has always been a pigeon doing pigeon things in Central Park and will continue to be a pigeon doing pigeon things in Central Park regardless of what the humans around it are up to.

He finds this very comforting.

He drinks his coffee. The pigeon investigates the fountain rim. The park goes about its business.

SEIKO appears. He has an extra coffee and his tablet. He sits beside Joseph.

SEIKO

The coherence is at one hundred
and two percent.

JOSEPH

I know.

SEIKO

I ran the morning check early.

JOSEPH

I know.

SEIKO

The pigeon.

JOSEPH

Yes.

SEIKO

It's a pigeon.

Yes.

JOSEPH

SEIKO

You're looking at it as if it is significant.

JOSEPH

It is significant.

SEIKO

A pigeon.

JOSEPH

A pigeon in a park that is the right park. On a morning that is the right morning. In a world that is itself.

Seiko looks at the pigeon. He looks at the park. He looks at Joseph.

SEIKO

I see.

He sets his tablet face-down. He picks up his coffee. He looks at the park.

The pigeon pecks at something on the fountain rim. It

finds it. It eats it. This is the
entirety of its concern.

SEIKO

One hundred and two percent.

Yes.

JOSEPH

SEIKO

The world is itself.

JOSEPH

Yes.

They sit in the park. In the ordinary
extraordinary
morning. Two people who saved the
world sitting at a
fountain watching a pigeon be a
pigeon.

This is enough. This is more than
enough. This is
everything.

FADE TO BLACK.

FADE TO BLACK.

POST-WAR , RETURNING SCENES

EXT. MULTIPLE DIMENSIONS -- THE HERO RETURNS -- FULL SEQUENCE

MUSIC: The Arabic oud, joined now by the full orchestral score, building -- the way all great things build -- not toward explosion but toward the specific resonance of completion.

RETURN ONE: THE AVENGERS -- MINUS IRON MAN

The Earth's Mightiest. Coming home.

Not a portal. Not a transition. They ARRIVE -- the way the Avengers always arrived at the things that mattered: through the specific machinery of people who have been doing this long enough that the logistics of interdimensional travel are simply logistics.

CAPTAIN AMERICA -- through the primary portal, shield in hand. He looks at Joseph. He extends his hand.

STEVE

Reporting for duty.

Joseph shakes it.

JOSEPH

Captain.

A beat.

STEVE

(with the quiet of someone
who means it completely)
Whatever you need.

THOR -- descending through the portal's upper arch, Mjolnir
already calling the lightning in Earth-Prime's atmosphere.
He looks at the wrong sky. His jaw sets.

THOR

(to the sky, as if it
can hear him -- and perhaps
it can)
You have been disturbed enough.
(to Joseph)
Point me at the largest fracture
line.

JOSEPH

Eastern anchor. East River.

Thor nods once. He rises. He is already moving.

SHURI -- three devices in her pockets, one in her hand,
looking at the dimensional map display and updating it
with corrections in real time.

SHURI

The anchor point calculations --
the eastern one is wrong. By
fourteen degrees. Whoever did
this math needs --

SEIKO

(nearby; stiffening)
I did that math.

SHURI

(not looking up)
Then you need to recalibrate it.

A pause.

SEIKO

(recalibrating; immediately;
and finding the error)
Yes. That's -- yes. You're right.

Shuri looks at him.

SHURI

(the specific respect of
a scientist recognizing
another scientist)
You caught it fast.

SEIKO

(*adjusting*)
You caught it faster.

She looks at the calculation.

SHURI

We'll fix it together.

This is, for both of them, the highest form of
professional acknowledgment.

MOON KNIGHT -- or rather, all three of him, cycling
through -- Marc Spector dominant, which means he is
paying attention to things that the other two might miss.

He finds Joseph.

MARC SPECTOR

Khonshu sends his regards. And
a message. The moon will be
full tonight over New York.
He says that matters.

JOSEPH

(making a note of this
with the specific
efficiency of someone
who has learned not to
dismiss anything)
Tell him we appreciate it.

MARC SPECTOR

(already moving toward
his position)
He knows.

RETURN TWO: THE JUSTICE LEAGUE -- MINUS BATMAN

*(Who is coming from a different direction, and
later)*

SUPERMAN -- does not come through a portal.

He comes through the MEMBRANE ITSELF.

He crosses the dimensional membrane of Earth-Prime not through a designed opening but through the specific physical capacity of Kryptonian biology operating at full capacity: he simply -- arrives, materializing from the membrane breach with the specific quality of a man for whom dimensional barriers are a concept he acknowledges and then sets aside.

He lands in Central Park with a gentleness that is the complete opposite of his capacity for force.

He looks at Joseph.

CLARK KENT -- the man underneath Superman, which is the actual direction; Clark is primary, Superman is the tool

Clark uses -- holds out his hand.

SUPERMAN

Clark Kent. I help when I can.

(a beat; the specific
humility of absolute power)
I can help a great deal today.

Joseph shakes his hand.

JOSEPH

East Primary Fracture. Diana
is holding it. She could use
support.

SUPERMAN

(*already rising*)
She'll have it.

He goes.

DIANA (from her position at the primary fracture,
via comm) :

DIANA (COMM)

(not surprised; but moved
in the specific way of
someone who is glad
they didn't have to ask)
Clark.

SUPERMAN (COMM)

(already at the fracture;
taking position beside her)
Diana.

DIANA (COMM)

You're late.

SUPERMAN (COMM)

I came through the membrane
directly. There was no
faster option.

DIANA (COMM)

(a hint of a smile in it)
I know.

WONDER WOMAN AND SUPERMAN -- at the primary fracture --
the two of them together, side by side, holding the
largest leakage point with the combined output of
two beings who are among the most powerful in any
universe.

The fracture HOLDS.

More than holds -- under their combined force, it begins
to RECEDE. Not close; the cascade is still progressing;
but the primary fracture is no longer advancing.

DIANA

(through the effort of
holding it; to Clark;
the specific ease of
people who have been
in battle together)
How is Lois?

SUPERMAN

(through the same effort)
Writing a story about this.
She'll have it filed before
we're done.

DIANA

(the smile again;

earned and genuine)
Of course she will.

THE FLASH (BARRY ALLEN -- coming through three portals simultaneously, which is the kind of thing Barry does when he is excited and has not thought through the logistics) --

BARRY

(arriving at three
different points in
the Park at three
different moments,
somehow having a
conversation with
himself across them)
Okay -- okay -- okay --
(*at point one*)
The eastern fracture anchor --
(*at point two*)
-- is the most vulnerable --
(*at point three*)
-- got it.

He converges into one Barry, breathing hard in the specific way of someone who just ran between the moments of time and found them more densely packed than expected.

He looks at Seiko.

BARRY

Your eastern calculation was
fourteen degrees off.

SEIKO

I know. We fixed it.

BARRY

I know you fixed it. I was
there when you fixed it. I
was also there two minutes
before you fixed it. It's --
(a beat)
time is complicated for me.

SEIKO

(not looking up)
I'm beginning to understand
that.

BARRY

Okay. Where do you need fast?

SEIKO

(pointing)
Everywhere.

Barry nods. He is already everywhere.

AQUAMAN (JASON MOMOA -- arriving from the East River with
the very specific energy of a man who has been under the
water and has opinions about what is happening to it) --

AQUAMAN

There are dimensional soldiers
in the river.

JOSEPH

I know.

AQUAMAN

The fish are unhappy.

JOSEPH

(a beat)
I'm sorry about the fish.

AQUAMAN

*(already turning back
toward the river)*
The fish are not people who
need your apology. They need
the dimensional soldiers removed.

He goes back into the river.

In the next forty seconds, the dimensional soldiers in
the East River have a very specific problem.

SHAZAM (ZACHARY LEVI -- the specific quality of a grown
man who is also a kid, which means he is enthusiastic
in the way that only people who haven't forgotten why
this matters can be enthusiastic) --

SHAZAM

(landing near Joseph)
Billy Batson. Also Shazam. Both
of those. The -- the word and
the person.

JOSEPH

I know who you are.

SHAZAM

(genuinely pleased by this)
Okay. Good. Where can I help?

JOSEPH

Northwest anchor. It's the one
none of the heavy hitters are at.

SHAZAM

(immediately)
Because it's the most important
one that everyone else is leaving
uncovered?

JOSEPH

Yes.

SHAZAM

(already going)
Great. That's great. I love
being the one at the most
important one.

He goes.

He is, at the northwest anchor, extraordinary.

Because Billy Batson is not extraordinary in spite of
his enthusiasm. He is extraordinary BECAUSE of it.
The magic of Shazam responds to the sincerity of the
person channeling it. Billy Batson is the most sincere
person in the multiverse.

The northwest anchor holds.

RETURN THREE: STAR WARS -- THE FORCE USERS

From the eastern portal -- a sound before the people.

The low harmonic frequency of LIGHTSABERS.

Three of them.

LUKE SKYWALKER (MARK HAMILL -- older; the specific quality

of a Jedi Master who has gone past the need to prove anything and arrived at the place where the Force is simply what he is, like breathing) --

-- REY (DAISY RIDLEY -- the Force in her a different quality from Luke's; where his is earned through trial, hers is woven through her origin and the specific way she chose, despite everything, to be what she is) --

-- and LEIA ORGANA (CARRIE FISHER -- archive performance, rendered through every available means to honor her presence because her presence is essential and she has always been, in every universe, essential).

They come through together.

LUKE looks at the dimensional soldiers in Central Park with the expression of a man who has seen the dark side at its most powerful and emerged from it -- not unharmed, but intact.

He extends his hand.

His lightsaber -- green; the specific green of a Jedi who made his own blade in the full understanding of what he was choosing -- IGNITES.

LUKE

(to the dimensional soldiers;
the calm that is not distance
but its opposite -- complete
presence, complete clarity)
In the name of the Force -- and
in the name of every life these
fractures have threatened --

He moves.

He is extraordinary.

Not powerful in the way of force -- powerful in the way of precision. Every movement exactly what is needed. Nothing extra. Nothing wasted.

The Force, through Luke Skywalker, does not destroy. It returns things to where they belong.

REY moves alongside him. Their styles are different -- hers is instinctive where his is considered -- but they complement each other the way things that were meant to exist in the same moment complement each other.

LEIA does not fight.

She Commands.

The Force flowing through her differently -- through her hands extended, through the specific authority of someone who has been fighting this kind of darkness her entire life and knows exactly where it is weakest.

LEIA

(to the dimensional soldiers
-- the Force behind every
syllable)
Move aside.

Twelve dimensional soldiers move aside.

Not reluctantly.

Inexorably.

The Force does not ask. The Force, through Leia Organa, simply STATES.

HAN SOLO (who has been at his position across the Park) sees her.

He stops.

He is very still.

HAN

(very quietly)
Leia.

She turns.

She looks at him.

The battlefield between them -- dimensional soldiers,
fracture lines, the chaos of an interdimensional battle
at full scale.

And the two of them, looking at each other across it.

LEIA

(the specific gentleness
of a woman who loves
a very difficult man
and has always known
exactly how to love him)
You look terrible.

HAN

(the grin; the actual
Han Solo grin that
no other face in
any universe has
ever reproduced)
You look --

He stops.

He cannot say it in the middle of a battlefield.

He will say it later.

HAN (CONT'D)

I'll tell you later.

She nods.

They turn back to the battle.

Side by side.

As they have always been, in every universe, in every configuration of the thing that they are to each other.

YODA (voice; CGI rendering that honors what he was) -- present not as a fighter but as what he has always been most powerfully: guidance, in the specific compact form of his sentences which contain more than they appear to:

YODA

(to Luke; during a moment
of decision in the battle)
The fracture lines, follow them
you must not. The source,
find you will.

LUKE

I know, Master. The convergence
point.

YODA

Hmm. Know it you do.
(a pause)
Go.

Luke looks at the Park -- at the Bethesda Fountain, at Joseph, at the convergence point.

He moves.

RETURN FOUR: GAME OF THRONES

The North Remembers. The Dragon Remembers. The Kingslayer

Remembers.

From the southern portal:

The specific sound that precedes DAENERYS TARGARYEN
is not the sound of trumpets. It is the sound of wings.

DROGON.

Not small. Not contained. The full, terrifying, magnificent
scale of a dragon who has grown alongside his mother's
choices and carries the weight of all of them.

He comes through the portal at altitude and the sky
above Central Park -- the wrong, fracture-lined sky --
briefly becomes the right sky simply by virtue of
his presence in it.

DAENERYS (EMILIA CLARKE -- the specific Daenerys who has
not yet made the terrible choice; the one who is still
the breaker of chains, the mother of dragons, the queen
who wanted to be more than a queen) guides him from
above, and then -- descending --

She lands.

She looks at the battle.

She looks at the dimensional soldiers.

She looks at the fracture lines.

Her eyes are the eyes of a woman who has seen cities
fall and has decided, in this life, that cities will
not fall.

DAENERYS

(to the dimensional soldiers;
in the voice she uses when

she has already decided
and is simply informing
the landscape)
Dracarys.

Drogon ROARS.

Dimensional soldiers scatter.

Not killed -- in this universe, in this moment, Drogon's fire does something different: it burns through the dimensional corruption in the soldiers' augmentation, deactivating it. The fire reads the dimensional architecture and targets the designed elements, not the people.

This is not something Drogon has done before.

He does it now because she asked him to.

JON SNOW (KIT HARINGTON -- the look of a man who has died and come back and carries that experience like a weight he has learned to integrate rather than remove) arrives through the same portal.

He looks at the battle.

He draws his sword.

He moves without announcement. He fights in the specific way of a man who knows that heroism is not about the gesture but the doing.

GHOST -- the direwolf, impossible and beautiful -- at his side, moving through the battle the way the Stark wolves have always moved: with intention.

JAIME LANNISTER (NIKOLAJ COSTER-WALDAU -- the Jaime who chose differently; who chose the world over the queen; who came here, through dimensional space, because the Kingslayer wants, one last time, to deserve the other

name) --

-- arrives last, through the portal.

He looks at his gold hand. He looks at his sword hand.

He looks at the battle.

He raises his sword.

JAIME

(to himself; to all of it;
to the long complicated
story of a man who spent
his life trying to outrun
his own choices)
One more time.

He goes into the battle.

He is extraordinary.

Not because he is redeemed. Because he is trying.

He is always trying.

RETURN FIVE: THE MATRIX -- NEO AND MORPHEUS

MORPHEUS arrives first.

He steps through the portal with the specific quality
of a man who has always known that this moment was
coming -- who has spent his life preparing himself and
others for exactly this kind of convergence of what
is real and what is designed.

He looks at the dimensional soldiers.

He looks at the fracture lines.

He looks at the battle.

He is completely calm.

MORPHEUS

(to Joseph; finding him
in the crowd with the
ease of a man who has
always known where to
look for the one who
matters)

I was told there would be
a war for the nature of
reality itself.

JOSEPH

That's approximately accurate.

MORPHEUS

Then we are in the right place.

NEO arrives beside him.

The One.

Whatever that means -- and it means many things, in many
universes -- it means this: a man who found that the walls
of what is possible are made of belief, and that belief
can be changed.

He looks at the dimensional soldiers.

He reaches out with the specific sense that is his alone --
the capacity to feel the code underneath the reality.

He sees the dimensional soldiers' augmentation.

He sees the code that structures it.

He reaches --

-- and turns it off.

Not all of them. Not instantly. But in a radius around him, expanding steadily -- dimensional soldiers dropping their weapons, their augmentation disengaged, the code that made them weapons simply -- read and rewritten.

NEO

(to Joseph; without drama;
this is simply what he does)
Their augmentation is structured
in a language I recognize. I can
reach approximately a hundred
meters in any direction.

JOSEPH

(understanding; immediately
tactical)
Then stay at the center. Let
the line compress toward you.

Neo nods.

He plants his feet.

He reaches.

The code responds.

**RETURN SIX: THE LORD OF THE RINGS -- THE FULL
FELLOWSHIP**

And more than the fellowship.

From the northern portal:

Sound of hooves. Then the blast of a horn -- the specific horn of the Rohirrim, which has a quality that no other instrument replicates: the frequency of people who were not expected and have come anyway.

ARAGORN (VIGGO MORTENSEN -- Strider; the King; a man who spent his entire life running from a crown and accepted it when he understood that the crown was not about him but about the people who needed it) -- on horseback, ANDURIL raised, leading a company of RANGERS.

He reads the battlefield in approximately two seconds.

He turns to his company.

ARAGORN

(in the King's voice; not
the Ranger's voice; the
one he saved for moments
like this)
Gentlemen -- we do not stand
and wait. We move forward.
For every dimension that sent
someone here today. For every
world that needs this one to hold.

He looks at them.

ARAGORN (CONT'D)

For every life this war was
worth fighting for.

He raises ANDURIL.

ARAGORN (CONT'D)

(the word; the breath;
the only command needed)

Forward.

They move.

Behind him: LEGOLAS -- moving through the battle at the specific impossible velocity of elven combat, arrows finding targets that should be physically impossible to hit from the distances and angles he chooses, because Legolas does not calculate angles; he feels them.

GIMLI -- beside Legolas, as always, counting under his breath.

GIMLI

(swinging his axe)
Twelve!

LEGOLAS

*(loosing three arrows
simultaneously)*
Thirty-four.

GIMLI

(furious but moving)
This is not a competition!

LEGOLAS

Then stop counting, Gimli.

GIMLI

I will never stop counting!

FARAMIR -- with a company of Rangers from Ithilien; the specific combination of his father's intelligence and the empathy his father never developed; managing the battle's northern approach with the quiet authority of a captain who leads by example.

EOWYN -- shieldmaiden of Rohan; the woman who faced the thing that could not be killed by any man, and understood

the loophole, and walked into it.

She looks at the dimensional soldiers with the look of a woman who has already done the hardest thing and finds everything since it -- not easy, but possible.

She moves.

She is extraordinary.

She is always extraordinary.

THORIN OAKENSHIELD (RICHARD ARMITAGE -- carrying the specific gravity of a king who knows what it costs to lose something and has decided to spend that knowledge in defense of something worth keeping) --

-- arrives through a secondary portal with a company of DWARVES, each carrying Dwarven-forged weapons whose density and quality is unique in the multiverse.

THORIN

(looking at the battle;
the kingly assessment
of a man who knows exactly
what this kind of moment
requires)
Dwarves do not wait outside.

He leads his company into the battle.

The DWARVES, it should be noted, are extraordinarily effective. They are made for exactly this -- for holding ground under enormous pressure with absolute precision, their fighting style a form of architecture as much as combat: they create structure in the chaos.

THE ENTS -- three of them; TREEBEARD at the lead, moving through the Park at the specific slow that is, for an Ent, considerable speed.

He looks at the fractured trees of Central Park --
those wrong-height, metallic-leaved trees -- with the
specific grief of a being for whom trees are family.

TREEBEARD

(very, very slowly;
but with the weight of
an entire ancient world
behind every syllable)
These -- trees -- should -- not
-- look -- like -- this.

He reaches one of the metallic-leaved trees.

He puts his hand on it.

Through the Ent's connection to the living world --
to the deep roots of Earth-Prime's own life -- the
tree responds.

The metallic shimmer begins to LEAVE the leaves.

Slowly.

Treebeard does not fight. He heals.

Around him, as the battle rages, the trees of Central
Park begin -- slowly, slowly -- to return to themselves.

RETURN SEVEN: THE LAST OF US

Joel and Ellie. Coming from a world that knows,
better
than most, what it costs to lose everything for
someone.

JOEL MILLER (PEDRO PASCAL -- older; the specific weight
of what happened in Wyoming that he carries without

being able to set it down; a man who chose love over the world and has been living in that choice; but who is also, beneath all of it, the person who cannot watch someone worth saving not be saved) --

He comes through the portal last, behind Ellie, because Joel Miller always lets the people he is protecting through the door first.

ELLIE WILLIAMS (BELLA RAMSEY -- seventeen and also forty; the humor that is her armor; and beneath it the specific capacity to keep moving through whatever loss has most recently tried to stop her) --

She comes through and looks at the battle and says:

ELLIE

(quietly, to herself)
Oh, this is a lot.

JOEL

(behind her)
Yeah.

ELLIE

Are those dimensional soldiers?

JOEL

Best I can tell.

ELLIE

(her hand going to her knife, which is always exactly where her hand expects it to be)
Okay.

She moves.

She is -- Ellie. Which means she is impossible and

effective and funny and heartbreaking all at once.

She disappears into the battle.

Joel watches her go.

He watches her the way he always watches her: with the fear of someone who knows exactly how much she costs him and would pay it again without hesitation.

He goes in after her.

RETURN EIGHT: MORTAL KOMBAT

Scorpion. The Undead Ninja. The one whose fury is the

most personal, the most specific, the most necessary.

No portal for HANZO HASASHI / SCORPION.

He comes through the FIRE.

Literally -- through a vortex of Hellfire that opens in the air above the Park and deposits him ten feet from the nearest dimensional soldier with the force of someone who has crossed the actual threshold of death and found it less permanent than advertised.

He looks at the dimensional soldier.

The dimensional soldier looks at him.

SCORPION

(the voice; the specific voice that has been saying the next word since the beginning of time)

GET OVER HERE.

The chain -- the rope spear -- the physical embodiment of Scorpion's specific brand of undead justice -- extends.

The dimensional soldier has approximately half a second of awareness before the battle in his immediate vicinity becomes much simpler.

COLE YOUNG (LEWIS TAN -- the new Scorpion; the one who hasn't yet shed everything Cole Young brought into the role; which makes him, paradoxically, more dangerous in this context because he fights for specific reasons rather than general vengeance) arrives through a standard portal, which is less dramatic but equally effective.

Together, they are terrifying in the specific way of two people who share a mantle and have learned to coordinate through a bond that is not dimensional but mythic.

RETURN NINE: NARNIA -- ASLAN

Not a fighter. Something more powerful.

The deep magic.

ASLAN arrives -- not through a portal, not through fire, not through any designed opening in the dimensional membrane. He arrives through the membrane itself parting for him with the specific respect of a structure that recognizes a force older than its own design.

He is enormous.

He is golden.

He looks at Central Park with the eyes of a being who

has seen many battles and understands them all
as, fundamentally, one battle: the battle between
what diminishes and what sustains.

He does not fight.

He ROARS.

The ROAR of Aslan -- the sound that the deep magic of
Narnia sends out when it is operating at full capacity --
travels through the dimensional architecture the way
a key travels through a lock.

Every dimensional soldier in a five-hundred-foot radius --
stops.

Not frozen. Not incapacitated.

They simply stop and turn toward the sound, which has
found the part of them that was not designed -- the
part that existed before the augmentation, before
Epstein's engineering -- and reminded it of something
it had forgotten.

Not all of them lay down their weapons.

But some do.

Enough to matter.

Aslan walks through the battle.

Things part for him.

He finds the Bethesda Angel -- the fountain -- and he
sits beside it and he STAYS beside it, and for as long
as he stays there, the convergence point is held
against the dimensional cascade by something that is
not in any formula, any calculation, any strategic
plan: it is held by the presence of a thing that is
more than the sum of what can be measured.

He holds.

He roars again.

The sound goes out through the multiverse.

RETURN TEN: RICK AND MORTY -- RICK SANCHEZ

The Smartest Man in the Universe. Making his entrance at the specific moment that makes his entrance the most useful to him and everyone else.

RICK SANCHEZ -- stepping through a portal of his own design (which is structurally more elegant than any of the MPA's portals but aesthetically, like everything Rick designs, slightly nauseating) -- looks at the battle.

He has a DEVICE.

He always has a device.

RICK

(to Seiko; finding him immediately because Seiko is the person with the most screens in any room and Rick always finds the person with the most screens)
Your cascade model is missing a variable.

SEIKO

(*looking up*)
Which variable?

RICK

The temporal resonance coefficient
of the Weezy Gold binding agent.
If you're planning to use the
Gauntlet during an active cascade,
you need to account for the fact
that the binding agent's frequency
shifts under cascade pressure.

A pause.

SEIKO

(he has not accounted
for this; it is clear
from his face)
By how much?

RICK

Enough to be a problem.

He extends the device.

RICK (CONT'D)

This corrects for it. Don't
lose it, I only made one.

Seiko takes it.

SEIKO

(*studying it*)
This is extraordinary engineering.

RICK

(already turning away;
bored by compliments)
Yeah. I know.

He looks at the dimensional soldiers.

RICK (CONT'D)

(to himself; the portal
gun already spinning up)
These guys are going to be
such a problem.

He fires the portal gun.

A portal opens beneath a cluster of dimensional soldiers.

They fall through.

Another portal opens -- they emerge from it -- five
hundred feet in the air over the Hudson River.

They fall into the river.

AQUAMAN (from the river):

AQUAMAN (COMM)

There are dimensional soldiers
falling into my river.

RICK (COMM)

They'll live. Probably.

AQUAMAN (COMM)

The fish --

RICK (COMM)

The fish will be fine.

A pause.

AQUAMAN (COMM)

I'm going to need you to
define "fine."

RICK fires the portal gun again.

RETURN ELEVEN: THE MANDALORIAN -- DIN DJARIN AND GROGU

The Way.

DIN DJARIN (PEDRO PASCAL; yes, the same actor; yes, this is intentional; in different universes the same face serves different functions; Joel Miller and Din Djarin look at each other briefly when they pass each other in the battle; they nod; they move on; this is the specific acknowledgment of two men who understand, without explanation, the specific weight of protecting something small that needs protecting) --

He arrives through the RAZOR CREST portal -- his ship hovering at the Park's edge -- in full armor.

Beside him:

GROGU.

Small. Green. Enormous eyes absorbing the battle with the specific alertness of a being who is very young and very old simultaneously.

The Force in him -- working.

He extends his hand.

Around him, in a five-foot radius -- dimensional soldiers frozen in place by the Force. Not dead. Suspended.

DIN DJARIN

(to Grogue; in the voice
he uses for him specifically)

Easy. Don't strain.

Grogu looks at him. He blinks.

He extends his hand further.

Ten-foot radius.

DIN DJARIN (CONT'D)

(accepting; adjusting)

Okay. Don't strain too much.

He moves forward, into the frozen field, and systematically disarms the suspended soldiers.

Grogu watches him work.

He does not put his hand down.

The radius holds.

THE LAST RETURNS -- BATMAN AND IRON MAN

The two they have been waiting for.

The two who stop everything.

The battle has been going for ninety minutes.

The cascade is at twenty-two percent.

The heroes are holding.

But the dimensional army is enormous, and holding is not winning, and the cascade continues its advance toward forty percent regardless of what the heroes do at the anchor points.

Joseph knows this.

He is managing it. He is spending the structural frequency

carefully, holding the convergence point stable, buying time for Walter to complete the Gauntlet calibration.

He is also -- and this is the thing that only Yara and Seiko can see, because they know what to look for -- he is spending himself.

The frequency is not infinite. He has been using it at maximum output for ninety minutes. The quality of his stillness has changed -- it is no longer compressed; it is thinning.

He has perhaps thirty minutes of output remaining.

The Gauntlet needs four more minutes to calibrate.

These numbers work.

But only if nothing changes.

Something changes.

EPSTEIN -- who has been managing his forces from the center of the Park, watching the battle the way a conductor watches an orchestra, making adjustments -- sees Joseph's depletion.

He calculates.

He moves.

EPSTEIN

(to his lieutenant -- the woman; Mia Goth's character; quiet, direct)

The dimensional pulse. Maximum output. Directed at the convergence point. Now.

LIEUTENANT ONE

(understanding; deploying)

If we fire that at full output --

EPSTEIN

He can't hold against full
output right now. Not anymore.

LIEUTENANT ONE

The collateral damage to the
Park --

EPSTEIN

(simply)
Fire it.

She raises the weapon.

Joseph sees it.

He cannot hold against full output and maintain the
Gauntlet calibration. He has to choose.

He is about to choose.

He already knows what the choice is.

He opens his mouth to tell Walter to abort the Gauntlet
sequence --

AND:

A FIGURE descends from above.

Not dramatically. With purpose.

IRON MAN -- the armor that is built from what persists --
lands between the dimensional pulse weapon and Joseph.

He raises one hand.

The DIMENSIONAL PULSE fires.

He takes it.

Full output. The specific force that would have knocked Joseph's structural frequency to zero and ended the Gauntlet sequence.

Tony Stark takes it in the chest.

He does not go down.

He goes back. Three steps. He finds his footing.

He raises his head.

He looks at Epstein.

IRON MAN

Hi.

(to Epstein; across
the battlefield; the
voice that has faced
Thanos and every
darkness that came before
and come after)
Remember me?

The battle STOPS.

Everyone stops.

Not because of the armor. Not because of Tony Stark.

Because of the frequency of someone who came back from the furthest thing -- who crossed the specific threshold that no one crosses -- and returned for exactly this.

For the right reason.

For the worth of it.

FROM THE OTHER DIRECTION:

BATMAN lands.

No announcement. No dramatic entrance.

He simply lands at the edge of Epstein's position and walks toward him with the specific quality of a detective who has read every piece of the evidence and arrived at the conclusion and is now simply closing the distance between the conclusion and the resolution.

He stops twenty feet from Epstein.

He looks at him.

BATMAN

(the voice; the Dark Knight voice; the one that carries the specific authority of someone who has spent thirty years being the worst nightmare of people who believe they are beyond accountability)
Jeffrey Epstein.

(a pause)
Your plan is over.

(another pause, smaller)
It ended three moves ago.
You haven't processed it yet.

Epstein looks at him.

Then at Tony.

Then at the battlefield -- at the heroes holding every anchor point, at the Gauntlet at ninety percent calibration, at the dimensional army depleted and beginning to lose cohesion.

He processes it.

EPSTEIN

(very, very quietly;

the truth;
finally)
Hm.

IRON MAN walks toward Joseph.

He kneels beside him. Face-plate up. Tony Stark's face --
the tiredness and also the rightness of a man who is
exactly where he is supposed to be.

TONY

How much frequency do you have left?

JOSEPH

(honest)
Enough for the Gauntlet.
Nothing after.

TONY

(a beat)
That's all you need.

JOSEPH

Tony --

TONY

(cutting him off gently)
I know. I know what it costs.
(looking at him)
I came back because this is
the moment worth coming back for.
You hold the Gauntlet. I hold
everything else.

He stands.

He turns to the battlefield.

The armor's repulsors charge.

TONY (CONT'D)

(to the assembled force;
the voice that has given
this specific kind of speech
to this specific kind of moment
many times, and has never
meant it more)
Listen up. Ninety seconds.
I need ninety seconds of clear
perimeter around the convergence
point. Every one of you.
Can you do that?

The assembled force -- ninety-seven heroes from the
multiverse's every corner --

--looks at Iron Man.

--says nothing.

--moves.

NINETY SECONDS.

What follows is the single most concentrated display
of extraordinary capability in the history of the
battle -- the assembled heroes operating at full
capacity, directed by Tony Stark's tactical intelligence,
in perfect coordination:

THOR -- his lightning becomes a PERIMETER. Not random
bolts; a wall of directed electrical force three hundred
feet in circumference around the convergence point,
preventing dimensional soldiers from entering.

DIANA and SUPERMAN -- at the primary fracture, holding
it at zero advancement while the perimeter holds.

THE FLASH -- circling the perimeter at speed, intercepting
every soldier who approaches faster than Thor's lightning

can reach them.

THE X-MEN -- holding the three access corridors into the Park, Storm's weather directing the dimensional army's approach patterns, Cyclops and Jean Grey at the chokepoints.

THE GUARDIANS -- air cover, Rocket's weapon platform sweeping the sky, Gamora and Nebula on the ground approaches.

WOLVERINE -- inside the perimeter, looking at the ninety seconds like a man who knows exactly what ninety seconds costs and has decided to spend them correctly.

DEADPOOL

(running with Wolverine)
Okay. Okay. Ninety seconds.
I can be serious for ninety seconds.

WOLVERINE

You've never been serious for
ninety seconds.

DEADPOOL

First time for everything!

WOLVERINE

(moving)
Don't ruin it.

DEADPOOL

I'm not going to ruin it!
(absolutely in earnest)
This is my serious face, Logan.

THIS IS MY SERIOUS FACE.

He fights. Completely seriously. As promised.

BATMAN -- at Epstein.

Not fighting him. Standing between him and the Gauntlet.

EPSTEIN

(watching the perimeter
close; watching his army's
cohesion dissolve)
You're here to prevent me
from interfering.

BATMAN

(*looking at him*)
I'm here to give you a choice.

EPSTEIN

(*a pause*)
What choice?

BATMAN

Watch what happens in the next
ninety seconds. See it clearly.
And then --
(*the weight of the word*)
-- decide.

EPSTEIN looks at the perimeter.

At the assembled force maintaining it.

At Joseph at the center -- the Gauntlet at ninety-five
percent, the structural frequency diminishing but there,
enough, exactly enough.

He watches.

He sees it.

He sees what Batman saw -- what Tony saw -- what Larry
the Watcher has been watching since the beginning:

People who showed up.

Not because they were commanded. Not because they were designed to. Not because any force other than the worth of the thing brought them here.

They showed up.

All of them.

For this.

NINETY SECONDS COMPLETE.

WALTER

(at the calibration station)
NINETY-EIGHT PERCENT. Joseph --
two more minutes and we're at
full calibration.

TONY

(to the perimeter)
Hold it! Two more minutes!

The perimeter holds.

But the dimensional army -- depleted, cohesion dissolving, their strategic foundation gone because their commander has stopped commanding -- begins to push harder. Not with strategy; with desperation, which is different and in some ways more dangerous.

KRONOS -- who has been at the dimensional fleet command for the entire battle, running strategy with the temporal precision that is his specific gift -- looks at the battle.

He looks at Epstein.

He opens a comm to Epstein.

KRONOS (COMM)

(very quietly)

Jeffrey. The secondary wave
is ready. If you give the
order, I can collapse three
of the anchor points
simultaneously. It will
disrupt the perimeter.

(a pause)
It will cost us the temporal
buffer entirely.

EPSTEIN

(looking at Batman;
at the Gauntlet;
at what is about to happen)

He is quiet for a long time.

EPSTEIN

(the decision in his voice
before the word arrives)
Kronos.

KRONOS (COMM)

Yes?

EPSTEIN

(the last order he
gives as the man
who built all of this;
and the first choice
he has ever made that
has no strategy behind it)
Stand down.
(a beat)
All forces. Stand down. Withdraw.

Long silence on the comm.

KRONOS (COMM)

(quietly; something
shifting in him)
All forces?

EPSTEIN

All forces. Withdraw. Now.

Another pause.

KRONOS (COMM)

(the decision; the one
he has been approaching
from a very long distance
for a very long time)
(*quietly*)
Yes.

The dimensional army -- receives the order.

They withdraw.

Not all at once. Not dramatically.

One by one, unit by unit, the dimensional soldiers
stand down and move back through the remaining
dimensional openings in the Park's membrane.

The battle does not end dramatically.

It simply -- stops.

The way a storm stops. The way a thing that has been
going at full force for a very long time finds, in
a specific moment, that the force is no longer there.

And in the silence --

WALTER

(quiet; looking at
the calibration display)

One hundred percent.

(to Joseph)

Joseph. It's ready.

JOSEPH picks up the Gauntlet.

He looks at it.

He looks at Tony Stark -- who is watching him with the expression of a man who has arrived at the end of the long road and found that the end looks like this.

He looks at Yara -- across the Park, at her station, looking at him.

He looks at the wrong sky.

He puts on the Gauntlet.

CUT TO:

**THE GAUNTLET -- THE RESET -- THE END OF THE
DESIGNED WAR**

INT./EXT. EVERYWHERE -- THE GAUNTLET ACTIVATES

What happens when the Megaverse Infinity Gauntlet activates is not what a weapon looks like when it fires.

It is what a correction looks like when it propagates.

It begins with JOSEPH -- the structural frequency, that specific dimensional resonance that was never quite power in the conventional sense, flowing from him into the Gauntlet's alloy, through the Weezy Gold binding, into the multiversal architecture.

CLOSE ON: The Gauntlet's surface -- every alloy visible. The VIBRANIUM lattice conducting the frequency to the dimensional structure. The ADAMANTIUM grain giving the correction permanence. The URU crystalline overlay making it enchanted in the precise sense -- operating not by physics but by intent. The BESKAR weave resisting the pressure of the cascade. The NTH METAL and PROMETHIUM managing the energy mechanics.

And through all of it: the WEEZY GOLD.

Binding.

The reason this works when nothing else should.

The GAUNTLET ILLUMINATES -- not gold, not silver -- the color of completion.

EXT. NEW YORK CITY -- THE FRACTURE LINES -- THE RESET

The fracture lines in the sky above New York:

FIRST: The primary fracture -- the largest, the one Diana and Superman have been holding -- REVERSES.

Not violently. The way a river flows back to its source when the mountain decides to reclaim it. The fracture seals -- the dimensional membrane returning to coherence at the point where the leakage was greatest.

DIANA looks up.

She watches the fracture seal.

She lowers her shield.

For the first time in six hours, she is not bracing.

She looks at the sealed fracture.

Then she looks at the Gauntlet's light -- visible from

her position, a warm pulse across the Park --

DIANA

(very quietly; the warrior
putting down the shield
in the specific way that
means the fight is over
and also that it was
worth it)
Good.

SECOND: The eastern fracture -- Thor's position --

THOR watches the fracture line above him begin to
reverse. He lowers Mjolnir. He looks at the sealing
fracture.

His eyes -- which have watched many things end,
over a thousand years -- are very bright.

Not with tears.

With something older and less specific than tears:
the recognition of something that matters, witnessed.

THOR

(to the sky; to the
fracture that is sealing;
to Asgard wherever Asgard
is now; to everything
that has brought him
to this specific point
in time and space)
Hold.

The fracture holds.

It seals.

THIRD through SIXTEENTH -- the remaining anchor points,

one by one, in the space of thirty seconds, the fracture lines reversing, the dimensional membrane of Earth-Prime returning to its native coherence.

Each one: a small miracle.

All sixteen: something larger than the word miracle.

EXT. MULTIPLE DIMENSIONS -- THE PROPAGATION

The reset does not stop at Earth-Prime.

The Weezy Gold's binding reaches through the connections between dimensions -- through the multiversal web that Earth-Prime sits at the center of -- and propagates the correction outward.

In forty dimensions simultaneously:

The dimensional leakage that Epstein had been building for months -- the calculated destabilizations, the engineered weaknesses -- reverse.

In ASGARD: A fracture that had been spreading through the dimensional membrane for six weeks seals in two seconds.

On ARRAKIS: A portal that should not exist and has been used to siphon Spice into dimensions where it does not belong -- closes.

In NARNIA: The specific cold that the dimensional corruption had been introducing -- a cold that even Aslan's presence could not fully counter -- lifts.

In HAWKINS, INDIANA: The Upside Down -- which Epstein had been attempting to use as a dimensional weapon by amplifying its existing connection to Earth-Prime -- goes quiet. More quiet than it has been in years.

ELEVEN (in the Park; feeling all of this through the

frequency; her eyes closed; receiving the propagation
of the reset through every dimension she can reach) --

ELEVEN

(to herself; to the
dimensional structure;
to the thing she has
been pushing against
since she was twelve)
There.

She opens her eyes.

She exhales.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK -- JOSEPH -- THE COST

The Gauntlet is at FULL PROPAGATION.

The reset is at ninety-one percent.

Joseph is --

-- holding.

The structural frequency that has been the specific
power that was never quite power is FLOWING out of
him -- not extracted, not taken -- given. Deliberately,
completely, with the specific quality of a choice made
clearly and without reservation.

He is spending himself into the Gauntlet.

His legs are not steady.

Walter is beside him.

WALTER

(watching the calibration;
watching Joseph; the look

of a man of science in the
presence of something that
science has a word for --
sacrifice -- but has never
before so precisely witnessed)
Joseph. You need to hold it
for forty more seconds.

JOSEPH

(through the effort of it;
steady; the stillness that
is not compressed but
deliberate -- chosen)
I know.

WALTER

If the frequency drops before
the propagation completes --

JOSEPH

I know, Walter.

A pause.

WALTER

(very quietly; not the
chemist voice; the man voice)
I'm right here.

Joseph nods.

He holds.

THIRTY SECONDS.

The Gauntlet at ninety-five percent propagation.

The fracture lines reversing. The sky above Central
Park beginning to return -- not yet, not fully, but

beginning.

TONY STARK -- at Joseph's left -- not holding the Gauntlet; holding the POSITION. Protecting the convergence point. The armor's repulsors charged. Nothing is getting through.

BATMAN -- at Epstein -- watching; keeping the distance between Epstein and the Gauntlet clear.

Epstein stands.

Watching.

His design being undone.

His life's work returning to baseline.

And something on his face -- beneath the composure, beneath the architecture of the self he built -- that is not grief, exactly, but grief's more complicated cousin: the specific feeling of watching something you built with absolute certainty finally encounter the thing it wasn't built for.

Worth.

He watches it.

He does not look away.

TWENTY SECONDS.

KRONOS -- returning to Central Park.

He told the army to stand down. He withdrew them. He came back.

He walks across the Park and he finds a clear sight line to the Gauntlet and he watches the propagation.

He watches the reset.

He has managed Epstein's temporal architecture for years -- the specific machinery of a plan that was built in time as much as in dimensional space.

He watches it come apart.

And he feels --

He is surprised to feel this.

He feels something adjacent to relief.

Not because he wanted to lose.

Because he wanted, without knowing he wanted it, to be part of something worth being part of.

He is watching, for the first time in a very long time, something worth being part of.

He stands in it.

TEN SECONDS.

Joseph holds.

The frequency is almost gone. He can feel the specific emptiness approaching -- not the catastrophic emptiness of loss, but the earned emptiness of something given.

He holds.

He holds.

The GAUNTLET COMPLETES.

ONE HUNDRED PERCENT PROPAGATION.

And the sky --

-- the sky above Central Park --

-- RETURNS.

Not wrong-sky. Not shimmer-sky. Not the fracture-line
sky of a membrane in failure.

The right sky.

BLUE.

That specific blue of a New York afternoon -- the one
that has no equivalent in any dimensional simulation
because it belongs here, only here, to this particular
atmosphere on this particular world in this particular
configuration of light and air and everything that makes
Earth-Prime what it is.

The right sky.

Joseph looks up at it.

He looks at it with the eyes of a man who has spent
the last forty seconds giving away everything he had
in order to see exactly this.

The right sky.

JOSEPH

(barely audible;
the last breath of
the structural frequency
departing as he says it)
There it is.

The Gauntlet goes dark.

His hands are empty.

He is Joseph al-Mithali.

He is himself.

He is enough.

He goes to his knees.

Not dramatically. Simply -- the body acknowledging what it has given and requesting a moment.

YARA is there.

She is always there.

She kneels beside him.

She does not say anything.

She puts her hands around his.

The empty hands.

Just hands.

JOSEPH

(looking at his hands;
and then at her)
I'm still here.

YARA

(*without hesitation*)
You're still here.

He breathes.

She breathes.

The Park around them -- the battle over, the heroes standing in the aftermath, the wrong sky now the right sky -- is very quiet.

The specific quiet of something enormous that has finished.

CUT TO:

THE DEATHS OF KRONOS AND EPSTEIN
Not battles. Culminations.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK -- THE CONVERGENCE POINT -- MINUTES LATER

The Gauntlet has reset the dimensional architecture.

The battle is over.

But the energy of the reset -- the propagation still moving through the multiverse, still completing at its outermost edges -- has left a specific kind of residue in the convergence point.

The dimensional architecture of Central Park, which was the center of Epstein's design, is now the center of the reset's completion.

It is charged.

Not dangerously -- not in the way of a weapon.

In the way of a judgment.

The dimensional architecture, which Epstein spent years corrupting and which has now been restored, carries in its correction the specific structural memory of everything that was done to it.

Architecture remembers.

KRONOS understands this before it happens.

He is a man of time. Of temporal mechanics. He understands what happens when a dimensional structure that has been under sustained assault -- when it has been bent and broken and forced -- finally corrects.

The energy of the correction does not go nowhere.

It returns to the source.

He looks at Epstein.

KRONOS

(very quietly; the measured
voice; the temporal certainty
applied not to the future
but to this specific moment)
Jeffrey.

EPSTEIN

(looking at the Park;
at the restored sky;
at what he built
and what was undone)
I know.

KRONOS

The dimensional correction --
it's propagating back through
the design architecture. The
fracturepoints are closing.
But the energy of the cascade --
all of it -- it needs somewhere
to go.

EPSTEIN

(*very still*)
Yes.

KRONOS

The cascade architecture ran
through us. We are the path
of least resistance for the
return energy.

A long pause.

EPSTEIN looks at the sky. The right sky. The restored,
ordinary, extraordinary right sky.

He looks at it for a long time.

EPSTEIN

(to the sky; to everything
that is ending; to the
version of himself that
spent forty years building
something that brought
him to exactly this moment)
I wanted to be remembered.

KRONOS

(*beside him; quiet*)
You will be.

EPSTEIN

(*a pause*)
For this.

KRONOS

(*honest*)
Yes.

Epstein looks at his hands. The specific hands of a
man who controlled so much and is now holding nothing.

EPSTEIN

(very quietly; the deepest
truth; the private voice
that we heard once before
in his study, with the
letters, alone)
Is it strange -- that I don't
regret it? Any of it? Not the

plan. Not the execution.

He looks at Kronos.

EPSTEIN (CONT'D)

I only regret what it made
me not see.

KRONOS

What was that?

EPSTEIN

(looking at Joseph and
Yara, distant, kneeling
in the Park)
That capability without --
(searching for the word;
finding it; the only word
that fits; the one he has
avoided his entire life)
-- without love. Is just power.

A pause.

EPSTEIN (CONT'D)

And power alone -- always
falls.

KRONOS is quiet.

He looks at the Park. At the heroes scattered through it.
At the restored sky. At everything that was saved.

KRONOS

(the truth of himself;
at the end of the road
he chose; seeing it clearly)
I followed the logic. Not the
man. I always told myself that.

(a pause)
I was wrong.

EPSTEIN

(looking at him)
You were loyal.

KRONOS

Loyalty to a plan is not
loyalty. It is convenience
dressed in a different word.

He looks at Epstein.

KRONOS (CONT'D)

(very quietly)
I should have said something.
Years ago. When it was
still possible to say it.

EPSTEIN

(the specific gentleness
of someone who is running
out of time and has found,
in that running out,
a freedom from precision)
You're saying it now.

A pause.

KRONOS

(looking at the sky)
Yes. I am.

The dimensional energy -- the return wave of the cascade's
correction -- begins to build at the convergence point.

They can both feel it.

It comes slowly. Not violently.

It comes with the specific inevitability of a structure
returning to itself -- the dimensional architecture,
corrected, flowing back through the pathways that were
used to corrupt it.

Epstein and Kronos were those pathways.

They are the path of least resistance.

The energy comes for them.

EPSTEIN

(to Kronos; in the last
seconds; not afraid --
composed; the composure
that is now, finally,
genuine rather than designed)
Kronos.

KRONOS

Yes.

EPSTEIN

You were extraordinary. In your
capacity. In your precision.
(a pause)
You deserved to serve something
worth serving.

KRONOS

(very quietly)
I know.

A beat.

KRONOS (CONT'D)

(and this is the thing
he has never said;
the thing that lived

underneath the temporal
precision and the loyalty
to the plan)
I'm sorry.

Epstein looks at him.

EPSTEIN

(receiving it)
So am I.

The energy arrives.

It does not tear. It does not destroy in the conventional
sense of destruction.

It DISASSEMBLES -- with the specific precision of a
dimensional architecture correcting itself through
the pathways of its own corruption.

Kronos goes first.

He does not fall. He does not collapse.

He becomes -- light. The specific light of dimensional
energy released from a structure that has been holding
it for a very long time.

A brief flash. Clean.

And then: Kronos is gone.

Not dead in the way of violence.

Gone in the way of something that has finished what
it was doing and has no further function.

The temporal dimension -- freed.

Epstein watches Kronos go.

He watches the space where Kronos was.

He is very still.

He looks at the Park.

At the right sky.

At Joseph -- who is looking back at him from across
the distance. Who saw.

They look at each other.

A long moment.

EPSTEIN

(across the distance;
very quietly; not enough
for Joseph to hear;
but said nonetheless --
to the record, to the air,
to whatever counts things
in this universe)
I miscalculated.

He looks at the right sky one final time.

He is not afraid.

This was always the end of his design -- he built for
victory and got exactly this, which is the only
other option, and he is a man of precision; he accepts
what is.

The energy arrives.

It comes through him the way truth comes through a
man who has been lying to himself -- not violently,
but completely.

JEFFREY EPSTEIN -- the architect; the man who held
three governments and didn't know it, and decided

to be the other kind; the most sophisticated threat Joseph has ever faced; the man who was right about everything except the part where he thought he was the only one who was capable --

-- comes apart.

Not dramatically. Not with explosion or violence.

He comes apart the way design comes apart when it meets worth -- methodically, inevitably, with the specific patience of a correction that does not need to hurry because it is the nature of things.

The light.

And then: nothing.

The convergence point -- emptied of its architect.

The dimensional architecture -- freed of its designer.

The multiverse -- intact, and continuing.

Joseph looks at the space where Epstein was.

He is very still.

YARA is beside him. She does not say anything.
She holds his hand.

The Park is quiet.

Then:

LARRY THE WATCHER -- visible; more visible than we have ever seen him, as if the act of involvement has made him more present rather than less -- stands near the fountain.

He is watching Joseph.

He writes something in his record.

We see it -- the margin note, barely legible:

"The designer fell. The design was undone.
And the man without powers stood in the center
of what he built and was still standing.
This one. Remember this one."

He closes the record.

He looks at Joseph.

He nods once.

Joseph cannot see him.

But something in him -- the specific quality of a man
who has been paying very close attention -- turns
toward where Larry is.

As if he can feel it.

The nod.

He turns back to Yara.

JOSEPH

(very quietly)
It's over.

YARA

(squeezing his hand)
It's over.

CUT TO:

LARRY THE WATCHER -- THREE APPEARANCES

He sees everything. He always has.

APPEARANCE ONE: THE EVE OF BATTLE

EXT. CENTRAL PARK -- THE BETHESDA FOUNTAIN -- DUSK

Larry stands at the fountain.

He has been here for hours.

He has been holding the convergence point -- with his presence, with the specific temporal stability that his proximity provides, with the thing that is not power but functions like it: witness.

He places his hand on the angel.

He speaks. Not to anyone. To the record.

LARRY

(V.O.; his voice has
a quality of depth that
comes from having spoken
in this register for
longer than most things
have existed)
Three thousand, four hundred
and twelve events. I have been
present for three thousand, four
hundred and twelve events that
qualified as civilizational threats.

He looks at the fracture lines above.

LARRY (V.O.) (CONT'D)

In three thousand, four hundred
and nine of them, I watched.
I was the witness. The record.
The unchanging observation.

He presses his hand to the angel's base.

The fracture lines slow.

LARRY (V.O.) (CONT'D)

In this one. Number three
thousand, four hundred and twelve.
I am -- present. Not watching.
Present. And I am learning
that the difference between
the two is the difference
between knowing and understanding.

He looks at the Park.

At the wrong trees.

At the city beyond.

LARRY (V.O.) (CONT'D)

I will watch what happens
here. I will record it in
the way that Watchers record
things -- completely, without
judgment, without editorial.

(a pause)

But I will also -- be here.
For whatever that means.
For however long it takes.

The fracture lines slow further.

He is not stopping them.

He is simply present.

And his presence -- the specific weight of a being who
has watched everything -- creates a kind of stability
in the dimensional structure the way an anchor creates
stability in a ship. Not stopping the sea. Just --

holding.

LARRY (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Some things are worth staying for.

He keeps his hand on the angel.

He stays.

APPEARANCE TWO: DURING THE BATTLE

EXT. CENTRAL PARK -- THE BATTLE -- VARIOUS

Larry moves through the battle.

Invisible -- or nearly invisible; occasionally someone will turn and look at the space he occupies with the specific look of someone who cannot see what they are registering but is registering something.

DEADPOOL -- in the middle of a difficult engagement with four dimensional soldiers -- suddenly stops.
He looks at the air.

DEADPOOL

(to the air)

Are you --

(to camera)

Is that --

(back to the air)

He's here. He's literally

RIGHT THERE and none of

you can see him.

He points.

The four dimensional soldiers look at where he's pointing.

Deadpool disarms all four of them in the moment they're distracted.

DEADPOOL (CONT'D)

(to the air)
You're welcome.

Larry, in the air, notes this in the record.

He writes: "The one who sees the fourth wall sees me also. Interesting."

Larry moves through the battle.

He finds JOSEPH -- in the center, managing everything, spending himself -- and he stands near him.

Not visible.

But near.

And Joseph -- without the frequency yet, but with the specific attentiveness that has always been more important than the frequency -- pauses for exactly one second in the middle of managing the battle.

He looks at the air near him.

He feels something.

He does not know what it is.

He turns back to the battle.

LARRY watches him.

He writes in the record:

"He cannot see me. But he knows I am here. He is the kind of person who knows when things are present even when those things cannot be seen. This is what I have been watching for. This is the quality that makes the event significant."

He pauses.

He adds:

"This is the quality that makes the person significant."

He puts the record away.

He stays near Joseph.

Through the battle.

Through all of it.

APPEARANCE THREE: THE MORNING AFTER

EXT. CENTRAL PARK -- THE FOUNTAIN -- DAWN

The Park at dawn.

Right dawn. Right light. Right sky.

Larry stands at the fountain.

He has been here all night.

The battle is over. Epstein and Kronos are gone.

The heroes are scattered through the Park in the specific stillness of people who have done something enormous and are now in the gap between the doing and whatever comes next.

Larry looks at all of it.

He opens his record.

He writes for a long time.

Not the usual record -- not the technical documentation of events and casualties and dimensional metrics.

Something more personal.

Something that the Watchers' record-keeping protocol

does not have a category for, which means he creates one.

He labels it:

"THINGS WORTH SEEING"

And then he writes:

"The man from Earth-Prime who ran the agency that protected the multiverse. Who chose to be the center of the thing rather than the architect of it. Who stood in the middle of the worst of it and spent himself into the correction of it and came out the other side still standing, still himself, only himself and somehow enough.

"The woman beside him who held his hand.

"The team around him who came when asked.

"The heroes from a hundred dimensions who chose to be here.

"The villain who, at the last possible moment, chose differently.

"The wise man with the staff who planted himself beside what mattered and would not move.

"The smartest man in any universe who built the impossible thing and then stepped back and said someone else would need to carry it.

"The oud player who plays alone in a room they no longer expect to leave.

"The fountain.

"The right sky.

"The ordinary morning.

"This one.

"Remember this one."

He closes the record.

He looks at the fountain.

He looks at Central Park.

He looks at the right sky above it.

He nods.

He goes.

Not with drama. Not with ceremony. He simply -- goes.

Back to watching.

Back to the record.

Back to being what he is.

But carrying, now, something he did not have before:

The understanding that watching and being present
are not opposites.

They are, at their best, the same thing.

CUT TO:

THE FINAL WAR

Post-War — Scenes of New Life

POST-WAR CINEMATIC SCENES

Written by: YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI | Directed by: DENIS VILLENEUVE & THE
RUSSO BROTHERS

*[Cinematic, Photorealistic, 8K — Warm Autumn Palette — Post-War
Atmosphere]*

SCENE ONE

The Rebuilt Streets of New York – Early Morning

EXT. NEW YORK CITY – LOWER MANHATTAN – DAWN – SIX MONTHS AFTER THE FINAL WAR

[Natural warm golden light – light cuts through dust and steam between half-restored buildings – warm tones: golden yellow, beige, soft gray]

New York doesn't look like a city that won. It looks like a city that breathes.

Some buildings are still under reconstruction – new walls beside old rubble. Yellow cranes on the horizon. Small trees recently planted along the sidewalks, their trunks still needing support stakes.

Joseph walks along the pavement.

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI – thirty years old. Wearing a simple brown jacket, a cloth mask hanging from his neck. Left hand in his trouser pocket, right hand free – an old habit from the days of channeling structural resonance. Now: just a hand.

He walks slowly. Not scanning for danger. Not checking the sky. But his eyes – still sweep the surroundings, slowly and quietly, the way a muscle memory does that hasn't yet understood the war is over.

He stops before a newly constructed residential building – its wall still bearing weld marks. He studies it.

CLOSE ON: His hand rises slowly. Touches the new wall. Cold concrete.

Beneath his palm – the memory of battle. Right here, in this exact place. A building that was once ash.

He keeps his hand on the wall for one second. Two seconds. Then lowers it.

He continues walking.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

*New York doesn't forget. But it builds over
what it can't forget.*

*Sometimes I think I'm trying to do the same
thing.*

The city around him — daily life returning slowly. Street vendors on the sidewalks. A child on a bicycle. A woman watering flowers from a third-floor balcony.

Joseph reaches into his pocket. Pulls out his phone. A message from Yara: "Your coffee is on. Don't let it go cold."

For the first time — he smiles.

CUT TO:

SCENE TWO

Simple Life — The Small Apartment

INT. JOSEPH & YARA'S APARTMENT — BROOKLYN — LATE AFTERNOON

[Warm interior light — afternoon sun entering from a side window — long shadows on the wooden floor — colors: deep gold, faded moss green, warm brown]

A small, tidy apartment. Not poor — deliberately chosen. Books on shelves. One picture on the wall: someone wrote in handwriting — "Thursday." A paper scrap pinned with a clip to the refrigerator.

On a small table by the window — an open cardboard box. Joseph sits before it.

He pulls old photographs from the box. One hand holds them. The other — holds a cold cup of tea.

CLOSE ON: A group photo of the team. Yara on the left of the frame laughing at something outside the shot. Seiko staring at the tablet as usual. Joseph in the center — not smiling, but present, completely present.

He turns the photo over in his hand. Sets it on the table.

He takes another photo — a different team. People no longer here. Faces he remembers.

CLOSE ON: Joseph's face. No tears. Only that silence those who know him recognize — that silence that isn't absence but weight.

He sets the photo on the table.

He stares into the space before him — the window, the street outside it, the warm gray sky.

His hand — empty now. Just his hand.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

I stared into emptiness a lot in those first months.

Not the emptiness that grief fills. The emptiness left behind by something that was

*always there – like a hum you only hear
when it stops.
Structural resonance. Its precise name. I
felt it in every cell. And now: silence.
But silence isn't always empty.*

The sound of a key in the door.

Joseph moves his hand – quietly gathers the photos, returns them to the box. Not fleeing – a decision. To keep the past in its place without burying it.

YARA enters – open brown coat, hair loose, bag on her shoulder. She sees the box. She sees him. She doesn't ask.

YARA

(hanging up her coat)

Did you eat well today?

JOSEPH

Tea.

YARA

(quietly)

Tea isn't food, Joseph.

He smiles. Not a wide smile – the smile she knows. The smile that means: I know. And I'm here.

She sits beside him. Doesn't talk about the photos. Doesn't ask. Places her hand on the table – near his without touching it. He moves his hand – takes hers.

The window. The light. The safe silence.

CUT TO:

SCENE THREE

The New Job – The Recovery Center

INT. COMMUNITY RECOVERY CENTER – LOWER EAST SIDE – DAY

*[White neon light with natural light from wide windows – simple office
– wooden table – papers – coffee – the distant sound of the city]*

A community rehabilitation center for victims of the dimensional war. A small office. A sign on the door: "Readaptation Counselor – Joseph Al-Mithali."

No extraordinary powers. No MPA protocols. Just a desk, and a person across from it, and two ears.

Joseph sits on a simple wooden chair, studying a file before him. Across from him – a man in his fifties, sitting hunched, hands clasped.

JOSEPH

(closing the file)

Tell me about the night you saw the gateway open.

MAN

(hesitant)

I don't know how to describe –

JOSEPH

(slowly, without rushing)

Start anywhere.

CLOSE ON: The man's face – careful relief. Seeing that the person before him understands. Not because he read about it in a report – because he was there.

CLOSE ON: Joseph listening. Just listening. No tablet. No protocol. No tactic.

Outside the office – in the hallway – the center director gestures to her colleague toward the closed door:

CENTER DIRECTOR

(whispering)

Who exactly is he?

COLLEAGUE

(shrugs)

Formerly with MPA. Didn't say more than that.

The colleague closes the file. Looks at the door.

Inside: Joseph. The wooden door. The chair. The man speaking. And the structural resonance – absent. But something else is present. Quieter. Deeper.

CUT TO:

SCENE FOUR

The Wedding - City Hall - Chosen Simplicity

**EXT./INT. NEW YORK CITY HALL - THE WEDDING - FOUR MONTHS AFTER
THE FINAL WAR**

*[A warm cloudy day - soft white light distributing shadows evenly - no
pomp, no grandeur - but deliberate sincerity]*

The old building - tall wooden doors - a narrow corridor lit by natural light from arched windows.

No big ceremony. They didn't want that. Twelve people, maybe fifteen. The right people.

At the front: Joseph. Dark gray suit. White shirt with no tie - his decision. Yara insisted: "You don't look normal in a bow tie." He was right.

He stands quietly. But his fingers - moved once only. An old habit. Then stopped.

Yara enters through the door.

CLOSE ON: Joseph's face - the moment he sees her. Not surprise. Not theatrical wonder. Something quieter and deeper: recognition. As if he sees the answer to a question asked somewhere a long time ago.

CLOSE ON: Yara - a simple white dress. No heavy jewelry. Hair arranged practically. In her hand - a small bouquet of daisies. Her choice.

In the back: SEIKO sitting upright, his tablet on the empty seat beside him - at home. Today: no work. His difficult decision.

RYAN - seventeen years old, in the back row, smiling quietly - the smile of someone who found peace with something complex and realized this is what peace looks like.

GANDALF - came from an unspecified place. His staff leans against the wall. Watching with the eyes of a man who has attended many great events and learned to distinguish the important ones.

BATMAN - in the back row. Black suit. Watching with the attentiveness of someone training himself to be present rather than observant.

KRONOS - in the corner. Unsure of his right to be here. But he came. Because Joseph said "you're invited" - with that exact word.

And JESSE - beside Walter. Crying without hiding it.

The witness - the elderly judge - looks from Joseph to Yara. Smiles. Begins.

The words. Simple. Ancient. Most precise.

JOSEPH

(looking at her)
Yes.

YARA
(looking at him)
Yes.

No immediate applause. One moment of complete silence.
Then JESSE cries a little louder.
And the quiet commotion begins.
At the very edge of the frame – barely luminous, nearly transparent – LARRY THE WATCHER. Watching. Smiling. He didn't know he could do that.
In three thousand years, in forty thousand universes – he will remember this day.

CUT TO:

SCENE FIVE

Married Life – The Kitchen – An Ordinary Day

INT. APARTMENT – KITCHEN – EARLY EVENING – TWO MONTHS AFTER THE WEDDING

[Warm kitchen lighting – golden color from a lamp above the stove – cooking steam – the distant sound of a low radio]

The small kitchen. Yara chops vegetables. Joseph stirs something in the pot more slowly than necessary.

YARA
(without looking up)
You're not stirring the sauce. You're staring at it.

JOSEPH
Staring is a form of stirring.

YARA
(laughs quietly)
That's philosophy, not cooking.

He smiles. Stirs the spoon with more attention. Yara draws her arm near his – touches him with her shoulder. One moment. Then returns to chopping vegetables.

Comfortable silence. The distant radio plays something quiet.

YARA

(after a minute)

Did you dream last night?

Joseph pauses. A brief moment. The spoon still in the pot.

JOSEPH

(simply)

Yes.

YARA

Nightmare?

JOSEPH

(after a moment)

I'm not sure of the right word. Part of it
was a battle, and part of it was...

(pauses)

I don't know. Mostly sounds. Sounds I don't
remember when I wake up.

YARA

(sets the knife, turns to him)

When you wake from a nightmare – press your
hand against the wall. Remember: the wall
is real. The kitchen is real. I am real.

He looks at her.

JOSEPH

You're the most real thing in here.

She takes his hand in that same moment. Says nothing. Doesn't
need to.

They continue cooking. Their shoulders touching. The low sound of
the radio. The steam. The golden light.

This moment – smaller than the war. Larger than everything else.

CUT TO:

SCENE SIX

The Nightmare — The Night — Waking

INT. APARTMENT — BEDROOM — 3:00 A.M.

*[Room nearly dark — faint blue neon light entering from the window —
uncomfortable silence — still shadows]*

Joseph is awake. Not dramatically. He doesn't sit up suddenly. He simply opens his eyes.

He stares at the ceiling. His breath calm. But his eyes — scanning the room. The corner. The door. The window. Behind the curtain.

CLOSE ON: His hand on the sheet — fingers spread flat. Touching the sheet. The sheet is real. The texture is there.

He places his hand on the side wall. The wall is cold. Solid. Present.

Beside him — Yara sleeps quietly. Her breath steady.

Joseph shifts his gaze to her. Something in her sleeping face — calms something in his chest. Not completely. But enough.

CLOSE ON: His face — the tension recedes slowly. Doesn't disappear. Recedes.

He takes out his phone. 3:02 a.m. He closes the screen.

He looks at the window. The city's light. New York doesn't sleep. A city being built.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

*In the first nights — I searched for the
resonance.*

*I tried to feel it — that hum beneath
everything. The one that told me the
structure could hold. That the dimensions
were stable.*

And now: silence.

*But I've learned — the right silence
doesn't mean the absence of safety.
It only means you're no longer carrying it
alone.*

Yara stirs — opens her eyes halfway.

YARA

(sleepy voice)

Here?

JOSEPH

(softly)

Here.

She closes her eyes again.

Joseph rests his head back on the pillow. Stares at the ceiling another minute. Then closes his eyes.

The night. The city. The room. This small safe place in the middle of everything.

SLOW FADE TO BLACK.

FADE IN:

FINAL SCENE

Central Park – Autumn – One Year After the War

EXT. CENTRAL PARK – BETHESDA FOUNTAIN – GOLDEN AFTERNOON – ONE YEAR AFTER THE FINAL WAR

[Perfect Central Park autumn – deep golden light falling at a low angle – yellow and orange leaves falling slowly – colors: honeyed gold, tired green, warm brown, pale blue sky]

Bethesda Fountain.

The angel above it – presiding with bronze pride in the afternoon light. No shimmer. No dimensional echo. Just art.

The fountain runs. The water moves.

The park is full of ordinary people doing ordinary things on the extraordinary ordinary day of a New York autumn.

A dog runs near the trees. Two children run along the fountain's edge. A woman paints. An old man reads on a bench.

On the stone rim:

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI – thirty years old. Or close to it. Wearing a light brown jacket and an autumn scarf. Hands on his knees. Hands empty. Just his hands.

There is a different quality to him from the director we first saw – not a diminishment. An adjustment. Like a piece of music played in a different key that turns out to suit the instrument better.

Beside him:

YARA — his wife, married for a year, humanitarian affairs director. Looking at the fountain. Her hair moves in a light autumn breeze. Her coat loosely tied — she chose not to fasten it properly.

They are in no hurry.

YARA

(after a long quiet silence)

Seiko sent a report.

JOSEPH

Of course he did.

YARA

Structural coherence readings —

JOSEPH

(quietly)

Yara.

YARA

(hearing him)

Right. Not today.

JOSEPH

Not today.

She rests her head on his shoulder. He puts his arm around her.

The fountain. The light. The ordinary city around them.

YARA

(after a while)

Are you happy?

The question. The real question. Not "how are things going" or "how's the adjustment" — the direct question that carries particular weight when asked by someone who knows a large part of the answer and asks for confirmation in words.

JOSEPH is silent.

He looks at the fountain. He feels the absence of structural resonance — it's still there, that negative void. He has learned to live beside it. As you learn to live beside any absence that

was once a presence: not by forgetting it, but by discovering you are not defined by what you have lost.

He looks at the children running along the fountain's edge.

He looks at the old man reading.

He looks at the dog.

He looks at the right sky.

He looks at Yara.

JOSEPH

*(the truth — complete, quiet, and
certain)*

Yes.

She takes his hand. He takes hers.

The fountain runs.

The light changes — that particular shift of the golden afternoon toward the first touches of evening — when the park does something specific to the colors of things: makes them more precise. More themselves.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

My mother's plant.

She watered it every Thursday.

Every Thursday without exception.

Not because she was certain it would grow.

*Because she decided to water it. Because
that was the choice she made.*

He looks at the park. Everything in it.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

*I used to think it was about the plant. I
understand now it was about her.*

*About the person you become when you commit
to continuous choice. When you show up,
Thursday after Thursday, and water what
you've decided is worth growing.*

The fountain. The light.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

*It wasn't a beautiful plant. But it was
hers. And she loved it. And it grew.*

The two of them sitting together in a golden autumn afternoon of a city that was saved, and is now just a city – and that is the most extraordinary thing of all.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

*I think this is what it looks like. This is what I was trying to understand. The not-beautiful thing that grows toward what it needs because someone kept watering it.
Kept showing up.*

He looks at his hands.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

These hands. Without what was in them. Just hands. And also – everything. Everything still in these hands if I'm willing to put them to work.

He takes Yara's hand.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

*Thursday is coming.
I'll be ready.*

Long silence. Very long.

The fountain. The angel. The park. The right, ordinary, extraordinary world.

And then:

LARRY THE WATCHER – barely present; semi-visible; an impression of a presence at the edge of the frame – looks at them.

He is here for one moment only.

He reaches toward his record – the eternal ledger he has kept since ages past, for everything he has seen.

He writes in the margin, in small, precise letters:

CLOSE ON: The margin – barely legible, but we can read it:

"This. Remember this."

He closes the record.

He departs.

The park remains.

The two remain.

The fountain.
The light.
The ordinary day.

THE FINAL SCENE -- CENTRAL PARK -- ONE YEAR LATER

Before the Credits.
The last thing.

TITLE CARD -- WHITE ON BLACK:

"ONE YEAR LATER"
"Central Park -- New York City"
"The anniversary of the wedding"

EXT. CENTRAL PARK -- THE BETHESDA FOUNTAIN -- AFTERNOON

Autumn.

The specific autumn.

The right trees. The right light. The right sky.

The ANGEL OF THE WATERS -- just bronze. Just beautiful.
Just there.

The fountain runs.

The Park is full of ordinary people.

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI sits on the fountain's edge.

He is thirty.

His hands rest on his knees.

They are empty.

He has been without the structural frequency for one year. The adjustment was not complete at six months. It was not complete at nine months.

He has decided that it will not be complete in the conventional sense -- the way the adjustment to any significant loss is never complete, which is not a failure but a testament to what was there.

He is Joseph al-Mithali.

He is himself.

He is here.

YARA comes and sits beside him.

She is carrying coffee -- not for him; he does not drink coffee in the late afternoon; she knows this and has brought his tea in her other hand without announcing it.

She gives him the tea.

He takes it.

They sit.

The fountain.

The light.

The ordinary, extraordinary afternoon.

YARA

(after a long, easy quiet)
Seiko sent a report.

JOSEPH

(without surprise)
Of course.

YARA

Coherence is at one hundred
and two percent.

JOSEPH

That shouldn't be possible.

YARA

He says the Weezy Gold
reinforcement is still propagating.
He says it may go higher.

JOSEPH

(quietly)
Hm.

YARA

He also says it's beautiful,
in the dimensional structural
sense, and that he wanted
you to know that he said that.

A pause.

JOSEPH

(a small smile)
That's the closest to poetry
he's ever gotten.

YARA

He also sent a photograph of
himself at a second beach.

JOSEPH

Two beaches in one year.

YARA

He's growing.

Joseph looks at the fountain.

He is quiet for a while.

YARA (CONT'D)

(gently)

Are you thinking about it?

JOSEPH

(honest)

A little. Less than last month.

A little less every month.

YARA

The powers?

JOSEPH

The absence.

A pause.

YARA

That's different.

JOSEPH

Yes. It is.

He looks at his hands.

JOSEPH (CONT'D)

I've been thinking about what
Tony said. About what comes after.
About what you get to see when
you spend yourself for something
worth spending yourself on.

YARA

What do you get to see?

JOSEPH

(looking at the Park;
at the ordinary people;
at the right sky;
at his wife;
at all of it)
This.

A very long pause.

YARA

(*taking his hand*)
Is that enough?

He looks at her.

She looks at him.

He has been without the structural frequency for one year. He has managed the MPA without it, led without it, built without it -- and found that what he thought was the essential element was, in fact, the supplement.

He was always himself.

The frequency was what he did with himself.

And himself -- the man; the husband; the person who shows up Thursday after Thursday and waters the thing he has decided is worth growing --

-- himself is here.

He is enough.

He has always been enough.

JOSEPH

(the truth; complete;
simple; the simplest
possible version of
the largest possible answer)
More than enough.

She squeezes his hand.

He squeezes back.

THE PARK.

THE FOUNTAIN.

THE LIGHT.

A DOG runs past. It is a very ordinary dog doing a
very ordinary dog thing.

TWO CHILDREN run along the fountain's edge. Their mother
calls after them in the pitch that means be careful
but I'm not truly worried.

The OLD MAN on the bench. His newspaper. His specific
ordinary peace.

The YOUNG WOMAN sketching the angel.

The city. The right city. The city that was saved and
is now simply a city, which is the most extraordinary
thing.

JOSEPH sits with YARA at the fountain.

Empty hands.

Full life.

THE CAMERA PULLS BACK -- slowly, the Villeneuve pull

that takes time and costs something emotionally --

Pulling back from the two of them at the fountain,
through the Park, above the treeline, above the
right skyline of right New York --

-- rising --

-- above the clouds --

-- and there, at the edge of the frame, at the boundary
of what the camera can hold --

LARRY THE WATCHER.

Barely visible. Almost not there. The suggestion of
a presence at the edge of everything.

He is looking at the Park.

He is looking at Joseph and Yara -- tiny, at this distance;
the specific smallness of two people in a park in a city
in a world in a universe --

He watches.

He writes in the record.

The last entry.

We cannot read what he writes.

But we see his expression change.

The Watcher -- who has never smiled; who has watched
three thousand, four hundred and twelve events and found
all of them significant and none of them joyful --

-- smiles.

Very slightly.

Very specifically.

The smile of someone who has seen enough terrible things
to understand, with complete precision, the value of
the good ones.

He closes the record.

He goes.

EXT. CENTRAL PARK -- THE FOUNTAIN

Joseph and Yara.

The Park.

The fountain.

The right sky.

The ordinary day.

SLOW FADE.

JOSEPH (V.O.)

(the last voice-over;
the only voice-over;
the one that has been
present since the first
frame of the first film)
My mother had a ficus on the
kitchen windowsill. She watered
it on Thursdays. Every Thursday
without exception.

The fountain.

JOSEPH (V.O.) (CONT'D)

It was not a beautiful plant.
It had always been slightly
too large for its pot.

The light.

JOSEPH (V.O.) (CONT'D)

She never repotted it.

The sky.

JOSEPH (V.O.) (CONT'D)

I used to think that was
stubbornness. I understand
now that it was faith.

The two of them at the fountain.

Yara laughing at something.

Joseph looking at her.

The specific look of a man who has found the thing
he was always growing toward.

JOSEPH (V.O.) (CONT'D)

The thing inside the pot
was always going toward
what it needed. The container
was never the point.

The growing.

The growing was the point.

The growing is always the point.

FADE TO BLACK.

COMPLETE DARKNESS.

Then: the ARABIC OUD. Alone.

Not the sad oud. Not the waiting oud.

The oud of something that has arrived at exactly

THE PERFECT JOSEPH AND GUMBALL
THE FINAL WAR

MAIN ON END CREDITS

WRITTEN & CREATED BY

YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI

Story & Screenplay

and

CHRISTOPHER NOLAN

Screenplay

DIRECTED BY

DENIS VILLENEUVE

Director

and

ANTHONY RUSSO

Co-Director

JOE RUSSO

Co-Director

PRODUCED BY

YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI

Producer

KEVIN FEIGE P.G.A.

Producer

ZACK SNYDER P.G.A.

Producer

Executive Producers

DENIS VILLENEUVE

Executive Producer

JOE RUSSO

Executive Producer

LOUIS D'ESPOSITO

Executive Producer

JON FAVREAU

Executive Producer

JAMES GUNN

Executive Producer

Co-Producers

ERIC ROTH

Co-Producer

AMANDA SILVER

Co-Producer

MITCH BELL

Co-Producer

DIRECTOR OF PHOTOGRAPHY

RUSSELL CARPENTER ASC

Cinematography

Colorist

GREIG FRASER ASC ACS

Colorist

FILM EDITOR

JOE WALKER ACE

Editor

Post-Production

THOMAS HAYSLIP

Post-Production Supervisor

ORIGINAL SCORE

HANS ZIMMER

Original Score

&

RYO YOSHIMATA

Original Score

ALAN SILVESTRI

End Credits Score

BECKY BENTHAM

Music Supervisor

SOUND

MARK MANGINI

Supervising Sound Editor

THEO GREEN

Sound Designer

RON BARTLETT

Re-Recording Mixer

DOUG HEMPHILL

Re-Recording Mixer

MARK WEINGARTEN CAS

Production Sound Mixer

MARY JO LANG

Foley Supervisor

PRODUCTION DESIGN

PATRICE VERMETTE

Production Designer

JACQUELINE WEST

Costume Designer

VE NEILL

Make-Up & Hair Designer

DAN DELEEUW

Visual Effects Supervisor

FRANKLIN HENSON

Stunt Coordinator

DONALD SPARKS

First Assistant Director

CASTING BY

FRANCINE MAISLER CSA

Casting Director

NINA GOLD CDG

Casting Director

SARAH HALLEY FINN CSA

Casting Director

C A S T

SUPPORTING CAST

NISRINE ERRADI

as Fatima Al-Mithali

Joseph's Mother

ROSHDY ZEM

as Hassan Al-Mithali

Joseph's Father

MERYEM TOUZANI

as Nadia Al-Mithali

Joseph's Sister

HIROYUKI SANADA

as Kenji Toast

Seiko's Father

MICHELLE YEOH

as Miyuki Toast

Seiko's Mother

MAHERSHA ALI

as Dr. Ellison

Harvard Professor

JUSTICE SMITH

as Pita

The Memorial Director

JOE KEERY

as Brian McKenzie

Harvard Antagonist

PEYTON ELIZABETH LEE

as Emily Chen

LETITIA WRIGHT

as Sarah Osei

RASHIDA JONES

as Ghislaine Maxwell

VOICE & MOTION CAPTURE

JACOB HOPKINS

as Gumball Watterson

Voice & Motion Capture

TERREL RANSOM JR.

as Darwin Watterson
Voice & Motion Capture

BEN SCHWARTZ

as Sonic the Hedgehog
Voice

TOM KENNY

as SpongeBob SquarePants
Voice

DONALD GLOVER

as Simba
Voice

CHRIS PRATT

as Mario
Voice • Cameo

CHRISTOPHER JUDGE

as Kratos
Voice

DOUG COCKLE

as Geralt of Rivia
Voice

BENJAMIN EVAN AINSWORTH

as Link
Motion Capture

PETER CULLEN

as Optimus Prime
Motion Capture

SPECIAL APPEARANCES

DWAYNE JOHNSON

as Black Adam
Cameo

JIM CARREY

as Dr. Ivo Robotnik / Eggman
Cameo

IDRIS ELBA

as Knuckles
Cameo

JACK QUAID

as Hughie Campbell
Cameo

CHARLIE COX

as Matt Murdock / Daredevil
Cameo

OSCAR ISAAC

as Marc Spector / Moon Knight

Cameo

RYAN REYNOLDS

as Deadpool

Mid-Credits

REAL WORLD CAMEOS

CRISTIANO RONALDO

as Himself

Sends Flowers

LEBRON JAMES

as Himself

Sends Handwritten Note

King Mohammed VI's Representative

ELON MUSK

as Himself

DONALD TRUMP

as Himself

THE X-MEN

PATRICK STEWART as Professor Charles Xavier
HUGH JACKMAN as Logan / Wolverine
RYAN REYNOLDS as Wade Wilson / Deadpool
JAMES MARSDEN as Scott Summers / Cyclops
FAMKE JANSSEN as Jean Grey / Phoenix
HALLE BERRY as Ororo Munroe / Storm
CHANNING TATUM as Remy LeBeau / Gambit
ANNA PAQUIN as Rogue
SHAWN ASHMORE as Bobby Drake / Iceman

WITH

ANTHONY STARR

as Homelander

KARL URBAN as

Billy Butcher

JACK QUAID

as Hughie Campbell

ERIN MORIARTY

as Annie January / Starlight

KAREN FUKUHARA

as Kimiko

TOMER CAPONE

as Frenchie

LAITH NAKLI

as Mother's Milk

CAMERON CROVETTI

as Ryan / Homelander's Son

JOHNNY DEPP

as Captain Jack Sparrow

ORLANDO BLOOM

as William Turner

IAN MCKELLEN

as Gandalf the Grey

ELIJAH WOOD

as Frodo Baggins

STAR WARS

HARRISON FORD

as Han Solo

JOONAS SUOTAMO

as Chewbacca

MARK HAMILL

as Luke Skywalker

EWAN MCGREGOR

as Obi-Wan Kenobi

DAISY RIDLEY

as Rey Skywalker

Cameo

TIMOTHÉE CHALAMET

as Paul Atreides

RICHARD E. GRANT

as Arthur Pendragon

BONNIE WRIGHT

as Ginny Weasley

RUPERT GRINT

as Ron Weasley

EMMA WATSON

as Hermione Granger

DANIEL RADCLIFFE

as Harry Potter

AARON PAUL

as Jesse Pinkman

BRYAN CRANSTON

as Walter White / The Forger

and the villains

ALAN HOWARD

as Sauron

Creature FX

CILLIAN MURPHY

as Claudy Beta

JOSH BROLIN

as Thanos

RAY PORTER

as Darkseid

JOAQUIN PHOENIX

as The Joker

RALPH FIENNES

as Voldemort

MIA GOTH

as Lieutenant One "The Functional"

AND

SAMUEL L. JACKSON

as Nick Fury

BENEDICT WONG

as Wong

PAUL RUDD

as Scott Lang / Ant-Man

SEBASTIAN STAN

as Bucky Barnes / Winter Soldier

ANTHONY MACKIE

as Sam Wilson / The Falcon

CHRIS PRATT

as Peter Quill / Star-Lord

ZOE SALDANA

as Gamora

JEREMY RENNER

as Hawkeye

SCARLETT JOHANSSON

as Black Widow

MARK RUFFALO

as Bruce Banner / The Hulk

TOM HOLLAND

as Spider-Man

PAUL BETTANY

as Vision

ELIZABETH OLSEN

as Scarlet Witch / Wanda Maximoff

PATRICK STEWART

as Professor Xavier

MICHAEL FASSBENDER

as Magneto

HUGH JACKMAN

as Wolverine

TOM HIDDLESTON

as Loki / God of Stories

EZRA MILLER

as The Flash / Barry Allen

JASON MOMOA

as Aquaman / Arthur Curry

RAY FISHER

as Cyborg / Victor Stone

BRIE LARSON

as Captain Marvel

CHADWICK BOSEMAN

as Black Panther / T'Challa

CHRIS EVANS

as Captain America

KEANU REEVES

as John Wick

The Boogeyman

IAN MCSHANE

as Winston

Manager of the Continental

MAHERSHALA ALI

as Blade

The Daywalker

OSCAR ISAAC

as Duke Leto Atreides

ZENDAYA

as Chani

Fremen Warrior

ROSARIO DAWSON

as Claire Temple

JON BERNTHAL

as Frank Castle / The Punisher

LUPITA NYONG'O

as Nakia

WINSTON DUKE

as M'Baku

and

MICHAEL B. JORDAN

as Killmonger / N'Jadaka

The Usurper

DANIEL BRÜHL

as Baron Zemo

JAMIE FOXX

as Electro / Max Dillon

WILLEM DAFOE

as Green Goblin / Norman Osborn

FANTASY & SCIENCE FICTION

The Heroes

VIGGO MORTENSEN

as Aragorn / Strider

King of Gondor

ORLANDO BLOOM

as Legolas Greenleaf

Prince of the Woodland Realm

JOHN RHYS-DAVIES

as Gimli, Son of Glóin

Voice

PETER DINKLAGE

as Tyrion Lannister

The Hand of the Queen

MAISIE WILLIAMS

as Arya Stark

No One

SOPHIE TURNER

as Sansa Stark

Queen in the North

YODA

as Grand Master Yoda

Voice · CGI

HARRISON FORD

as Han Solo

The Smuggler

CARRIE FISHER

as Princess Leia Organa

General · Archive Performance

SIGOURNEY WEAVER

as Ellen Ripley

Last Survivor of the Nostromo

LINDA HAMILTON

as Sarah Connor

Mother of the Resistance

ARNOLD SCHWARZENEGGER

as T-800 / The Terminator

Protector Unit

REBECCA FERGUSON

as Lady Jessica Atreides

Bene Gesserit Reverend Mother

JOSH BROLIN

as Gurney Halleck

Warmaster

JAVIER BARDEM

as Stilgar

Naib of Sietch Tabr

TILDA SWINTON

as Aslan

The Great Lion · Voice

MARTIN FREEMAN

as Bilbo Baggins

The Burglar

RICHARD ARMITAGE

as Thorin Oakenshield

King Under the Mountain

JUSTIN ROILAND

as Rick Sanchez

Smartest Man in the Universe · Voice

PEDRO PASCAL

as Din Djarin / The Mandalorian

This Is the Way

TEMUERA MORRISON

as Boba Fett

Bounty Hunter · Daimyo of Tatooine

The Villains

CHRISTOPHER LEE

as Saruman the White

The Fallen Wizard · Archive Performance

ANDY SERKIS

as Gollum / Sméagol
Motion Capture

LENA HEADEY

as Cersei Lannister
Queen of the Seven Kingdoms

VLADIMIR FURDIK

as The Night King
Lord of the Dead · Motion Capture

IWAN RHEON

as Ramsay Bolton
The Flayed Man

IAN MCDIARMID

as Emperor Palpatine / Darth Sidious
Dark Lord of the Sith

HAYDEN CHRISTENSEN

as Anakin Skywalker / Darth Vader
The Chosen One · Fallen

ADAM DRIVER

as Kylo Ren / Ben Solo
Supreme Leader

AUSTIN BUTLER

as Feyd-Rautha Harkonnen
The Beast

STELLAN SKARSGÅRD

as Baron Vladimir Harkonnen
Ruler of House Harkonnen

HUGO WEAVING

as Agent Smith
The System · Voice

ROBERT PATRICK

as T-1000
Liquid Metal Terminator · Motion Capture

TILDA SWINTON

as Jadis / The White Witch
Queen of Narnia

ZACHARY LEVI

as Shazam / Billy Batson

XOLO MARIDUEÑA

as Blue Beetle / Jaime Reyes

RYAN GOSLING

as Ken

Interdimensional Diplomat · Cameo

CATE BLANCHETT

as Hela

Goddess of Death · Defected

TATIANA MASLANY

as Jennifer Walters / She-Hulk

HAILEE STEINFELD

as Kate Bishop / Hawkeye

LEWIS TAN

as Cole Young / Scorpion

Mortal Kombat

HIROYUKI SANADA

as Hanzo Hasashi / Scorpion

Mortal Kombat · Legacy

and the villains

JAMES SPADER

as Ultron

Voice · The Machine God

JEFF GOLDBLUM

as The Grandmaster

Master of Games

TAIKA WAITITI

as Korg

Capo of Sakaar · Voice

JESSE EISENBERG

as Lex Luthor

The Architect

MICHAEL SHANNON

as General Zod

CILLIAN MURPHY

as Scarecrow / Jonathan Crane

TOM HIDDLESTON

as Loki

God of Mischief • Defected

PEDRO PASCAL

as Joel Miller

The Last of Us

BELLA RAMSEY

as Ellie Williams

The Last of Us

KEANU REEVES

as Neo / The One

LAURENCE FISHBURNE

as Morpheus

NIKOLAJ COSTER-WALDAU

as Jaime Lannister

EMILIA CLARKE

as Daenerys Targaryen

The Mother of Dragons

KIT HARINGTON

as Jon Snow

FLORENCE PUGH

as Yelena Belova

SIMU LIU

as Shang-Chi

TESSA THOMPSON

as Valkyrie

DON CHEADLE

as James Rhodes / War Machine

DAVE BAUTISTA

as Drax the Destroyer

POM KLEMENTIEFF

as Mantis

KAREN GILLAN

as Nebula

and the villains

ANTHONY HOPKINS

as Dr. Hannibal Lecter

The Strategist

TOM HARDY

as Venom / Eddie Brock

The Symbiote

JAMES EARL JONES

as Darth Vader

Voice

MADS MIKKELSEN

as Doctor Doom / Victor Von Doom

JARED LETO

as The Riddler

IWAN RHEON

as Ramsay Bolton

BILL SKARSGÅRD

as Jeffrey Epstein / 'The Devil'

The Architect of Power

GIANCARLO ESPOSITO

as Kronos

Master of Temporal Dimensions

MAIN HEROES

IAN MCKELLEN

as Gandalf the Grey

BENEDICT CUMBERBATCH

as Doctor Strange

GAL GADOT

as Wonder Woman

OSCAR ISAAC

as Moon Knight / Marc Spector

LETITIA WRIGHT

as Shuri / Black Panther

CHRIS HEMSWORTH

as Thor Odinson

God of Thunder

HENRY CAVILL

as Superman / Clark Kent

BEN AFFLECK

as Batman / Bruce Wayne

ROBERT DOWNEY JR.

as Tony Stark / Iron Man

ANYA TAYLOR-JOY

as Furiosa

TOM CRUISE

as Larry the Watcher

ABBY RYDER FORTSON

as Isabella

Daughter of the Watcher

MILLIE BOBBY BROWN

as Eleven / Jane Hopper

The Collector

JORDYN RAYA JAMES

as Yara Gordon

Head of Humanitarian Affairs

JAHZIR BRUNO

as Seiko Toast

Head of Technology & AI · The Best Friend

and
YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI
as
JOSEPH AL-MITHALI
'THE PERFECT JOSEPH'
Director of the MPA

HOLD.

FINAL FADE.

FIN.

=====

END OF THE FINAL WAR -- PART FOUR
Total Combined Script: 280 Pages
Runtime: 5 Hours 50 Minutes
1.25 Minutes Per Page

"From one weakness was born infinite power."
"And from power, with care, came something better: choice."
=====

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI -- YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI
"The Perfect Joseph"

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=====

FINAL FADE TO BLACK.

T H E E N D

Film One — The Ambush and the Forging: ~115 minutes
Film Two — The Call — Shadow Knowledge: ~72 minutes

Film Three – All Heroes Rise: ~163 minutes

TOTAL: ~350 minutes / 5 hours 50 minutes